

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book Two: The Resistance

Post Peleos

Copyright © 2026 Post Peleos

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author, except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

ISBN 979-8-2409-9382-4

First Edition

Post Peleos

*For MNB —
may your life be long and happy.*

CHAPTER ONE

The Box of Invisible Air

For three mornings she had woken already braced — for smoke, for the bell, for the particular weight of a building deciding to come down on the people inside it. For three mornings there had been only the quiet of a place that had not yet been frightened. The bracing did not believe the quiet. It met her at the surface of every waking and held her there a moment, hunting a fire that was not there, before it let her remember where she was: a hidden camp on the far side of a burned corridor and a dark wood, the rescued children of Hazel asleep in borrowed beds nearby, and the school she kept waking to drag them out of already gone to smoke without her.

On the fourth morning the camp put her to work, which was the kindest thing it could have done.

It was Brutus who did it, the broad sunburned man from the council, who found her standing at the edge of the lanes with nothing in her hands and the look on her face of a person who has run out of things to be useful for. He did not ask her how she was, which she was grateful for, because she had heard the question a dozen times since the burning school and had not yet found a true answer that did not cost more than it was worth to give. He simply looked her up and down, the way he looked at a length of timber, and grunted, and said, "You. You've got two arms. Come hold this."

The this was a wall. A low one, the back of a storehouse that had sagged in the spring rains and that he was setting to rights board by board, and he wanted her to hold each board flush while he drove the nails, and for an hour she did. It was the first hour since the gates of Hazel that her mind had been given nothing to do but the work in front of it. He was not a talker. He worked, and she held, and the morning passed in the sound of the hammer and the smell of cut wood and old rain, and when he had finished he stood back and looked at the wall as though it had personally tried something and failed, and nodded once, and said, "There. That'll see another winter." Standing beside him, Viridia understood that the wall was not really about the wall. He had built this place with his hands, the houses and the lines and the anchor-posts of the great wards, and a man who builds a thing with his hands does not measure it in boards. He measured it in winters. He was counting how many were left.

She kept that. She always kept the small true things, somewhere they would not be lost.

The camp in daylight was a real place. It still surprised her each morning. She had arrived in the dark expecting a desperate huddle, the way the burned and the hunted were supposed to live, and had found instead a village, hidden under a sky that was not quite a sky. The wards did something to the light. Stand at the center of the camp and you would never know; the sun came down honest and warm and the washing dried on the lines. But walk to the edge, where Brutus's anchor-posts stood in their ring, and the air there shivered faintly, the way heat shivers off a road, and beyond it the forest looked subtly wrong, too still, a painting of a forest rather than the thing itself, because what you were seeing was not the forest. It was the inside of the ward looking out. A whole village, lanes and bonfires and

children, folded into a box of invisible air, and the box held because three men spent themselves holding it.

She came to know the camp by its details, the ones that did not fit. The blacksmith's shed with its fire already going at dawn. The long table in the open where the woman called Mirelle taught the smallest children their letters, and the letters were not the ones Hazel had taught; they were older, rounder, and among them, set down for six-year-olds as a matter of course, the Moravian characters the light schools swore had been dead a thousand years. The lanes where the rescued Hazel girls were slowly being folded into games whose rules Viridia could not follow and did not try to. The bonfire ring in the center, cold by day, where the camp gathered at night.

And running under all of it, under the washing and the games and the smell of bread, a thing she could feel the way you feel a clock in a quiet house: the count. A week, Jazen had said. By this time next week I mean to be on the road to the capital. Four days of it were already gone.

* * *

After the wall she went to find Mirelle at the long table, because the children had spilled out for the morning and Mirelle had a baby on her hip and a slate in her free hand and the particular harried calm of a woman doing three things at once and a fourth in reserve.

"You're the one Jazen brought in," Mirelle said, not unkindly, shifting the baby. He was perhaps a year old, fat-cheeked, gnawing on his own fist with great seriousness. "The girl with the children. You don't have to hover. Sit, if you're going to stay. You make the little ones nervous, standing like that. They think you're a teacher come to test them."

Viridia sat. It was easier to do as she was told here, she was finding, than to invent reasons not to.

"Do you read the old script?" Mirelle asked. She had set the baby down in the grass at her feet, where he immediately began the long work of trying to eat a leaf, and she watched him with one corner of her attention and Viridia with the rest. "Most of them that come to us don't. Their light schools beat it out of them before they ever knew they had it. I have to start the older ones from nothing."

"I read it," Viridia said.

Mirelle's eyebrows went up. "Do you. Where'd a girl your age learn that?"

"My mother taught me."

It was true, and it was also the most she had said about her mother to anyone since the motorcar, and she felt the sentence go out of her and was glad when Mirelle did not chase it. Instead the woman handed her a slate, a child's slate, smeared and scratched, and a stub of chalk, and nodded at it.

"Then make yourself useful. Write me something true on it. The little ones learn faster from each other than from me, and you're nearer their size than I am." She said it dryly, and there was a thing under the dryness, a quick measuring look, and Viridia understood that she was being offered a place to stand, the way Brutus had offered her the wall.

She thought for a moment, the chalk in her hand. Then she wrote, in the old rounded characters, the only true thing small enough for a slate: a child's word, the word for safe. She turned it round and showed it.

Mirelle looked at it for a long moment, and her face did a complicated thing, and she took the baby back up off the grass before he could finish the leaf. "That's a good word to start them on," she said, and her voice had gone careful in the way Viridia's own went careful, and neither of them said

anything else about it. But the next morning there was a slate left out for Viridia at the end of the table, and after that she had a thing to do with her hands and her old buried language both, an hour each morning teaching dark-mage children to write the word for safe in a box of air that might not be safe by the end of the week.

She did not let herself think about that last part where the children could see her thinking it.

* * *

The thing she was finding hardest was the banking.

At Hazel her core had grown from a hearth to a furnace, the night of the well, and she had crossed the school's last corridor lit up like a kiln, throwing more light through her mana sight than she had known a person could hold. Here she could not afford to. The camp hid; the camp's whole life was the not-being-seen; and a girl with a furnace in her chest, to anyone with the sight, would stand out against the wards like a lamp held up to a thin curtain. So she banked it. She had learned the trick the first night, half by instinct, half by the memory of how Lor-ar held his own vast self compressed down into a house-cat. You did not put the fire out. You drew it in, packed it down small and steady, a flicker where the furnace had been, a banked coal you could feel even when no one could see it.

It was tiring in a way that working the wall was not. By midday her chest ached with the holding, the way an arm aches that has carried a weight a long way without setting it down. She mentioned it to no one. She had banked harder things than her own light, and for longer.

What she could not bank, because it was not hers to bank, was the bond.

Raizen was out there. Somewhere past the edge of the wards, past the painted forest, across a stretch of miles he

could not measure and she could not name, the prismatic dragon she was tied to was alive and coming, and the True-Bond between them ran taut over all that distance like a line stretched to its limit, humming. She had not known, before, that it could ache. At Hazel he had been near enough that the bond was only a presence, a warmth at the back of her mind, a thing she could turn toward the way you turn toward a window to know it is daylight. Now he was far. The warmth had thinned to a thread, and the thread pulled, low and constant, somewhere under the breastbone, beside the dark-blue stone and the small spear of the Dangris. It was not pain. It was the opposite of pain. It was the place where pain would be if he were gone, kept warm and open and waiting, and she carried it through the days of holding boards and chalk and her own banked light, and it was, she thought, the only honest thing in her chest that she did not have to hold down.

Lor-ar said little about it. He was much in the camp those first days, the size of a large dog now, drawing stares from the rescued girls and a wary respect from the village dogs, and he sat with her in the evenings by the cold bonfire ring and watched the camp with his ancient amusement and rationed his counsel the way he rationed the name he sometimes called her.

"You are managing it well," he said one evening, meaning the bond, meaning all of it, the banking and the count and the children. "Better than I expected of a creature your age. You do not ask it to be other than it is. That is most of the trick of carrying a thing."

"How far?" she asked. She had not meant to. It came out of her flatly, the way the hard things came out.

"Closer than yesterday." He yawned, showing the saber teeth that did not belong on a house-dog's face. "He cannot hurry the way you would wish. He is large, little one, and the

world between here and there is full of eyes, and he has learned, as you have, that the safest road is not the straightest. He will come when it is safe to come. He has the rest of both your lives to make the trip, and so do you. Try to remember that. You hold every hour as though it were the last one you will be given." He turned the lightning-blue eyes on her, kind and merciless at once. "It makes you very strong. It will also, one day, make you very tired. I only mention it."

She did not have an answer to that, so she gave him none, and they sat together while the lanes went quiet around them, and she filed *the rest of both your lives* somewhere she could find it again, and did not believe it, quite, but kept it anyway.

Amber came and sat with them sometimes in those evenings, when the cold left her bones enough to move. She was climbing back; Viridia could see it the way she saw everything, by the detail that was returning before the rest of her did. The first night in the camp Amber had been hollowed out, the drain of the woods written into her face, and she had sat by the fire and not reached for a single joke, which from Amber was the loudest alarm a person could give. Now, days on, the armor was coming back over the damage a piece at a time. She had found black again somewhere for her chipped nails. She had begun to lounge instead of merely sit, propping herself against whatever was nearest with the studied carelessness that was her oldest trick, and she had started, that evening, to tick things off on her fingers.

"Things I have learned about a resistance camp," she said, to the fire, to Lor-ar, to anyone. "One. There is always a baby crying in the next house, no matter which house you are in. I have begun to suspect it is the same baby and they move it to torment me. Two. Everyone here can mend a roof

and no one can make a decent cup of tea, which tells you everything about their priorities. Three." She held the third finger up and looked at it and seemed to lose interest. "There is no three. I had a three. It drowned." She let the hand fall. "Don't tell me I look better. People keep telling me I look better. It's an insult dressed as a kindness; it means they remember exactly how bad I looked."

"You look better," Viridia said.

Amber turned her head and looked at her, and almost smiled, the real one, the one that came up from under the armor and not over it. "There she is," she said. "The girl who never says the safe thing. I missed you. Don't tell anyone I said it; it'll ruin my reputation." She looked back at the fire. After a while, quieter, the lounging gone out of her: "He's going to march us, isn't he. Jazen. Soon."

"Yes," Viridia said.

"I thought so." Amber drew her knees up. "I'm not even afraid of it, which is the part that frightens me. I should be afraid of it. I think I used up all my afraid in the woods and they didn't restock me." She pulled the blanket one of the village women had given her tighter round her shoulders. "When it comes, whatever you're planning, and don't bother telling me you're not planning something, I've watched you plan things, you get the face. When it comes, I'm in. Whatever it is. I just want it on the record that I knew it would cost more than you'll let on, because you always say it'll cost less than it does, and I always believe you, because believing you is easier than the alternative." She closed her eyes. "That's my three. There it is. It surfaced."

Viridia did not answer that, because there was no answer to it that would not be either a lie or a promise she could not keep, and Amber did not seem to need one. They sat, the three of them, the girl and the tiger and the girl who deflected sincerity with a joke and meant every word of it,

and watched the camp go dark house by house, and the warm thread under Viridia's breastbone pulled toward a dragon on a far road. A friend had just put on the record, in the only way she knew how, that she would die beside her if it came to that, and Viridia, who had spent her whole short stretch at Hazel working to be a person no one looked at twice, found she could not make the old wish to be unseen answer when she reached for it. It had gone quiet in her. What had replaced it she could not yet name.

* * *

On the fifth day she sat the council.

She had not meant to. She had gone to the town hall to find Jazen, because she had questions about the supply lines she did not want to ask in the open. Coming in at the end of an argument, she made herself small against the back wall the way she always did, and no one told her to leave, so she stayed and listened. It was a thing she understood by then: that the things people most needed her to know were the things they said when they had forgotten she was there.

The council was four, and she knew them all now by their details. Coram, the old man with the gray beard, who had let her in that first morning and who spoke last and softest and changed the room when he did. The woman in the pale blue dress, Mella, who clicked the clasp of a small worn locket at her throat when she was afraid and did not know she did it, and who had two grandchildren in the camp and measured every word about supply lines against their two small faces. Brutus, who folded his big arms and said *strategy* when he meant *I built this and I cannot watch it burn*. And the stately woman with the silver hair pulled into a hard bun, whose eyes were the cold gray of her hair, and who frightened Viridia more than the rest of them together, because she was not afraid at all. She sat very straight and did the arithmetic

of how many would die on the road, and was prepared to spend them. Viridia trusted her least and understood her best, because the cold counting in her was a thing she knew from the inside.

A third ward-mage sat with them now, a man named Hiram, and it was Hiram that Viridia watched most, because Hiram was the one whose detail did not fit.

He was gray. Not old-gray; the wrong gray, the gray of a man who has been pouring something out of himself faster than it refills. He sat a little apart, against the wall near the door, and he did not say much, and twice while she watched, his hand drifted up to press flat against the wood at his back, the great anchor-post that ran up through the hall, as though he were steadying himself against it, or feeding it, or both. He held a third of the camp's invisibility in his body. Jazen held a third, and a man called Abe held the last, and the three of them between them kept the box of air closed over the village, and they had been doing it for two years, and one of them was the wrong color.

She thought: when he goes, the wall goes thin.

She did not know yet what the thought was for. She only knew it was true, and set it beside the count and the wall, and went on watching.

"—every patrol that comes within a mile of us now is a patrol that came near because they have stopped being warned away," Jazen was saying. He looked worse than he had four days ago. The grief he let show, he had told her once, was the curse of his family, and it showed; his eyes were raw, his close-cropped hair gone untended, his dark blue shirt unchanged in days. But under the grief was the thing that had decided the room at the gates, the flat hard certainty. "When my mother lived, we knew where they would be before they knew themselves. We moved supplies through the gaps she found us. We knew which roads were

watched. All of that died in the corridor with her. We are not hidden anymore. We are merely not yet found. There is a difference, and it is measured in days."

"You keep saying days." It was Mella, the woman in blue, and her hand was at the locket. "You said a week. Now it's days. Tell us the number, Jazen. If you mean to march my grandchildren toward the capital, tell me the number, and stop dressing it up."

"I can't tell you the number," Jazen said, "because I don't have it. That's the point. I had a clock once. Her name was Lightwell, and she's dead, and now we none of us have a clock, we only have the certainty that one is running. I would rather march while we choose the day than wait until the day is chosen for us by a column of soldiers at the wards." He set his hands flat on the table. "I have given this place two years. I am not throwing it away. I am refusing to die in it. There is a difference there too."

The silver-bun woman spoke for the first time, in a voice like cold arithmetic. "The number is roughly forty who can fight," she said, "and roughly two hundred who cannot, of whom perhaps sixty are children. Those are the numbers. Any plan that does not begin from those numbers is a wish, not a plan." She looked at Jazen without heat. "I am not against the road. I am against pretending the road is anything but a way of choosing which of the two hundred we are prepared to lose. Decide that you are prepared to lose some of them. Then we can talk about the day."

The room went quiet. Hiram's hand pressed flat against the post. Mella's clasp clicked, once, and stopped.

It was Coram who broke it, soft as ever. "She's right, you know," he said, to Jazen, and to all of them. "It's an ugly thing to say plain. But she's right, and we'd be cowards to make her be the only one who'll say it. The question was never whether we'd lose people. We've been losing them by

ones and twos for two years, in the dark, where it costs us nothing to pretend it isn't a war. The only question Jazen's asking is whether we'd rather lose them by ones and twos forever, or lose more of them at once and have it mean something." He folded his gnarled hands. "I'm too old to want the answer. I'm also too old to lie about what it is."

Viridia, against the wall, listened, and understood that they were all of them right, and that this was the worst kind of disagreement there was, the kind where everyone is right and there is not enough world to keep what everyone loves. At Hazel she had thought war would have villains in it. It mostly did not. It had frightened people who loved different things, sitting at a long table, doing arithmetic none of them wanted to be the one to say aloud.

And under it, quiet and steady and growing, she felt the thing she had been refusing to let herself feel since the well. The thought with no place to go. *I could end all of this. Not the war between these forty and that column. All of it. The thing under the war. The cut that made the dark and the light into two armies in the first place. I know how. I am the only one alive who knows how.*

She put it away. She put it away the way she banked her core: drew it in, packed it down small, a coal where the fire wanted to be. It was not a thought you could let burn where anyone could see the light of it. And she did not yet know, herself, whether it was a salvation or the worst thing a person could choose to do, and a thought like that you do not let out until you are sure.

Only her breath changed. No one in the room was watching the girl at the back closely enough to see even that.

* * *

Jazen found her after, as the council broke up, and walked her out into the lanes where the evening was coming on, and

he did not perform anything for her, which she had come to value in him more than kindness.

"You sat the whole thing," he said. "You didn't have to. It isn't pretty, watching people decide who to lose."

"No," she agreed. "But I'd rather see it decided than have it kept from me."

He almost smiled. "My mother would have liked you. She'd have hated how much she liked you, but she'd have liked you." He stopped walking, at the place where the lane ran out toward the edge and the air began to shiver. "You asked me, that first morning, to put the word out about your friend. The healer girl."

Her whole body went still. She did not let it show. She kept the careful face, the one that had carried her through the gates and the corridor and the woods, and only her hands, at her sides, curled, and she made them uncurl.

"I haven't forgotten," Jazen said. "I want you to know I haven't. The lines are slower now, without my mother to run them, but they still run, and I put the word out the same hour you asked me, on every one. Alice Pembroke. First-year. Healer's hands. A girl who got out of Hazel, or didn't." He watched her, gently, the way you watch a thing you are not sure is sound enough to bear weight. "I won't tell you anything is coming. I told you I'd bring you true news and not false hope, and the truest news I have today is still that I have none. But the lines are out, and the first of them is due back tomorrow or the day after. Sometimes they bring people. Survivors, off the roads, walking out of places that burned. Sometimes they bring nothing but rumor, and rumor is a liar more often than not." He paused. "I wanted you to hear it from me before you heard it from the camp. There's a line coming in. If it brings anything about Hazel, I'll bring it to you myself. Whatever it is."

"Thank you," Viridia said. The word came out flat and steady and cost her everything to make so, and Jazen, who had a sister he had not saved either, heard the cost in the flatness and did not reach for her, which she would have hated.

"Tomorrow, then. Or the day after." He looked out past the shivering air, toward the painted forest where somewhere a dragon was coming and a column of soldiers might be too. "It's a small camp. Word will reach you the moment it reaches the gate. I only wanted you to have a night's warning that there might be word." He turned to go, and stopped, and added, not as comfort but as fact, "She might be out there. Walking a road. Stranger things have come in on those lines than a living girl. I've stopped letting myself rule it out. You might try the same. Or you might not. You know your own heart better than I do."

He went back into the camp to do the work of the war, and Viridia stayed at the edge alone, where the wards shivered and the false forest stood too still, and she let herself, for one breath in the failing light with no one watching, feel both of the things at once. The hope came up in her like water rising in a well she had ordered shut. The dread came up beside it, because alive on a road and alive in the capital's hands were not the same kind of alive, and rumor was a liar, and tomorrow the line would come in and the not-knowing she had carried out of Hazel would either end or grow a new and crueler shape.

She did not let either of them onto her face. The edge of the camp was empty around her. She kept the practice anyway, because the practice was the only thing she trusted not to leave.

Out past the wards the thread to Raizen pulled, low and warm and closer than yesterday. Under her breastbone the dark-blue stone lay cool against the small spear. Behind her

the camp put itself to bed. The lanes went quiet, the bonfire ring stayed cold, the children safe for one more night under the wards that did not feel, tonight, like enough. And somewhere on a dark road, walking toward the gate by tomorrow or the morning after, was the answer to the only question she had carried whole out of the fire.

Viridia stood at the edge of the camp and faced the false forest and waited for the morning, and did not let herself decide, yet, which answer she was bracing to receive.

She only knew that the line was coming in.

CHAPTER TWO

The Thread Pulled Taut

The thread went slack a little after dawn, and Viridia knew before she was properly awake that he was close.

For days it had pulled, low and constant under her breastbone, the ache of a line drawn out to its limit. Now the line was loosening, hour by hour, the way a rope eases when the thing at its end stops straining away and starts coming home. She lay in the dark of the small house they had given her, eyes open, and felt the warmth at the back of her mind grow from a thread to a presence to a thing with edges. She did not move. Moving would have been admitting how much she had been waiting, and she had not admitted that even to herself.

He was perhaps a mile out when she finally rose. She did not have to be told. She could have walked to him blind, in a strange country, with her eyes put out; the bond knew the direction the way her own hand knew the way to her own face. She dressed without lighting a lamp. She did not bank her core that morning. She let it sit where it wanted to sit, a banked coal coming up toward a flame, because there was a thing coming over the edge of the wards that would stand out brighter than any furnace she could ever hold, and there was no point pretending the camp would not see it.

She went out into the grey lanes, past Brutus's mended wall, past the long table where the slates were stacked for

the morning that had not started yet, and at the rim of the camp, where the air shivered and the painted trees held that wrong stillness, she stopped and waited. The observer in her, the part that catalogued, noted that her hands were perfectly steady, and that this was the first morning since the gates of Hazel that they had needed no managing at all.

Then the shiver in the air parted, the way water parts, and he came through.

He came low and slow over the painted trees, and the painted trees were suddenly not large enough to be a measure of anything. She had forgotten. In the weeks at Hazel he had been hidden, small, a secret folded into a satchel and a stairwell, and her mind had quietly shrunk him to fit the places she had kept him. Here, over open ground, with the dawn behind him, he was the size of the thing he was. The light came off him in colours that did not stay still. Not one scale's worth of one colour, the way Drake was black and Varissa scarlet, but all of them, sliding, so that he was green where the forest touched him and grey where the sky did and gold where the first true sun struck along his spine, a creature scaled in every element there was and committed to none, and the mana sight she could never turn off showed her the same thing turned inside out: a core like hers, whole, undivided, holding both halves of the severed gift the way almost nothing alive still did.

He landed in the open ground inside the wards, and the impact of him went up through the soles of her feet, and he folded the great prismatic wings, and he lowered the long head down the last of the distance until it hung level with her, close enough that his breath moved her hair, and for a moment neither of them did anything at all.

She put her hand flat against the side of his jaw. The scales there were warm, warmer than a living thing should be, and they changed colour under her palm, settling toward

the silver-blonde of her own hair, and she understood that this was not chance, that he had done it, that he was matching himself to her the way a person turns toward the one they have come a long way to see. The bond, slack now, lay easy between them, a warmth with no pull in it, and into the easy warmth came a contentment so total and so wordless that she felt her own throat close around it, and the body that had managed itself through the corridor and the woods and five days of council pressed, for one breath, toward release.

She pressed back. She always pressed back. But it was close, that morning, closer than it had been in a long while, and she stood with her hand on the jaw of the only creature in the world tied to her for both their lives and let the closeness be its own small triumph, won and unnamed.

"You came," she said. It was not a clever thing to say. It was true, and small enough to fit in her mouth.

And the dragon, who at Hazel had spoken only in the wordless country of the bond, opened the great mouth, and spoke.

"You," he said, "are *smaller* than I remember."

The voice was not a voice the way a person's is. It came up out of him from somewhere below sound, and it arrived in her ears and in her chest and along the thread all at once, layered, more than one note, the way he was more than one colour. But the words were words. He had not had them, before. He had them now.

She looked at him. "You can talk."

"I learned," Raizen said, with enormous satisfaction, "on the road. There was a great deal of road." He pulled the head back a little and regarded her down the length of his nose, an angle of inspection she recognised from precisely no one and from a hundred adults at once. "Drake says I have done it badly and too soon and that I should have waited for the

proper time, whenever that was meant to be. Drake is six thousand years old and believes that things should take six thousand years. I disagree. I wished to speak to you and so I learned to speak. That is the whole of it." The prismatic head tilted. "Why is your face doing nothing? You are pleased. I can feel that you are pleased. You feel like a struck bell. Make the face that goes with it."

"I don't have that face," Viridia said.

"Then I shall make it for both of us," said the dragon, and showed her every tooth he had, which was a great many, and was somehow, unmistakably, a grin.

* * *

Three miles out, on the east road, a scout was coming in, and she was bringing the war with her.

Her name was Ferro, and she had been four days on the roads east of Hazel, and she came in on foot because the horse had gone lame on the second day and she had cut it loose rather than be slowed, and that decision sat in her like a swallowed stone, because the horse had been a good horse and she had liked it, and you were not supposed to like the animals. She came up the last of the track with her boots gone soft and her eyes gone hard, and she was thinking, against her will, about the way the soldiers had stacked things in the courtyard of the burned school. Not bodies. She had braced for bodies. It was the other thing that had got into her and would not get out, the careful, clerical, unhurried way they had been sorting the living from the dead and the useful from the rest, the way you would sort apples, with a man at a table writing it all down.

She gave the day's word at the wards and Hiram let her through, grey Hiram with his hand on the post, and she did not stop to talk to him because she could see he had nothing left over to spend on talk. She climbed the rutted track to the

town hall with the swallowed-stone feeling getting heavier and the thing she had to report arranging itself in her mouth. On the way she passed a sight she did not have the spare attention to be amazed by: a girl with silver-blond hair standing in the open with her hand on the face of a dragon that wore every colour at once, the two of them lit up like the inside of a church window. Ferro thought, with the flat exhaustion of someone who has stopped being surprised by the world, *well, there's that, then*, and kept walking, because the dragon was not her business and the report was.

She found Jazen in the hall, and she told him.

* * *

The grin did not last, because grins did not, in that place, in that week.

Raizen felt it change in her before she said anything. That was the thing about the bond that Viridia was still learning to live with: it did not lie, and it did not let her lie, not to him. She felt his contentment falter as her own attention pulled, half of it, toward the lane where a figure was going up toward the hall at the particular tired hard walk of someone carrying news that could not wait.

"Something is wrong," Raizen said. Not a question. The new words made it worse, somehow. The bond had always known. Now it could say so.

"Someone's come in," Viridia said. "From the roads."

She watched the scout go up the lane and into the hall, and she stood with her hand still on the warm jaw and felt the morning divide itself cleanly down the middle, the way she had always divided things, the way her mother had taught her without meaning to. On the one side of the line was the dragon, returned, alive, speaking, the bond gone slack and easy for the first time in days. On the other side

was a tired woman in soft boots carrying something up to the council, and Viridia did not yet know what it was, and already she could feel the shape of it coming, the way a foot finds the lip of a stair in the dark before the mind has named it.

"You have gone somewhere," Raizen observed. "Inside. You do it constantly. You go behind a door and shut it and stand on the other side of yourself and watch. I felt you do it the moment that woman walked past. Where do you go?"

"Where it's quiet," Viridia said.

"Is it quiet there?"

She thought about that, honestly, because he had asked it honestly. "No," she said. "But it's mine."

The prismatic eye, very near hers, held on her for a moment, and the colours in it slowed, and she had the sense, new and disconcerting, of being seen by something that had wanted words specifically so that it could ask her things she did not want asked. Then he let it go, because he had decided to, and the great head came down again and rested, for a moment, against her shoulder, the whole weight of it held back to a feather's worth so as not to crush her, and the contentment came back into the bond, dimmer now, banked the way she banked her own fire.

"Then go where it's quiet," Raizen said, "and I will be here when you come out. That is what I came across the world to do. Be the thing that is here." He settled the wings. "Go and find out what the tired woman knows. I can smell it on her even from here. She has been somewhere that things were burning, and she has the smell of the place where the people who burn the school keep the people they do not burn."

Viridia went very still.

"You can smell that," she said.

"I am a dragon," said Raizen, as though this answered everything, and in a way it did.

* * *

Drake was the last thing through the wards, and he came in his own time, which was slow, because grief moved slowly and Drake was made mostly of grief he called by other names.

He came down out of the high air long after Raizen had landed, a length of pitch black against the brightening sky, and he did not hurry the descent, and when he settled at last just inside the wards the grass under him went white with frost where the black flames guttered along his jaw and the children who had crept out to look at the prismatic dragon took one look at the death-black one and remembered urgent business elsewhere. He folded down to a great dark shape with eyes like banked coals, and he looked the camp over, the lanes and the wards and the cold bonfire ring, with the expression of a very old creature counting, again, how many of these he had outlived.

"Doesn't look like much," Drake said, which was the first thing he had said in some hours, and which Viridia understood, by now, to be the nearest thing he had to a blessing. A thing that looked like much was a thing that had not yet been taken from him. A thing that looked like nothing might be allowed to last.

"It holds," she said.

"For now things hold." He turned the banked-coal eyes on Raizen, and something passed between the two dragons that she had no part in, six thousand years long, and Drake made a low sound that was not quite words and not quite a growl, and Raizen lowered his head, briefly, the way a young thing lowers its head to an old one. Then Drake looked back at her, and the look went down through her the way his looks did, to the place where she kept the things she was not

saying. "He talks now," Drake said. "You will wish he didn't. Give it a week."

"I heard that," said Raizen.

"You were meant to."

It should have been a thing to hold onto, the two of them, the gruff old grief and the bright young noise, the way an ordinary morning might have a quarrel in it that meant nothing and meant everything. But the lane to the hall ran straight across the middle of Viridia's attention, and behind the closed door up there a woman in soft boots was setting something down on the council table, and Drake, who had buried more of the world than anyone living, watched Viridia's eyes go to the door and did not pretend not to see it.

"You're waiting on something," he said.

"Yes."

"From in there." He did not ask what. He had been alive long enough to know that the things people waited on with that particular stillness were not things you asked about; you waited beside them, or you left them alone, and he chose, in his gruff way, to wait. He lay down where he was, vast and black and patient, and the frost spread under him, and he said, to the painted forest and not to her, "I lost a daughter to a war like this one. Long ago. They took her before the fighting, not in it. People forget that part of a war. They think the dying is the worst of it. The worst of it is the time before the dying, when they have someone of yours and you have not yet been told which it will be." He closed the coal eyes. "Go and be told, little spear. Waiting on the porch of it is worse than the room."

She had not told him there was a someone. She had not told anyone, not in words. But Drake had buried a daughter, and Raizen could smell the place where the burners kept the unburned, and the part of her that always kept count noted, distantly, that she was surrounded now by creatures who

could read her better than the people could, and that there was a kind of mercy in it, and a kind of nakedness, and she had not decided yet which it mostly was.

She left the dragons where they lay and walked up to the hall, where Jazen was, and where the news was, and she made her face the careful face on the way, coin by coin, the way she always paid for it, and by the time she reached the door there was nothing on it at all.

* * *

She did not go in. She did not have to.

The door of the hall stood open against the warming morning, and Jazen was inside with the scout and two of the council, and Viridia stopped in the doorway with the light at her back and listened, because she had learned that the truest version of a thing was the one said before anyone arranged it for her ears.

"Not all of them, then," Coram was saying, soft, the old man, working it over. "Not killed."

"Not all," said the scout. Ferro. Viridia fixed the name. "That's the part I came to say, because it changes things, and it'll change things for some of us harder than others." Her voice was flat with road and with the swallowed stone. "I watched the courtyard at the school for the better part of a day, from the ridge, with a glass. They weren't burying. After the first day they weren't even killing, not the way you'd think. They had men at a table. Writing things down. They'd bring people up out of the wreck, the ones still living, and a light mage in a grey coat would put his hands near them, or his glasses on them, and look, and then they'd sort them. Most went one way, in a line, roped, toward the rail. A few went the other way, and the other way I didn't like the look of, but it was the line toward the rail I came to tell you about. They're not killing the useful ones. They're collecting them."

"Collecting them for what," said Jazen, and his voice had the flat hardness Viridia knew, the certainty that costs.

"For use." Ferro said it the way you'd report weather. "That's the word that came down the line, from a railman who saw the cars unloaded at the other end. The capital's short of healers; it's been short of healers since the severing made true mending rare; and now it's got a school's worth of first-generation talent pulled out of a fire, and it's not about to waste the ones that can knit a wound. They're taking them in toward the capital. The dead they leave. The dangerous they..." She stopped, and chose another word. "They deal with. The useful they keep." A pause. "I'd not call it mercy. I've seen what *kept* looks like. But it's not killed. And for some, that's the only word that matters this morning, so I'll say it plain so no one has to hope sideways: there are people who walked out of Hazel alive, in ropes, on a train, and they are alive now, this morning, somewhere short of the capital walls or just inside them."

The hall was quiet. Somewhere outside, a baby in the next house began, on schedule, to cry.

It was Mella who asked it, the woman in blue, because Mella had grandchildren and had learned the hard art of asking the question whose answer she dreaded. "Did you get any of them? Names. Faces. Anything a person could hold."

"Few." Ferro's voice changed, and Viridia, in the doorway, went so still that the stillness was itself a kind of motion, a holding of every part of herself at once. "We don't get names off a ridge with a glass. We get builds and coats and how they walk. The line of them I watched the longest, going toward the rail, there was a girl in it I marked, because she was helping. That's why I marked her. She'd no call to. Roped like the rest, and she kept stopping to put her shoulder under an old man who couldn't keep the pace, and a guard would shove her on and she'd go three steps and

drift back and do it again. First-generation, the grey coat tagged her, so she was for keeping, not killing. Heavysset. Younger than most. Fair hair, long, the colour gone dark with the soot of the place. And the hands." Ferro paused, hunting the detail, because she was a scout and the detail was her trade. "The hands were what I marked her by, in the end. The way she used them on the old man. Careful. Like she knew exactly how much a body could take. A healer's hands, if I ever saw a pair, and I've seen a few. A heavysset first-gen girl, fair-haired, with a healer's hands, helping an old man toward a train she'd no reason to want to board."

The cold working part of Viridia, the part that catalogued, the part that did not feel until later and then felt everything at once, took the inventory and laid it down beside another one it had been carrying since a burning corridor. Heavysset. Fair hair, long. First-generation. A healer's hands. Helping someone she had no reason to help, because she had never once in the time Viridia had known her been able to walk past a person who needed a shoulder, not in the dining hall, not in the corridors, not on the worst night of either of their lives.

It was not a name. A ridge and a glass did not give you names. It was a build and a coat and the way a girl used her hands, and rumor was a liar more often than not, and there were a great many heavysset fair-haired first-generation girls in a school of them, and Viridia knew all of this, held all of it, lined it up against the thing rising in her like a spring that would not stay capped, and could not make the water go back down.

She did not let it onto her face. She stood in the doorway with the light behind her and her face giving nothing, and only her breath changed, the smallest catch, in and held, and there was no one positioned to see even that.

"She might be anyone," said the silver-bun woman, from somewhere inside, in her voice of cold arithmetic. "A description is not a person. I'd caution this council against building a single decision on one girl seen through a glass at a mile."

"I'd caution the same," said Ferro, evenly. "I'm a scout. I report what I saw. What I saw was that they're keeping the useful ones alive and taking them toward the capital, and that's true whether or not any one of them is anyone's anyone. I'd not have a council move on one girl. I'd have it know what kind of place it's marching toward. It's not a place that kills everything. It's a place that *keeps* things. That's a different war than the one some of you have been planning for."

"It is a worse one," said Jazen, quietly, and Viridia heard, under the words, the thing he did not say, which was that a war you could lose was simpler than a war where losing meant the people you loved kept living in the hands of the thing you lost to. He had a sister he had not saved. He knew the arithmetic of *kept* from the inside. "It means there are people in there to fight for, not just a thing to fight against. That changes the shape of it. That changes..." He stopped, and Viridia knew, before he turned, that he had felt her in the doorway, the way a person feels a draught at the back of the neck and turns to it.

He turned. He saw her. And whatever was on his face arranged itself, gently, into the thing he kept for her, which was not pity, because he had learned she could not bear pity, but a kind of level fellow-feeling, one bearer of an unbearable thing recognising another.

"Viridia," he said.

"I heard," she said. Two words. They came out level and stripped, every difficult thing paid for before she let it past

her teeth. "A heavyset first-gen girl. Fair hair. A healer's hands. Going toward the capital on a train."

"Yes," Jazen said. He did not soften it. He had promised her once that he would carry her the truth and never a kindness dressed as one, and he kept the promise even now, when softening would have been the kinder thing and the easier one. "It might not be her. You know that better than I can tell you. A ridge and a glass don't make a name." He came toward the door, and the council watched him come, and he stopped in front of her, and he said the rest of it plainly, because plainness was the only honesty either of them trusted. "But it might. And if it's her, then she's alive, which is more than you knew an hour ago. And alive in there is the worst place to be alive that I can think of." He held her eyes. "I won't tell you which of those to feel. I don't think you can choose. I couldn't, when it was Jan. You feel all of it at once and it tears you and you let it, because the only thing worse than feeling all of it is deciding to feel none."

Behind her, down the lane, out past the houses, the prismatic dragon lifted his head, because along the bond, through every door she had shut, he had felt the well come up in her and overflow into a place even she could not bank. He did not understand it yet, the human grammar of hoping and dreading the same fact in the same breath, but he felt it, and he turned the prismatic head toward the hall and waited, the way Drake had taught him in an hour to wait, beside the thing and not inside it.

Viridia stood in the doorway between the dragons and the council, between the morning that had given her back the bond and the morning that had taken the not-knowing and handed her back something crueller in its place. It was a knowing she could not trust and could not put down: that a girl who helped people she had no reason to help was alive, perhaps, on a train, perhaps, going into the one city in the

world that wanted Viridia dead and would now, if the rumor held, be holding the one person Viridia had walked out of the fire still hoping to save.

She had wanted, six weeks ago, only to be unseen. She had spent the morning being seen by a dragon, a death-lizard, a scout, and a man who had lost his own sister to the same kind of war, every one of them reading her down to the place she kept shut, and she found, standing there, that she did not have the strength left over to mind it, and that this, too, was a kind of being saved, though it did not feel like one.

She looked at Jazen, and she asked him the only thing that mattered, the thing the whole morning had been narrowing toward, the question that would turn a rumor seen through a glass into something a person could act on or grieve.

"Can you find out," she said, "if it's her. Not a build and a coat. Her. Can the lines reach into the capital far enough to put a name to a girl on a train. Alice Pembroke. First-year. The hands."

And Jazen, who could not lie to her and would not, looked back down the lane at the dragons and the wards and the road that ran out toward the city that kept what it could use, and he said, "There's one line that reaches that far. I've been saving it. I didn't want to spend it on a rumor." He let out a breath. "But you're not asking me to spend it on a rumor. You're asking me to spend it on a name. That's a different thing, and you know it is, and you knew it before you asked." He met her eyes. "I'll send it tonight. We'll have an answer in three days. And then, Viridia, whatever it says, you and I are going to have to decide what alive-in-the-capital is worth, and what we're willing to pay to go and get it, and I'll tell you now so you can start carrying it: the price of that road runs straight through the war I'm already marching us toward."

Three days. She fixed it where she fixed everything, beside the count and the wall and the grey ward-mage and the rest, in the place that did not lose things. Three days, and then a name, or no name, and either way a road that ran through a war and into a city built to keep what it could use.

"Send it," Viridia said.

And outside the door, along a thread gone slack with a joy that had lasted exactly one hour, a dragon felt her decide, and rose, and came toward the hall to be the thing that was there.

CHAPTER THREE

Alive Is Not the Same as Safe

The three days did not pass. They sat. She had expected them to pass and they did not, and that was what the waiting taught her before it taught her anything else.

She had thought a count of days would behave like the other count, the one under the war, ticking down clean toward the road. But the war's count was made of hours doing things, supplies and patrols and the slow assembling of a march, and this one was made of nothing. There was no work in it. There was only Jazen's line gone out into the dark toward the capital, and a girl on the far end of it who was a name or was a rumor, and three days of weather between the question and whatever answer the dark would hand back. So she worked the other count instead. She held boards for Brutus. She taught the children their letters at the long table and started them on a second word, the round old character for *patience*, which she did not believe in and taught anyway. She banked her core to a flicker by daylight and let it come up to a coal at night. And she did not ask Jazen, not once, in three days, whether the line had answered, because she had learned long ago that the asking did not bring the answer faster and only told the room how much you wanted it.

Raizen had no such practice and saw no reason to acquire one.

"You are doing the still thing again," he said, on the second evening, stretched along the dead fire-pit with his prismatic length curled round half of it and the children of the camp creeping closer each night to dare a hand against his changing scales. "You did the still thing all of yesterday. You will do it tomorrow. I have decided I do not like the still thing. It is a way of being absent while remaining present, and I crossed the world to have you present."

"It's how I wait," Viridia said.

"It is a poor way to wait. Drake waits like that. Six thousand years he has had at it, and he has waited himself nearly to stone." He turned the long head and fixed her with one slowly cycling eye. "Tell me the thing you are waiting for. Out loud. I can feel it sitting on you. It has a flavour. It is the flavour of a door you are afraid to open because you cannot decide which of two terrible rooms is behind it."

She had not meant to tell him, and she found, the way she kept finding with him, that the bond made the not-telling pointless; he had the shape of it already and only wanted the words to put round the shape. So she gave him the words, flatly, the way she gave hard things. A friend. From the school. Maybe alive, maybe taken. Three days for a line to learn which.

Raizen took this in. The colours along his spine moved while he thought, the way light moves on water when something has passed underneath.

"And if the line says taken," he said, "you will go and take her back."

"I don't know."

"You do know. You have known since before the woman with the soft boots came up the lane. I felt you decide it then and decide it has been deciding you ever since." He laid the head down level with her, the breath of him stirring her hair. "I do not say it to scold you. I say it so that you will stop

pretending the waiting is for the answer. You are not waiting to learn what to feel. You are waiting for permission to feel it."

She did not answer that, because it was true, and because there was no answer to a true thing that did not either confirm it or insult them both. She put her hand against the warm jaw, and the scales went silver-green under her palm the way they did now, helplessly, the way a face turns toward a name, and they sat in the cold ring while the lanes darkened one window at a time and, somewhere off in the next house, a baby took up its nightly complaint.

* * *

The war's count did not wait for hers, and on the second day it put a hand on her shoulder to remind her of it.

It came in the middle of the afternoon, while she was at the boards with Brutus, in the shape of a scout coming up the east track at the particular flat trot of a person who has something that will not keep. Viridia set her board down and was at the council rail before the woman had finished giving her word, because she had read the trot for what it was, and what it told her was that a scout who has seen nothing does not run.

The patrols had changed. That was the whole of it, and it was enough. For two years, the woman said, the columns east of Hazel had drifted the way they had always drifted, near and then gone again, wandering up close to a thing they could not see and wandering off it none the wiser, never the same ground twice. They were not drifting now. Since the burning of the school they had begun to quarter the country, working it in lines, a grid laid down over the empty miles and walked west to east and back, each pass a little nearer than the last, the unmistakable method of men who have

been told there is a thing out here to find and have stopped expecting to stumble on it and started, patiently, to look.

Viridia went out to the east rim while there was light to do it, and brought the sight up, and read the ground past the shivering wards, out into the false stillness of the painted trees, and found nothing yet, no column, no warmth on the move, only the empty country and the long even breath of the living world. She did not need to see the patrol to know the woman was right. She could feel the shape of the search the way she felt the shape of a thing she was waiting on, and the shape of it was a net being drawn slowly closed over a country, and the camp was somewhere inside the net, and the net was tightening by a measurable amount each day.

She stayed there at the rim and did the arithmetic she did not want to do. The wait she had told herself was made of nothing had a second clock in it after all, running under the first. There was Alice's answer, two days out in the dark. And there was this, the grid coming on, nearer each pass, on a schedule the capital set and she did not, and the window she had been telling herself she could spend at her leisure had an edge to it now, and the edge belonged to the enemy.

She went back in and told the council what she had read, plainly, the way Jazen had taught her a thing was worth more said plain than dressed, and Jazen heard her out and did not disagree, which from him was the same as agreement. And the war's count, which until that afternoon had been a thing of supplies and patrols happening somewhere over the trees, came into the room and sat down at the table beside the count of Alice's days, and the two of them ran on together after that, and neither would be hurried, and neither would wait.

* * *

On the third night Jazen came for her, and she knew the answer before he said a word, because of how he walked.

By then she was out at the rim of the camp, where the air went thin and shivering, where she went in the evenings now to feel the bond pull and to stand where no one could read her. She saw him come up the lane in the last of the light. She read him the way she read everyone, by the one thing that did not fit. He did not walk like a man bringing nothing. A man bringing nothing walked loose, almost apologetic, the bad news of having no news. Jazen walked the other way, careful, level, the walk of a man carrying something full to the brim that would spill if he hurried. He was carrying an answer. She knew it the length of the lane away, and she had the whole of that lane to make her face, and she made it, coin by coin, so that by the time he reached her there was nothing on it at all.

"The line answered," he said.

"Yes," she said. Not a question. She had read it off his walk and there was no point making him watch her pretend she hadn't.

He stopped in front of her. He did not perform the moment; he had never performed anything for her, which was the thing she trusted in him over all the rest. He simply set it down where she could see it.

"Alice Pembroke is alive," Jazen said. "She's in the capital. My line put a name to her two nights ago and confirmed it last night, which is the only reason I'm telling you and not guessing at you." He let the first part land before he gave her the second, which she understood was a mercy, the spacing of it, the way you do not hand a person two weights at once. "She's in the workhouses on the south side, behind the river. They've got the first-generation healers there, dozens of them, off the trains from Hazel and from three other schools they emptied the same week. They're not

in cells. That's the part you'll have to hold. They're in *work*. Wards full of soldiers and quarry men and the ordinary sick of a city that's run short of mending, and the healers go bed to bed, knitting what comes in, all day, under a grey coat with a list and a man at a desk who writes down how much each of them mends and how much each of them eats." He paused. "My line spoke to a railman who carries the workhouse rolls. There's an A. Pembroke on the south rolls. First-generation. Tagged for keeping. The clerk's note beside her name says *calm hands*."

Calm hands. Brun had said that, once, a lifetime ago, a teacher at Hazel watching Alice steady a boy's broken wrist, *that one's got calm hands, you can't teach that*. It was the wrong detail to undo her and so of course it was the one that did it. Not the name, which a clerk could mistake, but the two words a stranger with a list had written down for a reason that had nothing to do with mercy, the same two words a kind teacher had once said for a reason that had everything to do with it. A fair-haired first-gen healer of heavier build was a description anyone might fit. *Calm hands* was Alice and no one else.

Viridia stood very still. Her face did nothing. Her hands did nothing. But her breath went out of her in a single short pull and did not come back the same, and Jazen, who had a sister he had not saved either, saw the one thing and not the rest, and did not reach for her, which she would have hated.

"It's her," she said. Two words, level, paid for before they passed her teeth.

"I think it's her," Jazen said. "I won't say more than I know. But I'd put a great deal on it, and I've spent the line that could put it past doubt, and *calm hands* is what it brought back, so." He stopped. "She's alive, Viridia. Three days ago you knew a description on a ridge. Tonight you know a name

on a roll in a city. That's the thing to hold onto first, before the rest of it."

"And the rest of it." Her voice came out flat. She made it come out flat.

"The rest of it is that alive is not the same as safe." He said it plainly, because plainness was the only kindness either of them trusted. "They don't kill the useful ones. They use them up. A healer mends with her own core; you know that; she pours herself into the wound and refills slow, and the workhouse doesn't let them refill. The railman says a few of them go that way every season. Not to cruelty. To arithmetic. They mend until there's nothing left to mend with, and then there's a new train, and a new list." He held her eyes. "I'm not telling you that to take the alive away from you. I'm telling you because you'd find it out yourself in a week and hate me for the week I let you not know it. She's alive. And the place she's alive in is a slow way of not being. Both of those are true tonight, and I won't choose between them for you. I learned with Jan that you can't."

The capital. The one place on the map that would kill her on sight. And inside it, behind a river, in a ward thick with the smell of other people's wounds, a girl who had never once been able to leave a struggling person unhelped, pouring herself out bed by bed for a man with a list, refilling slow, losing two or three of her own a season to nothing crueller than counting. The relief came up in her, real and warm, like a spring breaking open under a stone she had set on it herself. The dread came up right behind it, drawn from the same source. Now there was a person, a confirmed and named and located person, alive inside the exact place built to make Viridia stop being one, and a person you could save was a person you could fail to save. The not-knowing she had carried out of Hazel was gone, and what it had left behind was heavier and had Alice's name on it.

She had wanted, she remembered, only the not-knowing to end. She had not understood, asking for it, that a knowing could be the crueller weight.

* * *

They walked, because he could see she could not stand still with it, and walking was a thing the body could do while the rest of her went where it had to go. He took her not toward the lanes but along the inside of the wards, the long way, where the air shivered on their left and the camp slept on their right, and he talked, which surprised her, because Jazen did not waste words; and then it stopped surprising her, because she understood that he was not wasting them. He was giving her something to put against the weight, and the only thing he had to give was the one weight he had carried longer.

"You asked me once who Jan was," he said. "You didn't ask, actually. You let me not say. I noticed. Most people ask. You're the only one who's let me not say, and I think that's why I'm going to say it now, on the one night you didn't ask."

"You don't have to."

"No. But you're carrying a thing tonight that I've carried for two years, and I'd rather you carried it knowing one other person has, than carried it thinking you're the first." He walked a few steps. The shiver of the wards threw faint moving light along the side of his face. "Jan was my sister. Younger. Three years younger, which when you're the older one means you spend the first half of your life sure she's an idiot and the second half realizing she was the brave one." He almost smiled, and it did not last. "She had the gift the way I have it. Dark side. Strong, in her. Stronger than mine, if you measured it raw, which you can't, but I did, the way brothers do. And when the soldiers came to our town, two years ago, before any of this was a resistance, before there

was a camp to hide in, when it was just a town and some frightened people and her and me, they took her. Not killed. Took. The way they take the useful ones. She was sixteen and she could do things with a dark core that a grown man couldn't and a grey coat looked at her and tagged her for keeping."

Viridia said nothing. She had learned that the saying of a thing like this did not want answers in it.

"I went after her," Jazen said. "Of course I did. I was young and I was strong and I was sure, the way you're sure at that age that being strong enough is the same as being right enough. I found the column on the road. There were forty soldiers and one of me, and I want you to understand that I knew that, I counted them, I'm not telling you a story where grief made me forget the numbers. I counted forty and I went anyway, because the alternative was a road with my sister on it and me standing still." He stopped walking. The wards shivered. "I killed all of them."

The night held very still around the sentence.

"All forty," Jazen said, and his voice did not rise; it went lower, flatter, the way she knew her own went at the worst of things. "I don't remember most of it. That's the part nobody warns you about, with my kind of power. You think the horror will be remembering. The horror is that you don't. I came back into myself standing in a road with forty dead men around me and the smell of it on me and Jan." He stopped. He made himself say the rest. "Jan was already gone. They'd moved her ahead the night before. The column I caught was the wrong column. I killed forty men for a road that didn't even have her on it, and I have never since that day been able to find the bottom of what I'm capable of, because I went all the way to the bottom that day and I don't remember the trip. And I have been afraid, every single day since, of the thing in me that did that. Not afraid I'll do it

again. Afraid I'll do it *right*. That one day it'll be the right column and the right reason and I'll go to the bottom on purpose and find out that down there I'm not Jazen at all. I'm just the thing that empties roads."

He looked at her then, full on, and there was no performance in it, only the level fellow-feeling he kept for her, one bearer recognizing another.

"So when I tell you that being alive and being safe are two different things," he said, "and I tell you I won't choose your feelings for you, it's because I learned both of those at the bottom of a road two years ago, and I'd carry them for you tonight if carrying could be shared, and it can't. It can only be witnessed. That's all I've got to give you. I'll witness it." He started walking again, slower. "She never got to the capital, Jan. They lost her somewhere between. I never found which between. So you've got a thing I never got, did you notice. You've got a *where*. You know where your friend is. I'd have given the rest of my power for a where. I want you to hold that too, alongside the rest. You have a where. That's not nothing. That's the difference between a war and a wait."

Viridia walked beside him along the shivering inner line of the wards and held all of it, the alive and the not-safe and the where and the bottom of his road. And she understood what he had just done. He had handed her the most dangerous gift a frightened person can give another, the true measure of his own fear, on purpose, as a kindness, so that she would not be alone inside hers.

"Thank you," she said, and meant it the way she meant *yes*, with the whole of herself crushed down small enough to fit the word.

* * *

She did not sleep, the night the answer came. She had not expected to.

In the dark of her borrowed room she let the core come up to a coal, then past a coal, low and steady, just enough to see by. The world arranged itself the way it did through the always-on mana sight when she stopped banking it down: the wards a faint humming dome, the three ward-mages three guttering candles holding it up, Hiram the dimmest of them, burning on half his wick. And under all of it, deeper, the thing she could feel the way a foot feels the floor of a dark house. The lattice. The world's broken cores. Every living person near her a small divided fire, light or dark, half a gift each, burning on half its wick and not knowing there was a second half to burn. She had felt it since the well. She felt it now, lying awake with a name confirmed in a city behind a river, and she let herself, at last and entire, take out the thought she had been keeping packed down small since the council table, and look at it, where no one could see the light of it.

I could end this.

Not the war between forty fighters and a column. Not the road to the capital. The deeper thing the war was only a quarrel over. The cut, six hundred years old, that had set dark against light and called the two of them enemies, that had made a city short of healers and a school full of children to be sorted and a girl named Alice pouring herself out bed by bed because the gift she'd been handed was only half a gift and could not refill the way a whole one would. She could feel the severing as plainly as she felt the lattice, and she had stood at the well and understood, in a way she had not let herself finish understanding since, that what was severed could be mended. Not for one person. For all of them. Every core alive, at once, made whole, the way hers was whole and Raizen's was whole, the second half given back to a world that had burned on half its wick for six hundred years and forgotten there had ever been more.

She could give Alice a core that refilled. She could give the workhouse healers cores the arithmetic could not bleed dry. She could end the thing the whole war was a symptom of, not by winning the war but by un-making the wound the war was scratching at, and she was, so far as she could tell, the only person alive who knew how, the only one whole enough to reach the source and ask it for everyone at once.

She lay still and let the thought burn, just this once, just to know its size.

And then she shut it back down.

She drew it in and pressed it flat and stowed it under her ribs beside the rest. She did it not because the thought was wrong but because she could not yet swear that it wasn't, and a thing of that weight you do not turn loose until you are certain. To mend every core alive was to reach into every living person and alter the deepest thing they owned, without their leave, since there was no asking a whole world at once. Because the school she had walked out of had ruled people through their magic, settled for them what their gift could be, and she could not yet say what it would make of her, to settle for everyone what their gift would become, even if the settling was a gift, even if it was the kindest act a person could choose. Amber would have a word for it. Amber, who had shattered her own core to keep faith with her own grief, who had chosen the breaking herself, who would look at Viridia mending six hundred million cores no hand of theirs had broken, not one of them consulted, and find exactly the question Viridia could not yet answer.

She did not let the thought go out. She kept it, banked, a coal under her ribs where the mother's stone and the Dangris lay, and she stayed awake and waited for a morning she did not want. The morning would have a road in it now, a road with a where at the end of it, and she had three days fewer than before to weigh what alive-in-the-capital was

worth, and what she would spend to go and get it, and which of her own roads ran through the war and which ran somewhere far worse.

Beyond the camp the bond lay slack and warm and near, the dragon a steady presence at the back of her mind. The dark-blue stone rested cool at her collarbone, the small spear cooler beside it. And in a city behind a river a girl with calm hands knit a stranger's wound and refilled slow, alive and not safe, named and located and waiting, though she did not know it, for a friend who had just spent the night taking out the one thing that could save everyone, and stowing it carefully back.

* * *

In the grey before dawn Amber found her out by the dead fire, which meant Amber had not slept either, which meant Amber had heard.

"Don't," Amber said, lowering herself down beside her with the blanket round her shoulders and the studied carelessness that was her oldest armor. "Don't do the face. I already know. The whole camp knows by now, a camp's worse than a school for it. The healer girl. Your healer girl. In the capital, and breathing." She folded her arms over her drawn-up knees. "I'm not going to tell you it's good news, because you'll hate me, and I'm not going to tell you it's bad news, because that's a lie too, and I've decided I'm done lying to you on the grounds that it never once worked." She ticked it off on a finger, the chipped black nail. "One. She's alive. That's real and you're allowed to feel it." A second finger. "Two. Where she is is a slow grave with a list at the door, and you're allowed to feel that one at the same time, and if anyone tells you that's not how feelings work, send them to me, I'll explain it, I've got a degree in feelings from the woods." Her hand dropped to the blanket. "Three."

"There's no three," Viridia said.

"There's a three." Amber looked at the dead fire. The armor came down, a piece at a time, the way it did now, slower than before the woods. "Three is, I've been watching you, Vee. Since the camp. You've got a face you make when you think nobody's looking, and I look, because I've got nothing better to do while I'm being told how much better I look. And there's a thing you're not saying. Bigger than the healer girl. Bigger than the war. I don't know what it is. But you've got it the way I had my core that last year, before I broke it — like you're carrying something that could fix everything and end you, and you haven't decided yet which it'd mostly do." She turned and looked at Viridia directly, and there was no joke under it, none, the bare damaged honesty she let out maybe once a season. "I know that carry. That's my carry. I made the wrong call on mine. So I'm going to say one thing, and then I'll go back to being insufferable, I promise. Whatever it is, the big one, the one you're not saying, you don't get to decide it alone in the dark at five in the morning because the dark's the only place quiet enough. That's how you make the wrong call. The dark always votes yes. Wait for the daylight to vote." She pulled the blanket tighter. "That's three. I'm done. Say one kind word about my recovery and I'll bite you."

Viridia looked at her, and at the dead fire, and out past the wards where the dawn was starting to lift the false forest out of the dark.

"You look better," she said.

Amber laughed, a real one, short and surprised, the one that came up from under the armor and not over it. "Knew you would," she said, and leaned her head, briefly, against Viridia's shoulder, the weight of her real and tired and alive. "You always pick the true thing over the safe one. It's going to get us both killed and I wouldn't have you any other way."

She closed her eyes. "Get her back, Vee. The healer girl. Whatever it costs. And when you go to do it, you take me, because I am extremely good at distractions, I distracted myself for nine years, and because I am not sitting in a camp learning to teach Moravian to six-year-olds while you walk alone into the place that would hang you for your hair. I've decided. It's not up for discussion. It's three. There it is. It surfaced."

She fell asleep like that, against Viridia's shoulder, in the grey before dawn, the way the deeply tired do, mid-sentence, with her three finally counted. And Viridia sat very still so as not to wake her, and watched the dawn come up over the wards she did not fully trust, and held the warm sleeping weight of the one friend she had left in arm's reach while she carried the dread of the one she did not. She kept her face still and untold, though there was no longer anyone awake to read it, because keeping it was the one thing in her that nothing yet had managed to take.

Three days had passed. They had brought a name, a city, a river, and a clerk's note in a stranger's hand. *Calm hands*. And somewhere behind that river, in a ward that smelled of other people's wounds, Alice Pembroke knit a soldier's torn arm and refilled slow, alive and named and dying by arithmetic, and the only road that reached her ran straight through a war that had not started yet and a thought Viridia had taken out in the dark and put away unsure.

She sat with the dawn and the sleeping girl and the slack warm thread, and she did not decide, yet, which road she would spend the day's daylight learning to walk. She only knew, now, that there was a where at the end of it.

And that the dark had wanted her to say yes.

CHAPTER FOUR

His Mother's Papers

The box came up out of the ground in front of her before she knew what it was, and that was the first time she understood that Lady Lightwell had thought about her after she was dead.

It was the fourth day after the answer, and Jazen had taken her out past the back of the meeting house to a place where a flat stone sat in the grass and looked like nothing, the way the camp had taught her everything looked like nothing if it mattered. He knelt and pried the stone and lifted from under it a flat tin case the size of a serving tray, banded round twice with wire, and the dirt fell off it in a small dry rain, and he set it on the grass between them and did not open it at once.

"My mother left this with me the last time she came," he said. "I've been deciding for a week whether to show you. I decided this morning. I'll tell you why after, if you still want to know."

Viridia looked at the case and said nothing, which was the thing she did instead of asking, because the asking only ever announced how badly you wanted a thing, and she wanted this more than she had let herself want anything since the ridge.

* * *

Around them the camp went on being a place where people lived, which was the cruelty and the mercy of it both.

She had learned, this week, to hear the camp without looking at it. Brutus's hammer somewhere off to the east, slower now, a man pacing himself against a winter he was counting in boards. The children at their board chanting the round old letters after Mirelle, who taught them the way you teach a thing you are afraid will die with you, patiently, twice, and then a third time for the one who had been looking at a beetle. Mirelle had a baby on her hip while she did it, a fat solemn infant who watched the lesson as though grading it, and Mirelle's husband was two winters dead on a road he'd held while the rest of them ran, and she had borne the baby four months after and gone on teaching letters, and Viridia had marked all of that the first week and set it where she kept the people she did not intend to lose and could not promise not to.

And Amber, who was meant to be resting, climbing instead. She had taken it into her head to climb the meeting-house wall to the low roof, slowly, narrating each handhold, because the healer woman with the silver bun had told her to take it easy and Amber's recovery had reached the stage where defiance was a sign of health. "I'm not resting," she'd announced that morning, halfway up, both feet braced and her black ponytail swinging, "I am undertaking a structured program of altitude. The woods made me soft. I'm getting my edges back. Tell the bun-woman I said so." She had got to the roof and sat there triumphant and out of breath and pretending she wasn't, and that was where she still was now, a black shape on the ridgeline against the false sky, watching the two of them at the stone and not pretending she wasn't doing that either.

"Your friend is on the roof," Jazen said.

"She's getting her edges back."

"Mm." He almost smiled. He undid the first wire band, then the second, the wire stiff and unwilling, his hands careful the way she'd seen them careful with everything that had his mother in it. "She does the thing you do, your Amber. Watches the one place no one's looking at. You're a matched set, you and her, you watch the seams of a thing." He set the wire aside in a neat coil, because he was the kind of man who coiled the wire. "My mother watched seams too. It's how she stayed alive as long as she did, in a city full of people who'd have hanged her for the company she kept. Watch the seams. Trust the thing that doesn't fit." He lifted the lid.

* * *

Papers. That was all it was, to look at, and Viridia had to remind herself that the most dangerous things she had ever held had looked like nothing too.

He brought them out in layers and named each as he set it on the grass, and she understood that the naming was itself a kind of grief, a man taking inventory of the last of his mother in the open air because he could not bear to do it alone in the dark and had chosen her to do it with, which she filed away too, the size of that trust, to feel later.

Routes, first. Thin folded maps of the rail lines and the road-stations, marked in a small even hand with symbols Viridia did not know and Jazen did: a circle for safe, a circle struck through for fallen, a half-circle for a place that would hide you one night and no more. The capital sat in the corner of the largest map like a spider at the edge of its web, the lines all running into it, and Viridia's eye went to it the way a tongue goes to a sore tooth, because Alice was somewhere inside that ring of ink and she could not yet do anything about it but look.

Names, second. Lists of them, in columns, some struck out. "The struck-out ones are dead," Jazen said, level, "or

turned. She kept them on the list anyway. She said a name you cross off is a name you remember crossing off, and a name you erase is a name you start to think you imagined." He touched the top of one column without reading it aloud. "Her own's not on here. She never put herself on a list. She used to say the list was for the people she was responsible for, and she wasn't on it because she was the one holding it." His thumb stayed on the paper a moment too long. "Somebody's holding it now and it isn't her. I keep forgetting that. I'll go to tell her a thing and get halfway to wherever I think she is."

"I know," Viridia said. Two words. They were the truest thing she had, and she gave them to him the way he had given her *calm hands*, set down where he could see them and not pressed on him.

He looked at her, and something in his face eased, not much, the way a held breath eases by half.

"You do, don't you," he said. "That's the other reason I decided this morning. You're the only one in this camp who won't tell me she's in a better place." He went back to the papers. "She's in the ground in a city that burned her down for being mine. There's no better place in it. But there's this." And he came to the third layer, and his hands slowed, and she understood before he lifted it that they had reached the thing he had really brought her here for.

* * *

It was a single sheet, soft with folding, and on it there was no address and no signature, and Viridia did not need either, because she had read the same hand once before in her life and had carried the paper it was written on until it burned.

You are not broken, the note said. *You are whole, and someone wants you not to know it. Trust the part of you they tell you to fear. Be careful who you let see you do it.*

Underneath, in the same small even hand: a list of three things to do and not to do, and the third was *leave the open circle where the right people will find it*. And that was all. No name. The note that had come packed in the case with her focus, the silver rod, in the first week of Hazel, the note she had read a hundred times and never solved, the note she had assumed for half a year was Mrs. Zoran's doing, or her mother's reaching from somewhere it could not reach, and it was here, a copy of it, in Lady Lightwell's tin case, in Lady Lightwell's hand.

She did not let her face move. She had a great deal of practice and she spent every coin of it, and her face gave the grass and the false sky and the man across the case absolutely nothing, while underneath it some floor she had been standing on tilted and a great many things she had believed about her own beginning slid off it and broke.

Lightwell. The rose-tinted spectacles across a desk on her first day, *you were chosen*, said with that second meaning Viridia had heard under it even then and not been able to name. Chosen. Not chosen by the school. Chosen by the woman who ran the dark half of a city in plain sight under a light-mage's smile, who had picked a half-orphan whole child off a list somewhere and reached across a country to pack a true word in beside a silver rod, *you are not broken*, before Viridia had ever known there was a question. The note had not found her by accident. Nothing in her life since the morning the world ended had found her by accident. She had been chosen, first, on purpose, by a woman who was now in the ground and could not be asked why and could not be thanked.

"You know this hand," Jazen said. It was not a question. He had been watching her not-react, and he read the not-reaction the way she herself read a room, catching on the one note that rang wrong, which was that there was

nothing to read at all, and a face with nothing on it is the loudest face there is to a man who knows the trick.

"Yes," Viridia said.

"How."

"I've seen it before." She heard her own voice do the flat thing, come out level and stripped, and could not stop it and did not try, because to fight it would have shown more than the flatness did. "Word for word. On a paper that came with my focus, my first week at Hazel. I never knew who sent it." She made herself look up from the note to him. "It was her. It was your mother. She sent it to me before I ever set foot in that school. She knew what I was before I did."

* * *

The roof creaked. Amber had come down off it, soft for a girl who narrated everything, and was standing at the corner of the meeting house with her arms folded and the joke gone off her face, because she had heard enough of it, or read enough of Viridia's back, to know the seam of the moment without being told.

"What is it," Amber said. Not lightly. "Vee. What's the paper."

"In a minute," Viridia said.

"That's a no-minutes face. I know that face. I lived next to that face for six weeks." But she came no closer and asked nothing more, which was Amber giving a thing the way Amber gave things, by holding still when every nerve in her wanted to move, and Viridia marked it and would feel it later.

Jazen had not taken his eyes off Viridia. "Then you know more than I do," he said quietly. "I never saw her send it. I knew there was a girl. For two years she'd say *the girl*, the way you'd say a card you were keeping back. *When the girl comes through. The girl will need.* I thought it was a code for a

thing, a plan, a place. I didn't know the girl had a face until you walked up the lane with the tiger at your heel and my mother already a week dead, and you took the measure of this camp in ten minutes flat the way she'd have done, and I thought—" He stopped. The thing in his throat moved. "I thought, *there she is. That's the girl. She came through.* And my mother wasn't here to see it." He looked down at the note, soft with someone else's folding. "She spent the last of what she had getting you out of that corridor, didn't she. The warnings stopped because she stopped. The camp lost its eyes the week she died and we've been half-blind since, and I used to be angry about that, the timing of it, until just now. She traded the warnings for you. She decided you were worth the eyes of this whole camp." He said it without accusation, which was the hardest way he could have said it. "I'd like to know what she saw. Because I look at you and I see a half-grown girl who holds her face like a woman three times her age and reads a wall the way Brutus reads it, and that's no small thing, but it isn't *trade the camp's eyes for it.* So." He folded his hands. "What are you, Viridia. What did my mother see, that she'd spend herself blind to put in the world."

The question sat between them in the grass, beside the open case and the dead woman's hand, and Viridia felt the whole of it arrive at once: that he had nearly guessed, that he was a step from it, that a single true sentence would close the distance, and that the sentence was the most dangerous thing she owned and she had sworn she would let no one carry it who could be made to give it up.

She did not answer it. She did the thing she had learned in a corridor and at a council table and over and over since: she took the question out, looked at its size, and set it down somewhere it would keep.

"Something she thought was worth it," Viridia said. "I don't know yet if she was right."

Jazen looked at her a long moment. Then, to her surprise, he let it go, the way you let go of a wire you've decided not to cut yet. "All right," he said. "All right. You'll tell me when you tell me, and not before, and I find I trust that more than I'd trust a quick answer. My mother would've liked you. She liked the ones who made her wait." He almost smiled again, and this time a little of it stayed. "That's the third reason. The whole reason, if you want it plain. She liked the ones who made her wait, and I haven't had anyone to wait for since she died, and you make me wait, and it's the first thing in a week that's felt like her."

* * *

There was more in the case, under the note, and the more was the thing that pulled the floor a second time.

It was a fragment of a family line, drawn the old way, names hung off a branching rule in faded ink, generations of it, and most of it meant nothing to Viridia, a stranger's dead climbing back into a stranger's past. Jazen spread it flat with both hands. "Light-mage lines," he said. "She collected them. Knew them better than the Conclave's own clerks. Who married who, who carried what, which families bred the gift true and which let it thin. It's how she knew which doors would open. You want a moderate to listen, you don't knock on the loudest door, you knock on the one three branches back from a marriage everyone's forgotten was a scandal." His finger moved down the ink, easy, fluent, a man reading a thing his mother had taught him to read. "These two are Conclave. This one's the Chancellor's wife's people, see, that's why he—"

He stopped.

Viridia had already seen it. She had been reading the chart the same way she read everything, by the one thing that did not fit. And there it was, low on the branching rule: a name set in among the dead light-mage lines that did not sit right, that had no date hung beside it where every other name had two, that was written in a slightly different weight of ink as though added later, or earlier, or by a different hand, or by the same hand on a different day when it knew something it had not known before. A name that did not fit the pattern. She did not read it aloud. She read it once, silently, the way you read a thing you mean to keep, and let it go behind her eyes where she kept the rest, and she could not have said even to herself why it set the small cold bell ringing at the back of her skull, only that it did, the same bell that had rung over a spellbook in a school that no longer stood, the bell that meant *this one. Come back to this one.*

"That one's wrong," she said, before she could decide not to. "It hasn't got dates. Everything else has two and that one's got none."

Jazen looked at where her eye had gone, and something moved across his face that she could not name and filed for later, a flicker that was almost recognition and almost fear and was gone before she could fix it.

"I noticed that too," he said, slow. "Years ago. Asked her about it. She did a thing she only ever did once or twice." He sat back. "She closed the case. Said, *not yet, and maybe not by us.* And put it in the ground." He looked at Viridia. "I never asked again. You don't, with her, when she does the *not yet.* But you're the first person besides me who's ever found that name in ten seconds flat without being told it was there." The flicker came again and went again. "She'd have hated that and loved it. So would I. Leave it. We'll come back to it when there's time, which there isn't." He folded the chart along its old creases, gently, and set it back. "There's enough

in this case to lose ourselves in for a year, and we've got a week."

* * *

That was the turn, and Viridia felt it come as a relief and a danger both, because it gave her something to do with her hands and her mind that was not the unforgivable thing she kept banked under her ribs.

"The routes," she said. "The names. If she knew which doors would open." She looked at the spider in the corner of the map, the city with Alice in it and a war marching toward it, and then she looked away from the city, on purpose, to the names struck and unstruck in their columns. "She wasn't only collecting them to know who'd hang her. She was collecting them to know who might *listen*."

"Some of them, yes." Jazen watched her carefully. "There's a faction in the Conclave that's never wanted this war. Quiet about it, because the Chancellor's glasses are everywhere and a moderate who says so out loud is a moderate who disappears. But they're there. My mother kept the thread to them. Three of them, by the end. Two are struck out now." He found the page, and there were three names, and a line through two of them, and beside the third, in the small even hand, a mark Viridia had seen on the back of the note: an open circle, not closed, a circle left deliberately unjoined. "This one she didn't strike. Coram knows the man, distantly. They sat a hearing together once, twenty years back, before any of it. He's old. He's careful. He's got a granddaughter at a light school and a thing he doesn't say in rooms." He set his finger on the open circle beside the name. "She marked him with the open circle. It's her sign for *would hear it, if it came from the right mouth*. One circle. One maybe. She left it open on purpose, the way she left everything open, for the right people to find."

Viridia looked at the open circle, and at the name beside it, and at the city in the corner of the map, and for once since the council table the thing under her ribs went quiet, not because she had decided it but because something else had stepped in front of it, a smaller thing, a closer thing, a thing with a door in it instead of a wall.

A road that was not a sword. A name a dead woman had left unstruck on purpose, marked with a circle she had not closed, so that someone who watched seams would find it after she was gone and understand that it was a hand held out, the last hand Lady Lightwell would ever hold out, left in the ground for a girl she had chosen before either of them had a face to put to the choosing.

"That one," Viridia said, and her voice came out steady now, because the steadiness was real this time and not spent for. "We start with that one. Before the march. Before anything I can't take back." She put her finger beside Jazen's, beside the open circle, and did not let it shake. "She left it open for whoever came after. I came after. So I'll reach for the open circle before I reach for the thing that hasn't got a door in it at all."

Jazen looked at her, at her finger beside his on his mother's last held-out hand, and he did not ask her again what she was, though the question was right there, larger than ever, with the answer practically written in how she'd said *the thing that hasn't got a door in it*. He only nodded, slow, the way a man nods at a thing he has decided to trust before he understands it.

"She'd have liked that too," he said. "Reaching for the open one first." He began to gather the papers back into the case, layer by layer, in reverse, the routes and the names and the note and the chart with the dateless name folded back into the dark. "I'll set up the way to him. It's slow and it's careful and it'll cost us two of the days we haven't got.

The week I named is already gone. I held us back when the line came in, and I'll hold us a little longer for this. But it's a road, and it's hers, and—" He stopped, the case half-closed, and looked at it, and the grief came up in him plain and unhidden the way it never came up in her, his eyes going bright in the false light. He let them. He did not turn away or press it down or spend a coin to flatten it. He just let the tears stand in his eyes in front of her, openly, a man who cried and let it be seen, and Viridia, who had not let one person see her do it since the morning the world ended, sat very still across the case and witnessed it, because witnessing was the one thing she could give that cost nothing and meant everything, and he had taught her the word for it himself.

"She'd have liked," he said again, and stopped, and wiped his face with the back of his hand without apology, and finished, "that it was you who found it."

He closed the case.

* * *

Amber walked her back through the lanes in the last of the daylight, and did not ask about the paper, which from Amber was an act of love so large it nearly undid the thing the careful face had held all afternoon.

"You won't tell me," Amber said. It wasn't a question.

"Not yet."

"Not yet, and maybe not by us," Amber said, in a fair imitation of a voice she'd never heard, because she'd caught the phrase off the air the way she caught everything, and Viridia almost laughed, which surprised them both. "There it is. I knew there was one in you somewhere. We'll get the rest out by spring." She walked a few steps, hands in the pockets of a coat too big for her. "I'll tell you what I did get. You went out to that stone carrying a war and a dead friend

and a thing in your chest the size of the moon, and you came back carrying all three plus a *plan*. You've got a road now. I can see it on you. You walk different with a road." She bumped Viridia's shoulder with her own, light, the old gesture from a year and a lifetime ago. "Whatever it is, the big one — you found a smaller one to do first. Good. The bun-woman'd be proud. She's big on small steps. You should hear her on stairs."

The baby took up its evening complaint in the house they passed, the fat solemn one, no longer solemn now and very much heard, and Mirelle's voice came soft after it, the round old letters trading for an older song, and the lanes went dark a doorway at a time, and Brutus's hammer had stopped for the day, and somewhere out at the rim the air shivered over three men holding the camp unseen with the last of what they had, one of them on half his wick.

Viridia walked through the middle of it with the open circle behind her eyes and the dateless name behind that, and the thing under her ribs banked low and quiet for once, because at last, for once since the well, she had a door to knock on before she had to decide whether to take the wall down by hand.

There were fewer days left than yesterday. She had a war marching and a friend in a city that wanted her dead and a thought she still could not swear was wrong. But she had a name a dead woman had left unstruck on purpose, marked with a circle she had not closed, and tomorrow she would learn the slow careful way to reach the man it belonged to, and she would spend the daylight on the open door before she ever let herself look again at the thing that had no door in it at all.

She had been chosen. First. On purpose. By a woman in the ground who would never know she'd come through.

She filed that away, last of all, under the only heading she had ever kept for the people she could not lose because they were already lost, and she did not let it out, not even there, not even then. But she carried it back to the small bare room they had given her, and she brought her core up to a coal, and she looked a long time at the place behind her eyes where the open circle sat waiting to be knocked on, and the dateless name sat waiting to be understood, and she thought: *not yet*.

But soon. And maybe by us after all.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Furnace and the Match

The lie people tell about hard things is that they are hard.

Viridia had believed the lie most of her life, the way you believe a thing nobody troubles to disprove. The hard things were supposed to feel hard. You were supposed to strain at them, to come away wrung out and changed, to know by what a thing took out of you that you had done something that mattered. That was the bargain the world advertised. Effort in, weight out. She had carried boards for Brutus on the strength of it and learned her letters on the strength of it and held her own face still through a year that had taken everything on the strength of it, and the bargain had mostly held.

What no one had told her was that the largest thing she would ever do would be the easiest. It would take almost nothing out of her in the doing. That the price of it would go somewhere else entirely, somewhere she could not see and would never be billed, and that this, not the strain, not the difficulty, would be the thing she could not put down.

She learned it from a tree.

* * *

She went out beyond the wards in the last of the dark before dawn, while the camp was still a held breath of sleeping people and the only sound was Hiram's slow tread on the

rim where the ward thinned and a man kept it from showing. She took nobody but Lor-ar, who fell in at her left without being asked and walked the way he walked when he had decided the conversation was already underway and was merely waiting for her to catch it up.

"You did not bring the dragon," he said.

"He's loud."

"He is. It is one of his better qualities." The tiger picked his way over a fallen branch, seven feet of him moving like spilled water, the sky-and-forest of his coat going colourless in the grey. "You did not bring the girl with the black nails either, who is also loud, and whom you usually bring when you intend to do a thing you suspect she would argue against. You brought me. Who argues against everything. I am trying to decide whether that is courage or cowardice."

"It's neither. You don't tell people."

"Ah." He seemed pleased by this, in the dry way he was pleased by accurate things. "No. I do not. I am three hundred years old and I have learned that most of what people do is theirs to do and not mine to carry to the village square. You may do an unspeakable thing in front of me and I will keep it, little one, the way the forest keeps a grave." He used the words and let them land, and she understood that he had spent one of them on purpose, the way he did, to tell her the weather of the morning before she had said a word about it. "Now. Show me the thing you came out here to be sure of."

* * *

The place she had picked the day before, walking, with the part of her that was always walking the camp's edges and filing what it found. A clearing a quarter-mile past the wards where the old wood thinned to scrub. In the middle of it a rowan, dead.

It had not been dead long. A winter, maybe two. Lightning, or rot at the root, or only the ordinary arithmetic that takes a tree the way it takes everything in its turn. The bark had gone grey and was lifting in long curls. The branches held their shape and nothing else. No bud. No give. The wood under the dead skin had gone to the dry brown of a thing finished with being alive. A scatter of its own last berries lay blackened in the grass beneath it, and a bird had been at them once and given it up.

She stood in front of it and brought her mana sight up out of its bank.

She did not have to reach for it any more, which was new since the well, and still felt like a window left open in a house she'd grown up thinking had no windows at all. The world simply turned over and showed her its other face. The camp behind her a low steady glow of banked cores, and three burning thin and hard where the ward-mages held the screen. Hiram's was the worst of them, a guttering thing the colour of a coal kicked out of a fire and not yet dead. Lor-ar beside her an old deep green like the bottom of a lake. And running under all of it, under the ground and the roots and the dead grass, the thing she had only learned to see clearly in the last weeks, the thing she could not now unsee: the lattice.

That was the only word she had for it. A vast quiet structure of light, everywhere, in everything, the magic of the world laid into the world the way veins are laid into a leaf. And everywhere through it, on every living core she could see, the same wound. A line. A seam where the gift had been cut in two and one half sealed off and forgotten, so that every core she had ever looked at burned on half its wick, never told a second half existed. Hers had been like that once. She could remember the shape of the not-knowing,

the way you can remember a room you grew up in after the house is gone.

The rowan was not a core. It was a tree. But the tree was in the lattice too, the way the grass was and the dead berries were, a small spent place in the great structure where something had been and was running down. She looked at it the way she had learned to look at everything now, by the one thing that did not fit, and the one thing that did not fit about a dead tree was that it was not, in the lattice, entirely gone. The pattern of it was still there. The intent of it. The shape the tree had made in the structure of things was still pressed into the structure of things, the way a hand stays warm in a glove for a moment after the hand is gone.

She had not known she could do what she did next until she did it.

* * *

She did not use Moravian. There were no words for it. Moravian wrote intent, and she had spent a year learning to write her intent in it, sharp and exact, a focus made of grammar where her silver rod had been. But this was not a thing you instructed. This was a thing you simply stopped refusing.

She put her attention on the place where the tree's pattern lay pressed into the lattice, the warmth-in-the-glove of it, and she let the lattice do what it plainly wanted to do, which was close. That was all. She did not push. She did not strain. She found the seam in the small spent place and she let the two sides of it remember they had once been one, and the world, with what she could only call relief, did the rest.

The bark stopped lifting. It lay back down against the wood. She watched the grey go under like a tide turning, and a green come up through it that was not the green of new paint laid over old but the green of a thing that had never

stopped being green and had only been waiting for someone to admit it. The branches took weight. A give came into them, a spring, the difference between a stick and a limb. At the tips, where there had been nothing, there were buds, and then there were not buds but leaves, the soft red-bronze of rowan leaves first opening, and then the white froth of its flowering all at once and out of season, the whole crown of it foaming white in the grey light as though spring had been kept in a jar and the jar had broken. The blackened berries in the grass she left alone. But the tree above them was alive, fully, easily, entirely, and it had taken her about as long as it takes to decide not to flinch.

She stood and looked at it.

The cold working part, the bit of her that did the arithmetic while the rest of her felt things, noted that her breath had not changed at all. Her hands were steady. Her core, when she glanced down at it through the sight, had banked back to its coal on its own, untroubled, a furnace that had loaned out a cup of itself and not noticed the cup was gone. Nothing in her had moved. She had done a thing that, a year ago, in a classroom, the cleverest girl in her year had told her flatly could not be done by anyone living, the reversal of a death, even a small green one, and she had done it the way you'd straighten a picture on a wall in passing, and she felt fine. That was the wrongness of it. She felt completely fine.

"There," said Lor-ar, very quietly, behind her. "Now you know."

* * *

"Now I know it works," she said. "I knew that already. I felt it at the well. I just hadn't seen it." She stopped. There were not words for *done it with my hands and felt nothing*. "I hadn't seen it close."

"That is not the thing I meant, and you know that is not the thing I meant, but I will let you have it for a moment." He came and stood beside her and looked up at the white-foaming tree with his lightning-blue eyes gone narrow against the brightness of it in the grey. "It is a beautiful tree. I will say that first, because it is true and because in a moment I am going to be unkind. It is the most beautiful thing you have done. More beautiful than the spears. More beautiful than the corridor." He let that sit. "Tell me what it cost you."

"Nothing."

"Say it again. Slower. Hear it."

"It cost me nothing." And hearing it, she did go cold, finally, that small bell starting up somewhere at the back of her skull, the one that had rung once in a burning school and again over a nameless name on a dead woman's chart, the bell that meant *this one, come back to this one*. "Lor-ar. There was no price at all."

"No," he agreed. "It did not. And that should frighten you more than if it had cost you a hand." He sat, folding the great length of himself down into the wet grass with an old dignity, so that his eyes came level with hers, which she understood was a courtesy and a warning both. "Listen to me, because I am about to tell you a thing I have spent three hundred years not having to tell anyone, and I would rather not have to say it twice. Nothing is free. You have been taught that the price of a thing is the strain of doing it, and that is a child's accounting, fit for carrying boards. The true cost is never where the doing is. It is where the doing is paid for. You did not pay for that tree." He looked up at it, white and impossible against the coming light. "So something did. Look again. Not at the tree. Look past it. Look at the rim of what you can see."

* * *

She did not want to.

She knew, before she did it, the way you know a stair is going to be there in the dark, that she did not want to look where he was telling her to look, and she made herself do it anyway, because she had promised herself a long time ago that she would not be a person who declined to look at the thing she had done.

She turned the sight out, past the camp, past the lattice she could hold in her attention, out to the place where her seeing thinned and failed, the edge of what she could perceive, the way the eye has an edge past which the world goes to a grey crowding of things half-seen. And at that edge, at the rim of everything, there was a place where the lattice did not so much end as run out, fray, give way to a dark that was not darkness because darkness is a thing and this was the absence of the thing, a nothing so complete that it had no quality at all, not cold, not black, not empty, only *not*. She had seen it once before, at the well, and had not let herself look at it for long, and had told no one, because there was nothing to tell. It was the place where the magic of the world stopped being. The far shore of the lattice. The other side of the source she was tied to, the side that took back what the source gave out, the great quiet ledger of the world balanced across a line that ran through the middle of everything.

And the line had moved.

She could not have proven it. She had no measure for it, no mark she'd left to check it against, nothing but the memory of having looked once and the looking now. But she had spent her whole life reading rooms by the one thing that did not fit, and what did not belong, here, at the rim of all seeing, was that the *not* had drawn back. A hair. A breath. The fullness of the world had leaned toward the rim by

exactly as much, she understood, the figure arriving unbidden and unwanted, as one rowan tree. The cost of the tree had not vanished. It had simply gone where her own account would never be touched, out past the edge, into the ledger, and the ledger had paid it the way a tide pays, by drawing back a fraction somewhere no one would ever stand to watch the water go.

"There," said Lor-ar, who could not see it, who was watching her face. "You found it."

"It moved," she said. Flatly. Her voice did the flat thing. "When I fixed the tree. Something out at the edge moved. It came in. Toward." She did not have the word. "Toward full."

"Yes." He did not ask her to explain it. That was the worst of it, that he did not need it explained, that he had known the shape of it before she had words. "It is the oldest law there is, little one, and your kind forgot it because your kind cannot see the edge to be reminded. You cannot make a thing whole. You can only move where the broken part lives. You moved the brokenness of that tree to the rim of the world, where nothing stands to mind it, and that was a cup of it, for a tree." He let her hold that. Then he closed his hand of it, gently, the way you close a wound. "Now. Do the arithmetic you do not want to do. You are not standing here to learn whether you can mend a tree."

* * *

She did the arithmetic.

She made herself do it standing up, in the grey light, with the impossible white tree foaming behind her and the small spent place in the lattice gone quiet and right, and she did it the way she did everything she was afraid of, by naming it exactly and refusing to let it be larger or smaller than it was.

One tree. One cup. One hair's-breadth lean of the *not* toward full, out at the edge where no one would ever feel it.

And the severing was not one tree. She had taken this thought out once before, in the dark the night Alice's name came back. She had looked at its size and banked it unsure, because she could not yet swear it was a thing she could truly do, and a thing of that weight is not a thing you turn loose on a guess. The tree had just taken the guess out of it, for good, and what was left in its place was no longer a thought she could bank and call unsure but a fact she would have to live beside. The severing was every living core there was, every person walking the lanes behind her and every person in the city that wanted her dead and every person who had never heard of either, six hundred years of people burning on half their wick and never told the rest of it existed. She could mend it. She had just proven it, on a thing that had been all the way dead, which was harder than a living core that only needed its second half unsealed. She could find the seam that ran through all of them at once, the one great wound laid into the lattice the same way in everyone, and she could let it do what the tree had done, what it plainly wanted to do, which was close. Not one at a time. All at once. It would cost her, she understood now with a certainty that turned her stomach, almost nothing. It would cost her a furnace's cup. She would do it the way she had straightened the picture on the wall, her breath unchanged, her hands steady. And every core alive would come up whole in the space of a held breath, and not one of them would know why, or that anything had been done to them at all.

And the whole of that price would go to the rim.

Not a hair, then. Not a cup. She had no measure for what the whole of it would cost the ledger, what it would do to the *not* out past the edge of all seeing to pay for all of them at once, and the having-no-measure was itself the answer, because a thing you cannot measure is a thing you cannot be

sure you can afford. She would be spending a coin she could not count, drawn on an account she could not read, against a debt that would come due somewhere she would never have to stand and watch it land.

"I could do it now," she said. Out loud. To hear it, the way the tiger had made her hear *it cost me nothing*. "From here. This morning. I could mend every core in the world before the camp wakes up, and the war would be." She stopped, because that was not true, and she would not say untrue things even to be done with a sentence. "It wouldn't end the war. They'd still march. They'd still want me dead. But no one would ever again be told they were broken in a way they weren't, and that's the whole of it." She stopped again. "That's the whole thing. That's the thing the council that cut us was built to keep. I could take it down by hand. This morning. And it would cost me nothing I could feel."

"Yes," said Lor-ar.

"Tell me not to."

"No."

She looked at him.

"I will not tell you not to," the tiger said, and there was no dryness in it now, none of the amusement, only the great old level weight of a thing that had watched the world for three hundred years and learned that the watching did not give it the right to choose. "That is not my bond and it is not my burden and I will not lift it off you by pretending I have the answer, because I do not, and a creature who hands you a clean answer to that question is either a fool or selling you something. I can tell you the cost is real. I have told you. I can tell you it falls where you will never have to pay it, which makes it the most dangerous kind of debt there is, the kind a good person talks themselves into paying forever because the bill never comes to their own door. And I can tell you that the last time a council decided a thing this size for everyone

alive without asking them, you spent a year fighting what they built." He stood, and shook the wet from his coat, and the matter of it was closed in the standing, the way he closed things. "I can tell you all of that. But I will not tell you no. The day I tell you no is the day I have decided I am wiser than you about your own soul, and I have buried enough of your kind to know that no one ever is."

* * *

They walked back as the light came up.

She did not mend anything else. There was a dead bird at the edge of the scrub, stiff in the grass. She looked at it. She felt the pull of how easy it would be, and the new cold knowledge of where its price would land, and she walked past it and left it dead, and that was when she first understood that the discipline she would need was not the discipline of effort. The hard things had taught her the discipline of effort and the hard things had lied. This was the discipline of restraint, of standing in front of a thing you could fix at no cost you could feel and choosing not to, over and over, because the cost was real and you simply could not see it. It was harder than carrying boards. It was the hardest thing she had ever been asked to do, and it looked, from the outside, like doing nothing at all.

The camp was waking. Smoke was up from the long fire and the children were being herded toward their morning lesson and Brutus's hammer had started somewhere off east, slow and even, the sound of a man rationing himself to last the season. And Amber was sitting on the cold ring of last night's fire with a cup of something hot held in both hands and her black ponytail still flat from sleeping on it, and she watched Viridia come in through the wards with the particular stillness Amber had instead of a careful face. It

was not stillness at all. It was the held breath before a question.

"You went out," Amber said.

"I went out."

"You went out before the light, without the dragon, with the tiger, which is the exact combination of facts a person assembles when they're going somewhere to find out a thing they don't want anybody arguing about." She blew on the cup. "I'm not arguing. I'm noting. There's a difference. The bun-woman taught it to me. Noting is when you say the thing out loud so the other person knows you saw it and then you let them decide what to do with having been seen." She drank. "So. Noted. You've got the road face on. Worse than yesterday. Yesterday you had the road face. Today you've got the road face plus a thing behind it the size of something I can't see all of." She stopped, and for once the joke did not arrive to finish the sentence, and she looked at her friend over the rim of the cup with the armor off her eyes entirely, the real damage and the real love both showing the way they only showed when she forgot to ration them. "Vee. What did you go out there and find out you could do."

And Viridia, who had let no one see her do anything since the morning the world ended, who had spent a year deciding exactly who got to see what, stood in the waking camp and weighed the question, and did not lie, and did not answer it either.

"Something I won't be doing yet," she said.

"Yet."

"Yet."

"That's the second yet in two days. You're handing out yet's like they're free." Amber set the cup down on the cold stone and stood, and she did the thing she did when she had decided to be serious, which was to stop ticking points and simply stand square. "I'll say this once and then leave it

alone, because you've got that look and the bun-woman says you can't pour into a closed jar. So. Once." She held up one finger, the black nail chipped. "Whatever it is you found out you could do — and I can see on you that it's big, it's the biggest one yet, you walked back in through those wards carrying it the way you carry the heavy ones, low and quiet and braced — whatever it is. Promise me you'll try the small doors first." She did not smile. "You're always reaching for the wall. Ever since the corridor. You reach for the thing that ends it all at once because the slow things hurt to watch. I get it. I do the same with stairs. But the small doors, Vee. The slow careful awful little doors. Try those till there's not one of them left. *Then* you can scare me."

The thing under Viridia's ribs, the banked thing, the unforgivable thing she had now held in her hands as a green tree and put back down, went quiet at that. Not because she had silenced it, but because a smaller thing had stepped in front of it again, something nearer and lower and possible, a thing with a door in it: the man Lightwell had marked but never struck, the one maybe she had left in the ground for whoever came after.

"There's a door," Viridia said. "I found it yesterday. In Lightwell's papers. A man in the Conclave who never wanted this war. She left a way to reach him." She looked toward the meeting house, where Jazen would already be up, already at the slow careful business of opening the road to the open circle, two of the days they did not have spent on a maybe. "Jazen's setting it up. I'm going to send the first message today. The true one. Proof the severing was deliberate, and the whole gift offered freely, to anyone who'll take it, not." She stopped, and did not say *not pushed into all of them at once before the camp wakes up*, though it was the end of the sentence and they both heard the shape of it. "Offered. Not

imposed. That's the small door. I'm going to spend every day there is on it before I look again at the other thing."

Amber let out a breath she had plainly been holding since the wards. "Okay," she said. And then, because she was Amber, and could not let a serious moment leave the room without an escort: "Okay. Good. Send your nice letter to your reasonable man. Look at you. A diplomat. The bun-woman'll cry." She picked her cup back up. "What's the other thing, then. The wall thing. The one behind the road face."

"Later."

"Later." Amber turned the word over and decided not to push it, which from her was a discipline as hard as anything Viridia did with her own face, and she went back to her cup instead and let the question lie there between them in the cold morning, asked and unanswered and, for now, allowed to be both.

* * *

She wrote the message that afternoon at the children's empty board, once they had been cleared away from it, in Moravian and in the common hand both, so that it could be read by the man it was meant for and proven by the few who could read the older script. She wrote it carefully. She wrote it true. She set out what the severing was and that it had been done on purpose, six hundred years gone, by people who had decided a thing for everyone alive without asking. Without naming herself, she set out that it could be undone, freely, for any who wished it, a gift offered and not a thing pushed into them in the dark. And she signed it with the mark Lightwell had left on the back of the note, the open circle, the circle not closed, the sign that meant *would hear it, if it came from the right mouth*. She read it three times. She did not let her hand shake. And she folded it and gave it to Jazen, who took it the way he took everything that had his

mother's marks in it, with careful hands, and let his eyes rest on the unjoined mark a moment too long, and said, "She'd have liked that you used her sign," and went to send it down the slow careful dark toward a man who might listen, two days' travel and a hope.

Then she went out alone, before the light failed, back to the clearing past the wards, because she had to see it once more in her own eyes and not just in the ledger at the back of her mind, where it had already been written down and shelved.

The rowan stood where she had left it. White and foaming and out of season, alive in the middle of the dead scrub, beautiful, the most beautiful thing she had ever done. And out past it, at the rim of everything, where her sight thinned and failed and the lattice gave way to the *not* that was the far shore of the world, she could not tell any more whether the line had moved. She had no mark to check it against. She had looked once before the tree and once after, and now too much looking had blurred the once, and the *not* sat where the *not* sat, given nothing away, the way it gave nothing away, a ledger that did not show you its sums.

But she knew. That was the thing she carried back through the darkening wards, past Hiram grey against the anchor-post on the last of his wick, past Mirelle's window where the day's lesson had given over to the older song, into the bare little room that was hers now. She knew the cost was real and she knew it went where her own account would never be touched, and she knew that one morning, if every door but the wall closed, she would stand in front of all the cores alive at once and find the seam that wanted to close, and let it, and her breath would not change.

She brought her core up to a coal and held, behind her eyes, the man Lightwell had marked, the unjoined circle, the slow careful door she meant to spend herself against before

she touched the wall, and she made herself a promise she was no longer certain she could keep, which was the only kind worth making.

The small doors first. Every one of them. Till there's not a single one left to knock on.

And only then the wall. And only if it's the wall or the bodies. And even then I will know, the whole time, exactly what it costs, and exactly that I will never be the one to pay it.

It was nearly full dark when the runner came down the lane to her door, out of breath, a boy of Brutus's making with a man's job in his hands. The line had answered already. Not the slow careful days they'd budgeted for. Hours. Whoever carried it had not trusted the slow courier road at all; it had come up the rail-wire, relayed station to station the way only urgent capital traffic moved, which was its own kind of warning. The man with the open circle had answered the same day, in his own hand, fast, the way a careful man answers only one kind of thing.

She unfolded it under the coal of her core, and read it once, and went very still.

It was three words long.

Who else knows.

CHAPTER SIX

The Window Narrows

Who else knows.

She had read it under the coal of her core the night before and gone still, and she had carried the three words through the rest of the dark and into the grey morning, and they had not worn smooth in the carrying. That was the thing about a true sentence. She turned it over by the one part of it that snagged, and the snag was that it was not fear. A frightened man finding her letter would have asked *is it real*, or *what do you want*, would have grasped for the edges of the thing before the thing itself. This man had asked the only question that mattered to someone deciding whether he could afford to be brave. He had already decided, in the hours it took to relay three words up the rail-wire station to station, that the cure might be true. And the next thing he needed before he risked one further inch of himself was how many other people stood on the ledge he was now standing on, because the size of a secret was the size of the rope it could hang you with.

Who else knows. It meant *I might*. It meant *if it is only you and me, I might*. The door Lady Lightwell had left her was not painted shut after all. There was a real room behind it, and a man in the room, and the man had already begun, against the whole grain of a careful life, to lean toward the latch.

It also meant the window was real, and small, and a man that careful did not lean toward a latch twice.

She had not answered yet. That was Jazen's to weigh with her, and Jazen had not slept either; she could see it on him across the council boards in the grey, the raw eyes worse, the close-cropped hair gone past untended. He had her message in front of him, gone down the wire and come back as three words, and he had not stopped looking at it, because she had signed it with his mother's sign, the unjoined circle, and the answer had come back to that same mark, so that in some way the paper on the table was the last conversation Lightwell would ever have, conducted after her death, by a girl using her sign.

* * *

The patrol came an hour before noon, and not the way patrols had been coming.

The ones before had drifted near and drifted off, a column that had stopped being warned away and wandered nearer than it knew, blind men feeling along a wall they could not see was a wall. This one came on a line. Viridia was at the boards when Ferro's whistle went up from the east, two short and one long, the scout's call that meant *seen and coming*, and she was on her feet before the third note ended. The cold working part had already done the only sum that mattered, which was that a patrol walking a straight heading at empty forest was a patrol that had been pointed.

"They've got a heading from somebody," Jazen said. He had come up out of his chair the same instant, and the grief was gone off his face the way water goes off a hot stone, leaving the flat hard thing under it that had decided the room at the gates. "They don't see the ward. They've been told to walk at it anyway." He was already for the door, the council breaking, Brutus's chair barking against the floor,

the silver-haired woman rising slow and straight and unfrightened. "Hiram's on the east screen. Hiram—" He stopped. He declined to finish the sentence, the way they all declined the ends of sentences here, and she had taken a week to understand it was not a habit but a wound, a whole village that had learned the ends of sentences were where the bad things lived. Hiram had been the wrong colour for days, and the east stretch was the thinnest skin of the whole box of air, and a man pouring himself out faster than he refilled was about to be asked to pour faster.

"I'll take the east rim," Viridia said.

"You'll stay where the children are."

"The children are in the centre, where the ward is thickest, with Mirelle, who'd die before she let a soldier past her table, and you know it." She had not raised her voice. Raising it spent something she would rather keep. "The east is where it thins. The east is where they come through if they come through. I'm the most useful thing this camp has, and that's where the use is." She was already past him into the lane, the lattice turning over behind her eyes whether she asked it to now or not, the camp a low banked glow and out at the east three thin burning cores holding the screen, one of them guttering low, Hiram, worst of the three. "Send Brutus's anchor-mages to the post. I'll hold the gap while Hiram holds the screen."

She did not wait for him to agree. She heard him not disagree, which from Jazen was the same thing, and went east through the waking fear of the lanes with her hand finding the spears at her back without being told.

* * *

She had four. She had carried four out of Hazel and four she still carried, the Damascus steel of them dark and watered with its folded grain, light and balanced to throw, and she

had learned that four was both a great many and not very many at all, depending entirely on how many men there were and how much of herself she was willing to spend.

That was the whole of the morning's problem. She had a furnace in her chest. She had a thing in her chest that could take a whole column of armed men and unmake the ground under them, that could reach through the lattice and find the seam in every one of their cores and break it, that could mend a dead tree and so could surely break a living man, and the cost of any of it to her would be a cup of the furnace, nothing she would feel. She could end the patrol the way she had straightened a picture on a wall in passing.

And she could not. Not because it was forbidden. Because the whole life of the camp was its hiddenness, and a girl lighting the east like a kiln, throwing the unmistakable signature of a whole merged core against a thin curtain of ward, would not save them from this patrol. It would tell the capital exactly where they were and exactly what they had, and the next thing to come would not be a patrol. The screen hid them from being found. If she used the furnace to win, she would do the finding herself.

So she would fight the way the camp could afford, which was small. Four spears and her two hands and the banked coal and not one flicker more, against however many men a heading had pointed at a wall.

She reached the rim where Hiram knelt against the anchor-post, both palms to the wood, his head down, the grey of him gone past grey into the white of a thing wrung nearly out, and she did not ask him how he was, because she knew what it cost to answer that question. She set her back to the post beside him, facing out, and watched the column come through the shiver of the air, through the painted stillness that was not the forest at all but only the ward seen from within.

* * *

They came in a loose double file out of the trees, twelve of them, dark green with the gold piping that meant somebody's chosen and not a scratch levy, and at their head walked a man who was not a soldier. He walked the way a man walks when his eyes are doing the work, slow, his head turning, and over his eyes he wore a thing that caught the grey light wrong, a frame, lenses, and Viridia went cold and quiet at the sight because she knew them. The glasses of true seeing. The kind the Chancellor wore. The kind that saw through a curtain to the thing behind it.

"He'll read the wards in a hundred paces," she said, flat, to Hiram, to herself. "He's not a finder. He's a seer. Somebody up the line spent real glasses on a rumour."

Hiram did not lift his head. "Then he reads them." His voice was the voice of the white in his face, thin and far off, spoken from a long way down a hole he dug himself into with every breath. "I can hold against eyes that don't know to look. Not against eyes that do. The moment he reads it true the box goes thin where I'm thin and they walk straight in at the sag." He didn't finish; nobody here finished. "If they're stopped before he reads it, I can draw the ward tight over the rest of you and you fall back to the centre and we move tonight in the dark while they're still arguing what they thought they saw. Buy me that and I hold a little longer."

"How long can you hold."

"Long enough." It was a lie, and the kind a brave man tells, where the bravery is in the lie itself, and she let him have it, because there are lies that bear weight and you do not kick them out from under a man holding up a roof with his body.

The seer stopped at the hundred-pace line where the light went faintly wrong. He tilted his head. He raised a hand

and the column halted behind him, and she watched him read the wards true through the spending of one careful man's eyes. And the morning stopped being a question of whether they would be found and became a question of how many men she could put down before the rest ran home to report exactly where the camp was, and that it had a girl in it who could do the thing she must on no account let them see.

No. They would not report that, because she would not show it. She would show them four spears and a child fighting small. That was the whole of the discipline now. Not effort. Restraint: standing before a furnace she could open and choosing the steel instead, again and again, while men died who would not die if she only opened her hand.

She let the seer take three steps further into his certainty.

Then she stepped out through the curtain into the false forest, a slight silver-blond girl with a dark spear already turning loose in her grip, and gave him the one true thing she could afford to show, which was that the camp was defended.

* * *

The first spear took the seer in the meat of the shoulder before he had finished being surprised that the wards had a girl in front of them, and it spun him down into the leaf-litter with the lenses flying off his face into the brush. That was the entire plan. Blind the eyes that could read the curtain, then survive the next two minutes.

The column came apart into men the way columns always did. There was time, in the cold clear part, to be glad they were soldiers and not a mob, because soldiers came at you in an order you could read and a mob came at you like weather, all at once. She marked the order in the sliver of time she had. Two going wide on the left to flank, three centre coming straight, the rest hanging back the way men

hang back before they have decided the girl is the threat. She chose her spending the way she had been taught, which was to make the back rank decide.

The second spear went into the centre and dropped the foremost of the three before he had closed half the ground, and she did not watch him fall, because watching them fall was a luxury and she had two left. The flankers were the danger. She let them think the wide move had worked and went not away from them but at the nearer one, inside the swing of his blade where a tall man's reach turns against him, and drove the third spear up under his ribs at a range too close to throw, and felt it go in, and felt the wrongness of it her hands always knew a half-beat ahead of her. She turned him as he dropped so his body took the other flanker's stroke meant for her.

One spear left. Two still up in the centre, the back rank deciding, the seer clawing in the leaves for his lost glasses with his good arm.

She did not throw the last one. A spear thrown was a spear gone, and a spear gone was the furnace one decision nearer, the open hand one step closer, and she would not be cornered into the only thing she could not afford. She kept it in her fist and went at the two as a thing to thrust, and fought them the way a slight person fights two larger ones, by never being where the last swing had decided she would be, by spending footwork instead of force, tiring them and frightening them in the order that suited her. And it cost her. That was the thing she had refused to know until she was inside it. Fighting honest, with steel and her own two arms and a body that was fine-boned and five foot five and tired, against grown men in armour, cost her in a coin she could feel: sweat, breath, the burn climbing her arms, the cold certainty that this was a thing she could lose. The furnace sat banked the whole time, untouched, a cup of which would

have ended it in a breath, and the not-touching was a weight she carried in both arms while the men tried to kill her.

She put one down with the butt of the spear across his temple, and the last broke, the back rank breaking with him, four of the twelve down and the seer blinded and the rest deciding all at once that the rumour was true and had spears and they would rather tell someone than die confirming it. They went back into the trees dragging two of their own, leaving two and the seer.

She walked to him and stood over him while he stopped clawing for the glasses and went still, a man who had read the curtain true and was now reading the girl true and finding her worse.

She did not kill him. She could not afford to and did not want to, and for once the two pointed the same way. A blinded seer who ran home with a story about a girl and four spears was a story the capital could fit into the world it already believed. A dead seer was a question. She picked the bent frame out of the brush, one lens starred, and crushed the starred lens under her heel to glass dust in the leaf-mould, and left him the rest and the long walk home.

"Tell them a girl held the wood," she said. The flat voice. "Not what else you saw. You won't be believed, and you'll be the man who panicked. A girl held the wood with spears. That part's true."

She turned her back on him, which she would not have done a year ago, and went in through the curtain, and only when she was out of his sight did she let herself feel the thing she had held off the whole fight, which was the four men.

* * *

Four down, two dead by her hand, two more she did not count too closely, and she stood inside the ward with the last

spear in her grip and her arms shaking now that they were allowed to, and the cold clear part did the arithmetic it had been waiting on.

If she had opened her hand, none of them would have died.

That was the new and terrible shape of the thing Lor-ar had shown her at the tree. She could have stepped through the curtain and reached out and simply *stopped* them, all twelve, no blade, no body in the leaves, a cup of the furnace spent and a debt sent out to the rim where no living soul would be standing to see the water draw back, and not one of those men would be dead. She had killed them to keep a secret. She had spent their lives to keep the camp hidden, and the camp was hidden, and the lives were spent, and the sum was not the comfortable kind where the cost lands on the guilty. Two of those men had families who would learn, in a week, that their soldier had not come home from a patrol against a rumour. They had been pointed at a wall by someone up the line and walked at it because that was the work, and she had killed them with her own arms to avoid spending a thing she would never feel, and the part of her that did the sums would not let her round it off.

This was the cost the tiger had not named, because she had not yet earned the right to feel it. Not the rim. Not the ledger out beyond the limit of all seeing. This. Four men, dead, because keeping herself hidden was worth their lives to her, and she had decided that, in the instant she chose the steel, and she would decide it again, and the deciding-again was the war.

She did not weep. There was no one to see, and she held to the practice regardless, and there was a thing past the practice now: the grief of it would not come up as water. It came up as arithmetic, cold and exact, four men, two families, a coin she could feel paid to save a coin she could

not, and that was its own kind of weeping, the kind that did not show on a face and did not spend until it had to. She banked it the way she banked the fire, because Hiram was still at the post, and the post was the next thing.

* * *

He had not fallen. That was the first thing she saw, and the second was that he might have been better off if he had.

He was on his knees against the post with both hands to the wood and his head laid against it, and there was a blade in him. One of the flankers, she understood, in the moment she had been turned away, in the chaos of the column coming apart, had got past her wide enough to reach the rim, and Hiram, who could not take his hands off the wood to defend himself without dropping the box over two hundred people, had taken the blade rather than let go. It had gone in under his collarbone and the soldier had not had time to drive it home or pull it free before whatever happened to that soldier happened. It stood there yet, the green-wrapped grip of it out from his chest, and he was holding the screen anyway, white as the underside of a leaf, lips moving on the slow shape of the working, feeding the post the last of a wick she could see through the sight guttering toward nothing.

"Hiram." She was on her knees beside him. "Let go. They've run. Let me—"

"Pull it tight first." His eyes were open and not seeing much. "Help me pull it tight. The seer saw the sag. If I let go now the sag stays where he saw it. Help me draw it taut across the whole of us so the camp isn't where they leave it." His hand came off the wood and found her wrist and gripped with a strength that frightened her, coming out of a body that white. "You can see it. I've watched you not-look at things for a week, girl, the way you not-look at what you can

see fine. Put your hands on the post. Pull it tight with me and then I'll let go."

She did not tell him no. She set her hands on the post beside his and brought the sight up, and saw the screen as he saw it, a thin taut skin of intent stretched over the camp from three burning points, one his and nearly out, and the sag, a slack place over the east where his core had thinned and the skin drooped, the exact place the seer had read. And she did the only thing the camp could afford, which was not to flood the screen with the furnace and light herself like the kiln she could not be, but to do what Hiram did, small and hard, to lend a thread of herself banked so low it would read to any eyes as one more tired ward-mage and not as the thing she was. He felt the help come. His guttering wick took it and steadied, and together, the dying man and the girl holding her furnace shut with both hands, they drew the slack skin tight over the sag until the camp was no longer where the seer had left it.

"There," Hiram said, and let go.

He let go of all of it at once, and his hands came off the wood, and he sagged, and the screen did not drop because she had it now, banked and thin and held. Brutus reached them at last with two anchor-mages pelting up the lane, Jazen behind, and hands lifted Hiram off the post and laid him in the leaf-litter with the blade still standing in him because nobody dared draw it, and Viridia knelt with her palms to the wood holding the box closed over two hundred people while the healer ran and the man who had held it two years lay white at the foot of the post he had given himself to.

He was not dead. The sight showed her that, the wick gone low but not out. But he was the wrong colour past the wrong colour now, and there was a blade in him, and the screen he had carried two years had passed in one morning to a girl who could not hold it long without either tiring like a

mortal or burning like a beacon, and the camp had learned, all in an hour, that its three pillars were two and a child.

* * *

The council did not sit at the boards that evening. They stood, in the meeting house, around Hiram's pallet, because the healer had drawn the blade and packed the wound and said the thing healers say when they mean *maybe*, and nobody wanted to sit comfortably while one of the three fought for the wick of himself on the floor.

Viridia stood against the back wall, small, watchful, and watched them all be right and the rightness have nowhere to go.

"He read it true." Jazen's voice was the flat hard thing all the way through now; the grief would not come back until there was room for it. "A seer with the Chancellor's own glasses, sent at a rumour, and he read the wards before Viridia put him down. That tells us two things and I'll say them plain. One. They believe the rumour now. Somebody high enough to spend true-glasses believes there's a camp, and a girl. Two. They know there's something here worth a seer. He'll go home blinded and panicked and they'll discount half of what he says, but not that the wood was held. They'll come back. Not a patrol. A column. Days. Maybe less."

"And the screen is a girl and two tired men." The silver-haired woman, cold and exact, saying the sum none of them wanted to be the one to say. "Hiram does not hold a ward again this season. Not perhaps ever. I am sorry to say it over his own body, but he'd say it himself if he could, and we are past the kindness of pretending. We hid two years on three pillars. We cannot hide on two and a child who cannot use what she has without telling them where she stands. The arithmetic changed this morning. We are not deciding

whether to march. We are deciding whether we march before they come, or die deciding."

Brutus said nothing. He stood with his big arms folded and looked at Hiram on the pallet, at the wall he could not rebuild board by board, and counted, the way he counted everything, in winters it would see, and reached a number he did not like.

"How long can the wards hold," Coram asked, soft as ever, the question put gently to the room and to no one.

And they all looked, without meaning to, at the girl by the wall, because the girl was one of the wards now, and Viridia understood there was no answer she could give that was not also a sentence on something.

"Days," she said. "Banked low enough that I won't be read, I can lend the post enough to hold the skin tight. But I can't hold it tight and do anything else, and I can't do it forever, and the moment I have to do anything else"—she let it go unfinished the way they did, and then finished it anyway, because she had sworn once that she would not be a person who declined to name the thing she had done—"the moment I fight, or save someone, or am anything but a third tired ward-mage, the skin sags where I am, and a seer reads it. I bought us today with four men and a crushed lens. I can buy a few more days the same way. I can't buy a season. Hiram bought you two years. I can only be a girl pretending to be Hiram, and the pretending has a bottom."

Quiet. On the pallet Hiram breathed, slow, the wick low. Mella's locket clicked once and stopped. And Viridia, by the wall, felt the window. That was the only word for it. She had felt the count since the first morning, a clock ticking somewhere in a still house, but a count ran one way at one speed, and this was a thing closing, a gap narrowing hour by hour, the bloodless answer and the bodies swinging toward each other like the two leaves of a door. The morning had

been the hinge. Before it the window had been a thing she could spend slow careful days against, a letter down a wire and a reasonable man two days off. After it the window had a bottom and a closing rate, and the man behind the unjoined circle had wanted to know who else stood where he stood, which meant he would lean toward the latch exactly once, and the patrol had walked a heading, which meant the column was already gathering, and the screen was a girl now, which meant the days she could buy were days she spent and not days she had.

At the tree she had decided to spend whatever days she was given on the open road before she reached for the thing that had no door in it. She had not understood, at the tree, how few days there were going to be. She understood it by the wall, with a dying man's breath in the room and four families not yet told. The window was not a thing to spend at her leisure. It was a thing she would have to throw herself into before it shut, and the throwing had to start tonight, because a careful man who has counted his fellow-conspirators by return wire will not stay leaned toward a latch while an army assembles at the door he might open.

* * *

Jazen walked her out when the council broke, into the dark, and did not perform anything for her, which she valued in him more than kindness.

"You bought us the day." He stopped where the lane ran out and the edge of the ward shivered, the place they had stood the first evening, when he told her of the line that might bring word of Alice; she filed that, that they had stood here at the start of a hope and stood here now at the thing the hope had narrowed to. "I won't pretend it cost nothing. Four men is four men. But you bought us the day, you did it

small, and you kept what you are off that seer's last good eye. I know what that cost too. I've spent my life keeping what I am off people, and the only cost nobody can see is the cost of holding it in." He looked out toward the painted trees where a column was being readied around a blinded man's story. "Hiram might live. The healer says maybe. The camp can't. Not here. We march. I'm saying it at the morning council and there'll be no arguing it. The arithmetic made the argument for us."

"How long until you march."

"Five days to ready two hundred people for a road, sixty of them children and one a man with a blade-hole under his collarbone. Less if they come first." Five days. Maybe three. After that they were walking toward the capital ready or not, because the other choice was dying in the box, and he would rather choose the road.

Five days. Maybe three. The window had a number now, and the number was the march, which meant the bloodless answer and the bodies were not two doors but one, the same door, closing at the speed of an army getting to its feet, and she had until it shut.

She did the sum she did not want to do, standing in the dark with him, and then did the thing the sum told her, which was the hardest small door of all, harder than the letter, because the letter had been words sent down a wire and this was a thing she would have to put her own body into.

"Jazen." She held the careful face, and only her breath changed, the one tell she allowed, and she was glad of the dark that hid even that. "He answered. The open circle. He asked who else knows. That isn't fear. That's a man counting how far he can lean. He'll lean once. If we wait for the slow road the column comes before he's done counting, and the door shuts with him still on the safe side, and then there's

nothing left but the march and the walls and the dead." She made herself say it plainly. "I want to go to him. Not a letter. Me. While there's still a man leaning toward a latch and a few days before it shuts. I can go where shadow reaches that I've stood, and his papers say where he is. Let me try to reach the capital's moderates myself, in person, before we put two hundred people on a road toward a wall. It's the last small door. Let me spend myself against it before there's nothing left to spend it on but a war."

Jazen was quiet a long time in the dark, looking at her, the resistance leader and the girl who could end the wound beneath the war and would not, yet, while one door stood open. Out beyond the shiver the painted trees stood too still, and somewhere past them a column was gathering around a story about a girl who held the wood, and behind them in the meeting house a man who had given two years to the box of air breathed slow on a pallet with almost nothing left to burn, and the window narrowed by exactly the width of the silence before Jazen answered.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What She Tries First

She sent herself out into the world twice that day, and by two roads that should not have cost the same, and did.

The first way was words. You wrote the truth on a sheet small enough to carry. You folded it. You let it go out of your hands into the slow dark of the courier roads and the fast dark of the wire, and after that the truth belonged to other people and what they did with it was theirs. She had done that already, with the unjoined mark. It had cost her one folded sheet and a held breath, and the cost had not arrived until the answer came back three words long. That was the way of a thing sent in words. The price came later, by return.

The second way was her own body, walked through a place where the world had a seam in it, out the far side into somewhere she had stood once and could go again. That spent a swallow of the furnace she would not feel, and she had learned by now to be afraid of what asked nothing of her.

She did both before the day was out, the letter and the walking, the word out into the world of men and her own two feet onto stone where a dragon waited, and she would spend her life after unable to say which had been the brave one.

* * *

She wrote the second message at the children's board in the grey after Hiram's morning, when the slates were cleared and the long table empty and Mirelle gone to her baby. The first had been the careful overture, the offering laid open; this one had to answer a man who had already leaned, and so cautious a man would not risk leaning a second time, and so every word of it was a step on a stair she could not see the bottom of.

Who else knows.

She had turned the three words over for a day now, and she knew what they were. They were not a question about danger. They were a question about weight. The man who had drawn that unjoined mark was counting the rope the secret could hang him with, and the size of his answer would be the size of the lie she told him now, and she would not tell him a lie. That was the size of it. She could write *no one but us* and make the rope short and make him brave, and the day the rope turned out longer than she'd said, she would have spent his courage on a falsehood and earned the thing she least wanted, which was a moderate who learned that the dark mages lied the way the capital had always told him they did.

So she wrote the true thing, which was harder and which was a worse-shaped rope.

A leader and a council. Fewer than ten who could name you. None who would. The proof of the cure is real and I will put it in your own hands before you risk an inch you do not choose to risk. The offer stands: the whole gift, freely, to any who will have it, imposed on no one. I do not need your faith. I need a room and an hour and your eyes on the proof. You decide everything after.

She checked it over, slow, twice and once again. Her hand stayed steady. She wrote it in the common hand for him and a line of it in Moravian for the few who could prove the script was old, and she signed it with the unjoined circle,

Lightwell's mark, the circle left open, *would hear it if it came from the right mouth*. And she sat a moment with the strangeness of it: that she was conducting, on a child's board, in a dead woman's sign, the most important conversation of her life with a man whose face she had never seen. That the whole of it turned on whether a careful stranger believed a girl he did not know about a thing his entire world swore was impossible.

Somewhere behind the weight of it, the part of her that only ever counted made its quiet objection: she had given him the truth, and the truth made the rope longer, and a longer rope might be exactly the thing that frightened him off the latch. She let it object. She had settled it within herself long since: better to lose a man with the truth than keep him with a lie, because a man kept with a lie was a man who would let go the moment the lie did.

She carried it to Jazen at the hall, where he sat by Hiram's pallet with his mother's papers spread on his knees and had plainly not slept. He took it. He read it. His eyes held on the unjoined mark a beat past what reading it needed, the way they always did, and this time he did not speak of how his mother would have approved, because there was a man dying on the floor between them and even Jazen's grief knew its hour.

"You told him the number," Jazen said.

"I told him the truth of the number."

"It's a worse number than *no one*."

"It's the true one. He'll know I didn't make it small for him. A man that careful would rather have a long rope he can trust than a short one he can't." She watched him fold it. "Send it the same way the last one came. Up the wire. We don't have the days for the slow road, and he already broke cover to use the fast one, which means he's decided the slow road is worse than being seen on the fast."

Jazen regarded her a moment, the resistance leader and the slip of a girl who had just out-reasoned his own line-craft, and there was a thing in his raw eyes that was not quite a smile and was certainly grief and was, underneath both, something close to respect for a tool he had not known he had. "It'll go before noon," he said. "And then we wait on a careful man, with the camp on a clock, while I get two hundred people ready for a road I don't want to walk. That's our morning." He set the paper on the small stack of his mother's papers, where it looked, for a moment, like one more thing Lightwell had left half-finished for someone else to carry. "You should rest before the other thing."

"What other thing."

"The thing you're not asking me about because you've already decided to do it." He did not look up from the papers. "You want to go to the dragons. You've wanted it since the patrol. You think there's a thing they know that we don't, and you're not wrong, and you'd rather I came so it isn't a girl alone with two creatures the size of barns." He turned a page. "I'll come. Brutus can hold the morning. But Viridia." Now he looked up. "We're going to ask them about a war. Be ready for the answer to be the kind dragons give."

* * *

She had stood on the dragons' ground exactly once, weeks ago now, in the high cold place Drake had brought Raizen home to, and once was enough. Shadow-walking took her where shadow reached that she had stood, and she had stood on a windy ledge of black rock under a sky too big, and so the shadow could reach it, and so she could go.

She took Jazen's hand, which he gave without performing anything about it, and she found the seam in the dim doorway of the hall where the shadow of the lintel lay long across the floor, and she walked them both into it.

The going was one held breath and a darkness that was not darkness, and then it was wind. A flood of wind, and a flood of sky, and the particular cold of a height where the air has given up most of what makes it kind, and under their feet black rock streaked white with old droppings and scored with claw-marks the length of a man. Jazen staggered and caught himself and said a soft word she chose not to hear, and stood very still the way people stood still on edges, and looked out, and then made the mistake of looking up.

Drake was already there.

He had been there before they arrived. She understood that the way she understood the mountain had been there; he was simply a feature of the place that happened to be alive. Six millennia had made him less a creature than a country. He was pitch black. Black past black. The black of a thing that ate the light that touched it and gave none of it back, and he lay along the ridge above them with his vast head lowered on a forearm thicker than a house, one eye open. The eye was the colour of a banked coal and older than anything Viridia had ever looked into, which was saying a thing, because she had looked into Lor-ar.

"The small one comes on her feet," Drake said. His voice was not loud. That was the terror of it. It was low and it was even and it went through the rock and into the soles of her boots and up the bones of her legs, and she understood that when Drake chose to be loud the mountain would do it for him. "Through the dark, the way the dead come. I felt you cross. Few things still surprise me. You are one." The coal eye moved to Jazen and dismissed him in the same motion, not with contempt but with the economy of a thing that had only so many centuries left and would not spend one on a man. "And you bring the leader of the rabbits."

"He's my friend," Viridia said.

"He is your warren-mate. It is not the same and you will learn it." Drake's head lifted, slow, a cliff deciding to move, and the wind changed where he moved it. "My son is below, hunting. He felt you the instant you arrived; he is already climbing; you will not get three sentences out before he is on you, so say the thing you came to say while there is quiet, because there will not be quiet long."

She had not expected him to feel Raizen feel her. She filed it, the way the bond ran out from her to the dragon and out again from the dragon to his father, a thing wired into the world she had only stood at the edge of. The warm thread under her breastbone had pulled tight the moment her feet touched the rock, and now it was singing, taut and bright and *coming*, and she had to set a hand against her own chest to keep the joy of it from doing something to her face in front of a creature six thousand years old.

"I came to ask you about a war," she said.

"I know what you came to ask." Drake settled his vast body lower against the ridge, and a small avalanche of scree went down the slope and was gone before it made a sound she could hear. "You came because the rabbits are about to walk into the wolves, and you have a thing in your chest that could end it, and someone wise has told you that the price of the thing falls where you cannot see it, and now you cannot sleep. You came to a creature who has watched six hundred of your years go by to ask whether you should pay a debt you cannot read." The coal eye did not blink. "You came to the wrong dragon for comfort. You should have brought your tiger. He lies."

* * *

Far off and below, where she could not see, a rumour ran up the fast wire instead of down the courier road, and a man in

a grey office in the capital read three words and then read them again.

She did not see this. No one in the camp saw it. But it happened while she stood on the black rock, and the two things ran alongside each other the whole of that day like a pair of rails, the message going out into the human dark and the girl gone up into the cold, and neither knew the speed of the other.

The man with the open circle had her first overture in a drawer he locked with his own key. He had asked *who else knows*, and the asking had cost him a night's sleep, and the answer that would come back to him — *a leader and a council, fewer than ten, none who would name you* — had not yet arrived; it was still a folded thing in Jazen's careful hands, not yet given to the wire. So the man sat with a question he had asked and no answer yet. It was the worst part of any bargain, the part where you have leaned and not been caught and do not know whether what comes back up the wire will be a hand or a blade. Careful men do not survive that part well. He had a wife. He had a post he had spent thirty years not losing. He had a thing in him, small and stubborn and thirty years buried, that had drawn an open circle in the margin of a dead woman's note because some part of him had never believed the war was righteous, and he hated that thing now, the way you hate the part of you that is about to cost you everything.

She did not know any of that. She would learn the shape of it only by what came back. That was the way of the first kind of sending. You spoke into the dark and the dark decided when to speak back.

* * *

Raizen came over the ridge like the dawn arriving all at once.

She felt him a breath before she saw him, the thread going from taut to *home* in a snap that put a sound out of her she did not make on purpose, a small broken thing she would have been ashamed of in front of anyone but these, and then he was up over the black rock in a wash of light, because Raizen was made of light the way his father was made of its absence. Prismatic, every scale a different fire, the whole of him a thing that should not have been able to land softly and landed softly anyway, folding his wings with a care that was entirely for her, settling his great bright head down to her level on the rock so that his eye, which held all the colours there were, came level with her green ones.

You came, he said, and he said it in the bond and out loud both, because he could speak now, and the speaking was still new enough to him that he used it the way a child uses a new word, more than he needed to, for the joy of it. *I felt you cross the dark. I have been telling Father for a week that you would come and he said I was a hatchling and now you are here and I am right.* A pause, the bright eye searching her face, the new sentences coming slower, more careful, finding the harder thing under the joy. *You are tired. You are tired in the place I cannot reach. What has happened to you, Viridia.*

"A man held a ward with a blade in him," she said, because she would not lie to him either, and because the bond would have shown him the shape of it anyway. "And I killed four men with my hands to keep from showing them what I am, and the not-showing is the work now. And the window is closing. And I came to ask your father a thing I'm afraid of the answer to." She laid her open palm to the bright scale of his jaw, and the warmth of him came up through her hand, and she allowed herself one breath of it, the one true thing she carried unhidden, and then she folded it down the way she folded everything, because there was a war on the rock with them and the war did not pause for a girl and her

dragon. "I missed you," she said, which was the smallest and truest of all of it.

I know, Raizen said. I carried the missing too. It is heavier on legs than on wings. And then, because he was young and could not hold a serious thing longer than its weight required, Your friend is going to fall off the mountain.

Jazen, who had been standing very still and very upright and very near the edge for the length of the reunion, with the expression of a man being polite at the apocalypse, said, "I am fine."

"You are not," said a new voice, and it came up the far slope on a wind that smelled suddenly of furnace, of forge, of the inside of a kiln, and Varissa came over the ridge breathing fire.

* * *

She was scarlet where Drake was black. A brilliant burning red, smaller than her mate and somehow more frightening for it, the way a struck match is more frightening in a dry room than a bonfire in a pit. She did not lie along the ridge the way Drake did. She came down onto the rock between Raizen and the two strangers in a single dropping rush and put her body, all of it, between her child and the girl, and she breathed flame as she landed, a low rolling line of it across the black rock that did not touch any of them and was not meant to, a thing said in fire instead of words, and what it said was *mine*.

"Mother," Raizen said.

"Be quiet." Varissa did not look at him. She looked at Viridia, and her eyes were the gold-white centre of a flame, and there was nothing old in them the way there was in Drake's; there was only fierce and present and now. "You. The bonded one. The half-grown human thing my son has tied his whole life to, so that the day you die, he dies, do you

understand that, child, do you understand what a True-Bond is, it is not your little summoned cat that goes home when the spell tires. It is his life poured into yours. He gave it. I could not stop him. I have hated you for a year for letting him." She breathed again, smaller, the flame guttering at the edge of her jaw. "And now you come walking through the dark with a war on your back, *tired in the place he cannot reach*, and you ask his father to help you do a thing that may kill you, and if it kills you it kills my son, and you did not think of that, did you, because you are a child and you think the only life on your ledger is your own."

The cold working part did the arithmetic well before the slap of it landed, and the arithmetic was that Varissa was right. She had stood at the rim of all seeing and weighed the cost of the rebirth as a thing that fell on the world and on her own unreadable account, and she had not once, not once, put Raizen on the ledger, the dragon whose life ran into hers, who would go out like a snuffed coal the day she spent herself too far. She had done the sum with a piece missing because the missing piece was the one she could not bear to look at.

"No," Viridia said. The flat voice. The voice did the flat thing. "I didn't think of it. You're right. I weighed my own life and the world's and I left him off the sheet because—" She stopped. She did not let her hand find the dark-blue stone at her throat, though it wanted to. "Because if I put him on the sheet, I can't do any of it. I can't fight the patrol. I can't hold the ward. I can't reach for the cure if it comes to that. Every brave thing I do spends a thing that's also his now, and if I let myself feel that, I'll be a girl who can't move." She made herself meet the gold-white eye. "So I left him off. That's the true answer. It's not a good one. You can hate me more for it if you want. It won't make it less true and it won't make me

stop, because the only other choice is letting two hundred people die so my ledger stays simple, and I won't."

The rock was very quiet. Even the wind seemed to wait. Jazen had gone still in a different way now, not the politeness of a man near an edge, but the stillness of a man watching a thing he would not have believed if told. Raizen made a low rumble that was not words, a sound out of the chest, and pressed the side of his bright head against his mother's scarlet flank, and Varissa, fierce Varissa, did not move him away.

"There," said Drake, from the ridge, in his low even mountain voice. "Now she has said the true thing, Varissa. Leave her the rest of her skin. She carries the weight you wanted her to carry. I can hear it on her. She is not a child who left him off the sheet because she did not love him. She is a child who left him off the sheet because she loves him too much to do the arithmetic, which is a thing you and I have done over a grave, you and I both, so come down off your fire."

Varissa's flame went out. Not all at once. It guttered, and shrank, and was a glow at the edge of her jaw, and then it was nothing, and she folded down onto the rock beside her son with a sound like a forge being banked, and she said, low, to Viridia, "If you spend him, I will find you in whatever comes after, and there will not be enough of you left to bond to anything ever again. That is a mother's promise. Now sit down. You are swaying and it offends me to watch a thing too tired to stand pretend it is fine."

Viridia sat down on the cold rock. It was easier, here as everywhere, to obey someone who had just named the true thing.

* * *

It was Drake who spoke of the dead.

He did it the way he did everything, from a height, slow, the words coming down the slope like the scree, and he did not perform the grief and he did not hide it; he simply let it be the weather of him, the way Jazen let his be the weather of him, two creatures from two ends of the world who grieved out loud and were not ashamed of it.

"You asked me about a war," Drake said. "I will tell you about a war. Six hundred of your years ago, the same hands that cut your gift in two cut a great many other things, and there was a war over it, the long kind, the kind your books have made small. I was younger then. Younger than I have any right to remember being." The coal eye had gone somewhere else, somewhere down the centuries. "I had a daughter. Scarlet, like her mother. Loud, like her mother. Foolish, like her father. She thought a war was a thing you could win by being brave at it, which is the lie that takes the young of every kind, yours and mine. She flew at a thing she should have flown around. And I came too late. I was six hundred miles off being wise somewhere, and I found the place where she had been, and there was not enough of her left to bring home, and I went up." He paused. "Up so high the air would not hold a flame. I made one anyway. Three days of black fire on a mountain, where the whole world could see it, because that is how my kind weep, child. We do not hide it under a careful face. We take it to a height and we let the world watch it burn. Your tiger keeps things. I do not keep this. I have grieved her loudly for six hundred years and I will grieve her for six thousand more, and the loudness is the love."

Viridia said nothing, which here was the only true thing to say.

"I tell you this," Drake said, "so you understand the thing I am about to offer you, and refuse it if you are wise, which you are not, or you would not have come. You stand at the

edge of doing what those hands did six hundred years ago. You would decide for every soul that breathes, never once asking their leave, the way they did, and you would call it mending and they called it safety, and the road to both is paved the same. I will not forbid you the road. The tiger refused to forbid it, and he lies, and I do not, so hear it from a thing that does not lie: I will not forbid you. But I will tell you that if you walk that road, there will come a place on it where you will need to *end* a thing. A magic that should not be. A door that should not stand open. A working too large to fight, that must instead be unmade." The coal eye came back from down the centuries and found her, and held her, and was terrible and kind in the way only very old things are both. "There is a symbol for it. The oldest one. The one your kind buried deepest because it frightened them most. It ends any magic. It closes any portal. It is the only thing the severing-hands feared, because it is the only thing that can undo what such hands make. I know it. I used it once, on the thing that killed my daughter, when there was nothing left to do but end it. I have not taught it to a living soul. A soul that wants it should not have it."

"And the kind that doesn't want it," Viridia said.

"Is the only kind that should." Drake was quiet a moment. Above them the sky had gone from grey to the bruised gold of a height's late afternoon, and Raizen's scales threw little fires of it across the black rock, and Varissa lay still as banked iron with her child against her side. "You did not come up my mountain wanting a weapon. You came up it afraid of the one you already carry, and trying every small door before the wall, the way the loud girl with the black claws told you to — yes, I have it from my son, who has it from you; the bond is a leaky thing and you should mind what you feel near him. You do not want the death-symbol. Which is exactly why I have decided, sitting here, watching

you leave my grandchild off your ledger because you love him too much to count him, that you are the first soul in six thousand years I would trust to hold it."

The wind came up off the slope and went through all of them.

"Come back tomorrow," Drake said. "Through your dark, on your feet, the way the dead come. Come alone, or bring the rabbit. I do not care. And I will teach you the symbol that ends things. Not today. Today you can barely stand, and a thing like this you do not learn tired. The danger of it is not in the casting. The danger is that it is *easy*, and clean, and it asks nothing of you, and the things that ask nothing of you are the things that take the most. You know this already. I can see it on you. It is why you are the right one, and why you are afraid, and the fear is the only fee I will charge."

* * *

She got them home in the last of the light, back through the seam, out into the meeting-house doorway where the lintel's shadow lay long across the floor and Hiram still breathed slow on his pallet and the world was small again and human and on a clock.

Jazen sat down on the bench by the door rather harder than he meant to, and put his head in his hands for a moment, and then took it out again, because there was no time to be a man who had stood on a mountain with two dragons and been weighed and found smaller than the war.

"He's going to teach you a thing that ends magic," Jazen said. "A thing that closes portals. You understand what that is. That's not a peace road, Viridia. That's the other kind."

"I know what it is."

"And you said yes."

"I didn't say yes. He said come back. That's different and you know it's different, or you'd never have survived

running a resistance." She held the threshold with the dark coming on behind her and the camp going to its uneasy bed, and she felt the two rails of the day run on past her into the night, the message somewhere out on the wire toward a careful man who had not yet answered, and the black mountain behind her where a thing waited that she did not want and would learn anyway. The word and the walking, the two ways of going out. The letter loosed into the world of men, which might still bring a hand back. And the going up into the cold, which had brought back the one thing she had sworn to spend every small door against before she touched it: a way to end.

"I'll send the true message, and I'll wait on the careful man, and I'll do everything Amber asked of me, every small door, every one," she said. "That's still the plan. That hasn't changed. A man up the wire might still say yes. I haven't given any of it up." She turned her eyes to the hall where Hiram breathed, and past it to the false stillness of the trees where a column was readying, and she did the sum she did not want to do, which was that the small doors were closing at the speed of an army and the wall had just grown a second face she had not known it had. "But Drake's right about one thing. The road to the cure has a place on it where I'll need to end something. He saw it before I did. And a person doesn't refuse to learn the shape of the worst thing on a road just because she's praying she won't have to walk it. That's not hope. That's the kind of stupid that gets two hundred people killed."

Jazen held his eyes on her a long time in the failing light.

"My mother used to say the same thing about you that the red one said," he told her. "Not in those words. But the same thing. That you'd put everyone on your ledger but the one person you couldn't bear to count." He stood, and his knees did not quite hold it the first time, the mountain still in

them. "Get some sleep. Tomorrow you learn to end things, and the day after you might get an answer from a man who could let us not have to."

He went in to sit with Hiram.

And Viridia was alone at the threshold with the long shadow of the lintel pooled at her feet, the seam she had walked through twice today lying quiet now, a door to a mountain where a grief six hundred years old had agreed to teach her the one thing she had hoped never to need, and she set her hand at last to the dark-blue stone at her throat, because there was no one left to see her do it, and she allowed it, for one breath, the exact size of the fear she was carrying.

Then she drew it down small again, the way she drew the furnace down to a coal, and went to make herself sleep, because Drake had said the unmaking was not learned tired, and tomorrow she would have to wear the sort of calm that is only fear held very, very still.

She did not weep. There was no one to see, and there was a thing past that now, which was that she had a great deal to do, and weeping was not on the sheet.

The bond to Raizen drew across all the dark miles, low and warm and *coming-soon*, now that he was nearer, now that he had decided, she could feel it, to follow her home. And up on the black rock, she knew without seeing it, his father lay awake under the too-big sky, turning over in all his long memory the symbol he had used once on the thing that killed his daughter, deciding how you teach the unmaking to a child who is right not to want it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Dust to Dust

She slept the way Drake had told her to, which was to say badly and on purpose, lying still in the dark of the children's hall with her eyes shut and her breathing slow and her mind refusing to settle, because a person cannot order sleep the way she ordered her face. But she rested. She lay flat and let the day go out of her arms. Her arms forgot the four men for a few hours, mostly. When the grey came up at the window she was as ready as a girl could be to go and learn the thing she had hoped, for many months, never to need.

She did not eat first. She found she could not. She drank water from the bucket by the door and stood a while at the threshold where the doorway's long dark stretched out across the boards, and felt the bond before she felt anything else, the warm line under her ribs gone from far to near in the night, so near now that she knew if she went out past the rim she would find him within an hour's flight, but she would not go out past the rim this morning. This morning she went up.

She did not wake Jazen. He had said to bring the rabbit or not, as she chose, and Drake had said the same, and she had decided in the dark that this was a thing she would rather do without a witness, because the witness was a kindness she could not afford to want. A person who learns the worst stroke on a long road should learn it the way you take a

wound, alone, so that no one has to watch your face do whatever it was going to do. She left him sleeping on the bench beside the wounded man, his mother's papers slid off his knees onto the floor, and she stepped into the seam in the dark of the doorway, and she went.

* * *

The black rock took her as it had the first time, with a flood of wind and a flood of sky and the thin biting chill of a place where the air has given up most of what makes it kind. She came out of the dark standing, the way the lost ones arrive, and she held still a moment to let her stomach forgive her and her ears stop ringing, and then she looked above her, because the old one was always there before her.

He was. He lay along the high stone with his enormous head down on a forearm the size of a cottage. The coal of his single open eye was banked low this morning, the way a fire is banked that has burned all night and means to burn all day. Raizen was not on the height. She felt him below and to the south, riding the wind, deliberately given the morning's air to himself, and she understood that this had been arranged between them, father and son, that the son would not be present for this, and the arrangement sat oddly in her, that a creature six thousand winters deep had thought of her feelings and moved his child off the mountain to spare them both.

"You came by yourself," Drake said. "Good. The rabbit would have wept, and you would have spent the lesson watching him instead of taking it." The banked eye opened the rest of the way. "And you slept. Not well. Well enough. Better than I did at your age before a thing of this size, but I was a fool at your age, and I had centuries to stop being one, and you will not be given centuries. So. Sit."

She sat on the cold stone where she had sat the day before. The wind came off the rock face and cut straight through her. She did not let it bend her. Her mother's blue stone lay cool at her throat under her shirt.

"You will want me to start with the look of it," Drake said. "The mark. How a hand draws it. I will not, yet. A girl who learns the look of a thing first will think the look is the thing, and the look is the least of it. I will start where the lesson starts, which is with my daughter, and you will sit and you will let an ancient creature grieve out loud at you, because that is the fee, and I told you yesterday it was the only one I would charge."

"You told me the fear was the fee."

"The fear is what you pay yourself. This is what you pay me." The banked eye held on her. "Listen."

* * *

He told her about the day.

He told it slow, from the height, the way he told everything, and he did not perform it and he did not soften it, and Viridia held herself motionless and let it come down the slope at her like the scree.

"I have told you she flew at a thing she should have flown around," Drake said. "I have not told you what the thing was. It was a working. A great one, of the kind the severing-hands made in those years, when they were still learning what they had bought with the cutting. They had opened a door. Not a portal as your kind makes them, a small seam you step through; a great standing door, torn into a place that is not a place, and they had set things to come out of it, and the things that came out of it could not be killed, because a thing that is not alive cannot be made dead. You understand me. You have stood at the far edge of all your seeing. You know there is an absence past the warmth. They had cut a hole in

the world and they were spending what came through it like coin, and my daughter, who was loud and brave and a fool, flew at the door to shut it, because she thought a door could be shut by something strong enough flying hard enough at it." He paused. "It cannot. A door of that kind does not care how strong you are. It is not a wall. It is an absence wearing the shape of an opening, and you cannot push an absence closed. She learned that in the last half-instant of being alive, and then she was not alive, and then she was not anything, because what came through that door did to her what the door did to everything, which is make it into nothing. There was no body. That is the part I do not say to my son. There was a place where she had been. The place was wrong. The air over it bent the way air bends over a forge, and there was nothing in it to carry home. I made a flame in air that would not hold one and I burned three days on this mountain and there was nothing beneath me to burn for. That is the truth of it. I grieved an absence. I have been grieving an absence ever since."

The wind dropped, the way it had the day before, the whole mountain seeming to wait around the old grief.

"And then," Drake said, "I shut the door."

Viridia held her silence. She had learned by now that the only true answer to a grief this old was to give it the room to finish.

"I did not fly at it. I had watched my daughter fly at it. I am a fool, child, but I am not a fool twice over the same grave." The banked eye returned from down the years and found her. "I used the symbol. The oldest one. The one your people buried furthest down. And the door that could not be pushed shut, that did not care how strong a thing flew at it, that had eaten my daughter and left me nothing to bury, simply was not, anymore. One stroke. One breath. And the thing that had taken everything from me gave nothing back and asked

nothing of me and was gone, clean, the way a candle is gone when you pinch the wick, and I knelt on the stone where my daughter had been and I understood that the worst thing that had ever happened to me had just been undone by something so easy it frightened me more than the door had." His head settled lower against the stone. "That is the lesson. Before the look of it. I want you to understand, before I teach your hand to make it, that you will hate how easy it is. You will close the worst thing you ever face, and it will cost you nothing you can feel, and you will kneel in the place where the thing was and you will wish it had been harder. Because a working that ends the world's worst making and takes not one drop from you is a working that has taken the drop somewhere you cannot watch it go, and you, of all the souls I have met in all my years, already know what it is to pay where you cannot see the coin leave your hand."

"Yes," she told him, and the word came out level and stripped, the way it always did at the edge of too much.

"Then you are ready. Stand. Find a clear span of stone. You will make it once, and you will not fill it, and then I will tell you why making it and filling it are two separate mercies, and we will both be glad you did not learn the second one tired."

* * *

He taught her the look of it.

It was not, she thought, what a person would expect of the oldest and most-dreaded mark in the world. She had braced for something vast, a thing of a hundred strokes, a sigil so dense with intent that the making of it would take an hour and a steady hand. It was not that. It was very nearly nothing. It was a ring, but not joined. An unjoined ring, like the sign she had been writing all week, the one she signed her letters with, and the sameness of it went through her like

ice-water. The sign of the man who might bring peace and the sign that ended all magic were the same broken ring, and the only difference was a single line drawn inward, toward the center, beginning at the gap in the ring and running in and stopping before it reached the middle. An unjoined ring, with a line that pointed at the hollow it left.

"It is a door that will not close," Drake said, watching her draw it in the grit with a splinter of dark stone. "That is what it says. Not *closed*. Not *ended*. It says, here is a thing that will not close, and then it says, and yet, and the *and yet* is the line you run inward, and that line is everything. You are not closing the door. You are telling the door that it was never truly opened. You are telling the magic that it was never truly made. That is why it ends any working and shuts any portal, because it does not fight the thing. It unsays it. It reaches back to the breath before the thing was made, and it stands in that breath, and it says *no*, once, and then the thing simply is not, because the breath that made it has been spent on unmaking it instead." The eye watched her hand. "Again. Your inward line trembles. It must not tremble. A trembling inward line is a door half-unsaid, and a door half-unsaid is worse than one left wide. Again."

She made it again. And again. Her hand did not tremble the fourth time, or the fifth, and somewhere in the seventh she felt the thing she had been dreading, which was that the mark wanted to be made. It had a rightness to it the way a true sentence had a rightness, the way a child's word had sat right on a slate. It fit her hand. It fit the part of her that did the sums, the cold working part, which looked at the open ring with its line turned inward and understood it at once and without effort, and approved, and that was the worst of all. Her hand agreed that the mark was *good*. So did the cold reckoner behind her eyes. Neither of them was the part of her that was supposed to be afraid.

"You feel it," Drake said. It was not a question. "It is easy in your hand. It is easy in your head. It is the easiest thing you have ever learned, and you have learned to step through shadow and you have learned to bring a dead tree back, and this is lighter than either, and that is the whole of why I made you sit through my daughter first. So that when the easiness came you would have the weight of her to set against it. Make it once more, full now, the intent behind it, but on nothing, on a thing that is already nothing, and feel what it costs you, and then do not make it again until the day you have no other door."

She drew it on the air. She put the intent behind it, the *no, once*, the reaching back to the breath before a making, and she aimed it at nothing at all, a hand's width of empty wind above the stone, and the mark took her intent and used it and handed it back, and the wind in that hand's width simply was not, for an instant, a small clean absence the exact shape of the line she had drawn, and then the air rushed in and filled it and there was nothing to show she had done a thing, and it had taken nothing from her. Not a draught of the fire in her chest. Not a swallow. Nothing she could feel. She knelt on the height with the mark fading off her fingers, and she understood the old one completely, and she was afraid in just the way he had promised, which was not afraid of the mark but afraid of how little it had asked, and she set her free hand flat against the cold to steady what the easiness had done to her stomach.

"There," Drake said, low. "Now you have it. Now you carry it. I will not ask you to swear anything over it, because a soul that needs to swear over a thing this final is a soul that should not hold it, and you have not sworn, which is how I know you can. Go home, child. You have learned to end things. Go and try every door that is not this one, the way the loud one with the bitten nails counselled you, and pray to

whatever you pray to that you never run the inward line at anything that breathes." The eye banked low again, the lesson done. "And eat something. You came up here on water and a poor night, and a girl who carries the unmaking should not also carry an empty stomach. It makes the easiness easier, and that is the one way we do not want it to slide."

* * *

She came home to a camp that had stopped.

She knew it before her feet finished arriving, the way you know a house is wrong from the doorway, by the quality of the quiet. The camp was never silent; it had the baby Amber complained of and the small ones at their slates and the ring of Brutus at his endless mending, and it had none of those now. It had a knot of people at the meeting-house door, and Jazen at the heart of the knot with a paper in his hand, and his face. Jazen, who let his grief be the weather of him, who never kept a thing off his face the way she kept everything off hers, had a face that was doing a thing she had not seen it do, which was nothing. It had gone flat. It had gone to the hard certain thing without the grief over it. The grief not being there was worse than the grief, because it meant whatever the paper said had taken his grief and burned it for fuel.

"It came back," he said, when he saw her. He did not ask where she had been. He held the paper out, and his hand was steady, and the steadiness was the alarm. "The wire. Your careful man. Word came back."

She took it. She read it standing in the wind with the knot of people watching her not move.

It was not from the careful man. That was the first wrongness, and something behind her eyes marked it before she had read three lines. It was a broadsheet. A printed

thing, the capital's own type, the kind that goes up on station walls and gets read aloud in market squares to people who cannot read it for themselves, and across the top in letters meant to be seen from across a road it said A WARNING TO EVERY MOTHER. And beneath that, in the smaller type that did the real work, it said the dark mages were not dead. That they had never been dead. That they hid in the wild places and reached out now, in these very weeks, up the honest wire that carried a nation's letters, to the good and faithful folk of the light, with poisoned words. That they had a girl. A child, it said, used as a lure, sent to whisper to careful men in the night that the old severed gift could be *given back*, freely, to any who would have it, forced on no one. And here the sheet quoted her, quoted the true words she had set down in a dead woman's hand, her offer of a room and an hour and proof laid in honest eyes. It set those words in the capital's type and called them what the capital needed them to be: a plot to corrupt the children of the light, to open their cores to a dark that would not let go once it was inside, to make every faithful family into a thing the dark could use. *They will come for your children with kind words*, the sheet said. *They came for ours with kind words once. We did not forget. Watch the wire. Watch the strangers. Watch the quiet man at the next desk who reads his letters too long.*

She read it twice. Her hand stayed steady. Drake had taught her, an hour ago, to fear easy things, and there was nothing easy here, so she was not afraid; she was something colder than afraid, and she let the cold do its sums.

"He didn't sell us," she said. The words came out level and stripped. "Read it. He never answered at all. They have my first words, the careful overture, *forced on no one*, the exact line. That's the first letter. Not the second. We only sent the second yesterday, three words of his own question answered." She turned the sheet over, found nothing on the

back, turned it again. "They have the first and not the second, which means they took the first off the wire. There was a tap. On the line he used, or on his desk. They lifted the overture the day it landed and they sat on it and they printed it, and the silence we read as a quiet man counting his rope, that wasn't him counting. That was the capital deciding how to spend it." The cold working part finished the sum and she said its end without wanting to. "The question that came back to me. *Who else knows*. That might have been him. Or it might have been them, fishing, asking in his voice to learn the size of the council. And I gave it. I told the truth of the number. I handed them the rope."

* * *

The knot of people had gone very quiet, and Jazen took the broadsheet back out of her hands, not unkindly, the way you take a sharp thing from someone who has cut herself on it and not yet felt it.

"You don't know that," he said. "The second message went up yesterday, the way you told me to send it. If they have a tap, they have that now as well. But you don't know they held it when you answered. You don't know the question was theirs and not his. You're running the cruellest possible sum and calling it the only one."

"It's the sum that keeps people breathing." She heard how she sounded and could not make herself sound otherwise. "If it was him, then a quiet man is sitting in a grey office having watched his own overture turned into a poster that tells the whole capital to hunt for the man at the next desk who reads his letters too long. He will never lean toward another latch as long as he lives. That door is shut whether he was loyal or not, because they didn't need to turn him; they only needed to make leaning fatal, and they have. And if it was them, if the question was a hook in his voice,

then I told the capital the size of the council with my own pen, and they will know there are fewer than the fingers of two hands who could name him, and they will go hunting those few." She made herself say the last of it plainly, because she had sworn once that she would not be a person who looked away from the thing she had done. "Either road, the way through the moderates is closed. Either road, I closed it, by writing the truest letter I knew how to write, because the truth made a better poster than a lie would have. They couldn't have done this with a lie. They needed my real words to make it land. The very thing meant to win the quiet man, that I told him the honest number and made it small for no one, is the thing that turned deadly in their type. I was right that a man held by a lie lets go the instant the lie does. I just never once thought about who else might be holding the same wire."

Jazen looked at the broadsheet a long moment, the capital's letters, her own truth inside them.

"My mother had this happen," he said, at last. "Twice that I know of. You put out the honest hand, and the honest hand is the thing they sever and hold up, because honest hands are the only ones that work on a poster. She told me once it was the foulest feeling in the work, worse than losing people, because losing people is at least a thing the enemy did. This they make you do to yourself. They take your best self and they print it." He folded the sheet, careful, and did not put it in the fire, because a thing of this kind you keep, to learn from, the way you keep a scar. "It is not your fault, Viridia. It is the work. The work eats good intentions and pastes them on walls."

"It is my fault," she said, not as penance, as arithmetic. "It is the work and it is my fault. Both can stand. I sent it. I will learn from it. But I will not make it smaller than it is, because the next time I put out an honest hand I need to

remember that the honest hand is exactly the part they will sever, and a person who tells herself *it is only the work* is a person who reaches out the same hand the same way and loses the next one too." She looked at the folded sheet in his fist, her truest words inside the capital's type. "How many doors does that leave."

"One that I know of. Perhaps." Jazen's flat face did not move. "There is a councilor. A real one, not a quiet man at a desk, a moderate with a seat at the table, who has spoken against the war twice in chamber and lived through it. My mother kept a thread to him. It is a thin thread and an old one, and after this morning it is the only one we have left, and a councilor reading that poster over his breakfast may decide the safest thing is to shout against the dark louder than anyone, the way frightened men do. But it is a door. It is the last one." He slid the sheet inside his shirt. "Rest. Eat. We weigh it tonight. You learned your other thing on the mountain, the ending thing, do not pretend I can't read it on you, and now you have watched a door close that you tried to open with nothing but the truth, and I want you to sit with both before you let either point you anywhere, because I have watched people decide the only door left was the one that ends things, on a morning shaped exactly like this one, and I do not want it to be you."

He went in to tell the council the road through the moderates was a poster now.

* * *

She did not rest. She went to find food, because the old one had told her to and because there was nothing else useful to do with her hands, and she was at the edge of the lanes with a heel of bread she was not eating when Amber found her.

Amber had been climbing back all week, the armor settling back over the hurt by slow degrees, and there was

none of the climbing in her now. She came down the lane fast, the bitten black nails of one hand wrapped white around a copy of the broadsheet, the other hand at the necklace at her throat, the Lightwell-linked thing that kept her core alight, gripping it the way Mella gripped her locket, the tell of a frightened person who did not know she had one. She stopped close enough that the wind could not get between them, and her eyes, which had cried themselves dry in the woods and not wept since, were doing a thing that was not weeping and was worse.

"I ran your line," Amber said. Her voice was very level, the way Viridia's went level, and the levelness was the alarm. "Did you know that. Did it cross your mind even once, while you were writing your true and honest letter, that the *line*, the courier, the wire, the hands that carried it, was *me*. I asked Jazen for work. He gave me the message line, because I'm fast and I'm quiet and I look like a girl nobody watches. I carried your overture to the relay. I put it on the wire with my own two hands. And this morning I got to read it again." She held the poster up between them, shaking, not with fear. "On *this*. Word for word. The thing I carried, in their type, telling every mother in the capital to watch for a girl who whispers about giving back the gift. I *am* the girl on the poster, Viridia. I carried her. I made her real."

"Amber."

"No. You don't get the flat voice with me. I know the flat voice. I invented half of it." She did not lower the poster. "I told you in the worst of it, that night by the fire when you came in, that whatever you were planning, I was in. Whatever it was. And I meant it, and I still mean it, and that is the trouble, because I am starting to understand I said *whatever it is* to a person who has never told me what it is. You went up a mountain this morning. You came back changed. You're standing there eating bread you aren't

eating with the careful face pulled on so tight I can see the seams, and there's a thing you learned up there, I can feel it on you the way I could always feel things on you, and a peace road just died, and I watched your face when you read this and you weren't surprised. You were sad. You weren't surprised. Like a girl crossing items off a list." Her voice cracked, finally, the one small human failure, and she let it, which from her was the loudest alarm there was. "What is at the bottom of the list, Viridia. What is the thing you keep trying all the little doors *before*. Because I have been carrying your messages and telling you I'm in, and I am starting to think I never asked the only question that counts, which is, in to *what*. What are you really going to do."

The wind came up off the lanes and went through them both. Viridia stood with the bread in her hand and the unjoined mark and its inward stroke still fresh in her fingers and the dead door folded inside Jazen's shirt, and she looked at the only person who had ever made her say the true thing aloud, and she understood she was not going to get out of this one wearing the flat voice, and that the question Amber had just put to her was not a thing you answered standing in a lane with bread going stale in your fist. It was the kind that took the rest of a night, or the rest of a war, and Amber was not going to let her fold it away, because Amber had carried the girl on the poster up the wire herself, and a person who has made your secret real has bought the right to know what it was.

"Sit down," Viridia said. "Not here."

"I don't want to sit down. I want an answer."

"I know," Viridia said. "That's why we have to sit down."

CHAPTER NINE

The Right

The hall smelled of the wounded man and of the lamp that had burned all night, and those were the two smells of the place now, the slow sweet wrongness of Hiram on his pallet and the flat tin smell of the oil they could not spare and burned anyway. Viridia walked into both of them with Amber a half-step behind her and the bread still in her fist, because she had not been able to make herself put it down on the way and had not been able to make herself eat it either. A girl who carries a thing she will not use is a girl who has run out of better places to put her hands.

It was not a room she had chosen for an argument. It was only the nearest room with a door, and there was a war on outside it, and Amber had said *not here* with her body in the lane and Viridia had said *not here* with her mouth, and so they had walked to the place where the dying ward-mage slept and shut a thin door on a camp that was already packing itself to march, and that was the room they were going to do this in, because in a war you do not get to pick the room. You get the one with the door.

Hiram did not wake. He was past the colour of a man who wakes for voices. He lay on the pallet with his hand fallen off the edge of it toward the tall anchor-post that carried the camp's wards up through the roofbeam, the way a sleeping child's hand falls toward the side of the bed where the

parent sat, and even asleep, even grey, even with the wick of him guttering down to almost nothing, the hand reached for the post he had spent two years feeding, because the body does not forget the thing it was made to do even when the man inside it has stopped being able to do it.

Viridia set the bread down on the bench by his head. She did it carefully, the way you set a thing down in a sickroom, and she did not look at Amber while she did it, because she knew what was coming and she wanted one more breath of not having begun it yet.

"You're stalling," Amber said.

"I'm putting down bread."

"You're stalling, and you're doing it with bread, which is somehow worse than just stalling." Amber had not let go of the broadsheet. She had it still in the white grip of her bitten black nails, folded now to the size of a hand, the capital's type pressed against her own palm. "I have known you for fourteen months. I have watched you do this exact thing maybe forty times. You set something down very carefully, you make your face do the nothing, and then you tell me the smallest true thing you can get away with telling me, and you call it an answer. It's a good trick. I'd admire it if it weren't aimed at me." She tossed the folded sheet onto the bench beside the bread, where the two things lay together, the food and the poster, neither of them eaten. "Not today. Today I get the whole sentence. You owe me the whole sentence. I carried it up the wire."

* * *

"Ask me, then," Viridia said. "The real one. The one you've been carrying since the lane. You keep walking up to it and you keep flinching off it into the smaller ones, the bread and the trick and the forty times, because the real one is large

and you're afraid of how I'll answer it. So ask it. I'll stand still for it."

Amber looked at her a moment, and there was a thing in her face that was almost a laugh, the bitter kind, the kind that is just grief that has nowhere to be.

"You really will, won't you," she said. "Stand still for it. You'll let me hit you with it as hard as I like and you'll just stand there and take it level, because taking it level is the last way you've got to be in charge of it." She drew a breath. The bitten nails had gone to the necklace at her throat, the small bright thing Lightwell had made to keep her shattered core alive, and she did not seem to know her hand had gone there. "Fine. Here it is. The thing you can do. The thing at the bottom of the list. I worked it out on the walk up. It's not a spell to win a battle, is it. It's not a weapon. You'd have told me about a weapon. You tell me about weapons. You showed me the spears the day you made them. This is the other kind of thing. This is the kind you don't show anyone."

"Ask it, Amber."

"You can give it back," Amber said. "Can't you. The whole gift. Not to a person who comes asking. Not the way it's in your letters, *to any who will have it, imposed on no one*. That's the small door. That's the door you keep telling everyone you'll knock on first." Her voice had flattened right out, the way Viridia's did when a thing got too large to feel safely, and the flatness was the alarm, and they both knew it was the alarm, which was its own small horror, that the two of them had taught each other the same tell. "The thing you've buried under all the little ones is bigger than that. You can give it back to everyone. At once. Every core that's alive. Without a single one of them saying yes."

The lamp guttered. Hiram breathed his slow wrong breath. And Viridia, who had let no one but a tiger and a dragon's grief hear this said aloud, stood in the sickroom

and held the nothing on her face, and said the true thing, because she had sworn long ago never to flinch from what her own hands could do, and what her hands could do she had already done once, to a tree.

"Yes," she said.

* * *

She had expected Amber to shout. She had braced for the shout the way she braced for everything, by going still under it, and the shout did not come, and the not-coming was worse.

Amber sat down. She sat down on the end of Hiram's bench, near the grey man's feet, with the broadsheet and the bread between them, and she put her face in her hands for a moment the way Jazen did, and then she took it out again, and when she looked up the heat had gone out of her and left something steadier and far harder to answer.

"Okay," she said. "Okay. Then I'm going to ask you the only question that matters, and before I ask it I need you to know I'm not asking to win. I'm not the bun-woman. I don't do arithmetic. I'm asking because I'm the only one in this camp who's going to, and somebody has to, and it's me, because I carried that honest letter of yours up the wire with these two hands and watched the capital turn it into a thing that tells mothers to be afraid of girls who talk about giving the gift back. So." She set her hands flat on her own knees, the chipped black nails spread, and she held Viridia's eyes the way you hold the eyes of someone you love when you are about to say the thing that might end being able to. "The capital controls people through their magic. That's the whole of what they did. Six hundred years ago somebody decided what every person alive would be allowed to be, in the deepest part of them, the part that's the *gift*, and they decided it without asking, and they made everyone half of

what they were and told them the half was the whole, and you have spent a year, Viridia, a *year*, the whole time I've known you, learning to hate them for it. Lightwell died for hating them for it. Jazen's run a war in the woods for two years on the strength of hating them for it." She did not look away. "How are you any different. If you reach into every living core and change what it's allowed to be, without asking, because you've decided you know what's best for them better than they do. How is that not the exact thing they did. How are you not just the next council deciding for everyone, only this time it's a child in a wood instead of a robe in a chamber."

The room held very still.

Viridia opened her mouth to answer it, because she had an answer, she had three, she had been carrying them since the rowan, and the cold working part lined them up the way it lined up everything, in order, the strongest first.

And then she said the first one out loud, and heard it.

"Because I'd be giving it *back*," she said. "Not taking. They cut people in half. I'd be making them whole. It's not the same to give a person their own—"

She stopped. She stopped because she had heard it, the way Lor-ar had once made her say *there was no price at all* slow until the wrongness rose up through the saying. She heard her own voice say *making them whole*, and she heard underneath it, in the exact same shape, in the exact same righteous certain tone, the voice of every robe in every chamber who had ever settled the fate of every soul alive and called it *making them safe*. The road to both was paved the same. Drake had told her that on the mountain. She had filed it. She had not, until this moment, felt the paving under her own feet.

"Finish it," Amber said. Quietly. Not cruelly. "You stopped. You never stop. Finish it. *It's not the same to give a*

person their own— what. Their own gift back? Who decided it's theirs to want? You did. You decided, looking at them through your magic eyes from a wood they've never heard of, that what they have isn't enough and what you'd give them is better, and you didn't ask one of them, not one, and I know you didn't, because you can't, because the only way to do it is all at once, and a thing you do to everyone at once is a thing you do to nobody's face." She leaned forward. "That's the council, Vee. That's the chamber. The robe doesn't think he's hurting anyone either. He thinks he's making them safe. He's *sure* of it. He's so sure of it he never asks. You're so sure of it you can't ask. The not-asking is the whole crime and you'd commit it bigger than anyone in history."

* * *

Viridia did not have an answer that survived being said aloud. She found that out the way you find out a stair is not there in the dark, by reaching her foot down for the next one and finding nothing under it.

She tried the second answer. She did not say it out loud this time; she said it inside, where she could test it before she spent it, and the second answer was *the cost falls on the world, not on them; no one ever feels it; a thing that hurts no one cannot be a crime*. And the part of her that did the sums turned it over and handed it back broken, because that was not a defence of the not-asking. That was a defence of getting away with the not-asking. A robe in a chamber who does a thing to everyone and arranges that no one ever feels it has not become innocent. He has only become harder to catch.

She tried the third answer. *They'd thank me. If they understood, every one of them would choose it. I'm only doing for them what they'd do for themselves if they knew*. And she heard that one in Amber's tone before she could even finish

thinking it, *they'd thank me if they understood*, and it was the oldest sentence a powerful person had ever told themselves about a powerless one, it was the sentence that had built every chamber and burned every school and packed her own true words into the capital's type, and she put it down. She did not say it. She would not stand in a sickroom and say *they'd thank me* about people she had decided not to ask.

So she said the only thing she had left, which was the truth, and the truth was not an answer.

"I don't have one," Viridia said. "You're right. I've been turning it for weeks and you've put it cleaner in one breath than I managed in all of them, and I don't have an answer to it that holds up when I say it out loud. Every one I've got sounds, when I hear it, exactly like the thing I hate. *Making them whole. It hurts no one. They'd thank me.* I've thought all three. I thought I'd worked out which one was true. They're the same three sentences the council that cut us would have used, only turned around, and a sentence isn't made right by which direction you point it." She stood very still in the lamp-smell and the wrong-breath of the dying man, and she did the hardest thing she did, which was to let a thing be as large as it was. "I can't claim I have the right. I've been pretending to myself that the giving-back made it different from the taking, and it doesn't, not on this question, not on the only one that matters. The question stands. You've just made it bigger than it was an hour ago, and I'm going to have to carry it that size now, and I will, because you're right to make me."

Amber stared at her.

"That's not—" Amber started, and stopped, and tried again. "You're supposed to fight me. I came in here to fight you. I had the whole thing ready. I had three more things to say after that one and now I'll never get to say any of them because you just *agreed* with me, which is so much worse,

Vee, do you understand that, it's so much worse, because now there's no fight, there's just the two of us in a room with a thing that's true and nobody to be angry at about it." Her voice cracked. She let it. "Tell me you're not going to do it. That's all I want. I don't even want you to lose the argument. I want you to tell me you won't reach into the whole world without asking it. Just tell me that."

"I can't promise you that either," Viridia said, and it was the cruellest thing she had said to anyone in her life, and she said it level, because the only kindness left in it was that she would not dress it up. "If every door but that one shuts, and the bodies are real, and the only thing on the sheet is two hundred people I love dead in a wood or the whole world made whole without its leave, then, Amber, I don't know which way I'd choose. I won't lie to you and say I'd let them die to keep my hands clean of the asking. And I won't lie to you and say I'd do it easy. I'd do it knowing exactly what you just told me. That's the most I have. I'll carry the question the whole way. I won't pretend I answered it. That's not nothing." She paused. "It's not enough. But it's not nothing, and it's all there is."

* * *

The door opened.

Jazen came in without knocking, the way you come into a room you have been in ten thousand times, with a roll of marching-list under one arm and the flat that had been in his face since the broadsheet still set hard over the grief, and he stopped two steps in, because he had walked into the back end of something and a man who has run a resistance for two years knows the shape of a room that has just had the truth said in it.

He looked at the bread and the broadsheet lying together on the bench. He looked at Amber, whose face had gone past

armor entirely. He looked at Viridia, who had her careful nothing on so tight that Jazen, who could read her by now the way his mother had read everyone, saw straight through it to the thing underneath, which was a girl who had just lost an argument she had needed to lose.

"She asked you," Jazen said. It was not a question. "The right of it. Whether you've got the right."

"You knew she would," Viridia said.

"I hoped she would. I'd have done it myself if she hadn't, only worse, because I'd have done it as the man who needs you to win the war, and that taints it. It had to come from her. She's the only one in this camp who wants nothing off you." He set the marching-list down on the bench, on the far side of the bread from the poster, three things now, the food and the lie and the war, none of them touched. "She's right. You know she's right. I can see you know it. Good. Carry it." He pulled the stool from beside Hiram's pallet and sat on it heavily, near the grey open hand that still reached toward its anchor, and for a moment he looked at his ward-mage instead of at the girls, at the slow wrong breathing, and something went across his flat face that the flat could not hold down. "I want to tell you the other half of it. The half she can't, because she's never had it and I have, and I've spent two years not using it, and there's nobody else alive who can put it to you straight."

Amber, on the bench, had gone still. She knew this tone. Everyone learned this tone of Jazen's eventually; it was the one with the grief taken out, which meant the grief had been spent for fuel.

"You think the not-asking is the crime," Jazen said. "It is. She's right. But there's a thing across from it that nobody warns you about, and it's worse, and I'm the proof of it." He turned his hands over on his knees. They were a powerful dark mage's hands and they looked, in the lamplight, like

any man's. "I am the most powerful dark mage alive. You both know that. You say it about me the way people say a man is tall. It's a fact about the furniture." He did not look up from his hands. "Two years ago a column came through a town that had sheltered us. Eighty men. They had my sister. They had Jan in a cart with her hands tied, and I came over a rise and saw it, and I did not decide anything, Viridia, that's the part you need to hear, I did not stand at the rim of all my seeing and weigh a cost. I *opened*. I let the whole of myself out at once because the careful face came off and there was nothing under it but the thing I am, and when it was done there were eighty men dead in a road and a cart with my sister in it that I had not got to in time anyway, because the thing that kills eighty men in a breath does not pick, it does not aim, it does not leave the cart standing in the middle of it. I killed her column and I did not save her and I have not let myself off the chain since." His voice did not rise. That was the terror of it; it stayed flat, the way Drake's stayed low. "So here is the other half of Amber's question. She's asking whether you've got the right to act without asking. I'm telling you there is a sin opposite to it, and it's the one I committed, and it's *not acting because you're too afraid of what you are*. I have stood at the rim of this war for two years with a thing in me that could have ended a dozen of their columns, and I have not used it, not once, because the last time I used it I learned what I was, and I would rather lose people slowly than be that again. And people have died slowly. Every patrol that's killed a scout in the dark these two years, I could have stopped, and I didn't, because stopping it meant becoming the thing on the road again. I don't know if I was right. I've never known. That's the mirror, Viridia. She's the question and I'm the warning, and we're both in the room, and the foul truth of it is that we can't both be heeded. If you act, you might be the council. If you don't, you might be me.

There's no clean foot to stand on. There's only which regret you can live inside."

* * *

Nobody said anything for a while. The lamp burned. Hiram's hand lay open toward the post.

It was Amber who broke it, and she broke it the way she broke everything, sideways, because she could not let a thing this size sit unaccompanied, and the company she brought it, when it came, was not a joke. The joke would not come. She reached for it and it was not there, and what came instead, in the place where her joke lived, was the smallest and truest thing in the room.

"I shattered my own core," Amber said. "You both know that. I did it to say goodbye, when they took my parents, I broke the light in myself on purpose because I couldn't stand to feel it where they'd been. And this." She touched the necklace, the dead woman's gift that held what was left of her core alight, and this time she knew her hand was there. "This is what holds me together, a thing a dead woman made, around a wound I made, and I have spent ten years being the girl who chose to be less than she was." She looked at Viridia, and the heat was gone and the grief was gone and what was left was only the asking, stripped right down. "If you do your thing. Your whole-world thing. Without asking. You'd mend me too. Wouldn't you. I'd be one of the cores. I'd wake up one morning whole and not know why, and the thing I chose, the goodbye I broke myself to say, you'd undo it, because you decided being whole is better than the choice I made out of my own grief with my own two hands." Her voice did not crack this time. It was past cracking. "That's the part the council never had to look at. The robe didn't have a friend on the table. You do. I'm on the table, Vee. I'm a core. When you sit there weighing the right to fix everyone,

you are weighing the right to fix *me*, and I never asked you to, and I'm the one who told you to knock the little doors first." The bun-woman's lesson, turned all the way around. "Note it. That's all. I'm noting it. I'm on the sheet now. You can't leave me off the way you left off the dragon."

And Viridia, who had heard the whole of the argument and lost it and stood in it level, felt that one land in the place the argument had not reached, somewhere below the part of her that did the sums, because Amber had taken the question out of the chamber and the wood and the world entire and set it down on a single bench in a single sickroom, in the shape of one person she loved who had chosen her own wound on purpose and would have it healed against her will, and there was no arithmetic for that. There was only the face of her friend, asking to be asked.

"I see you," Viridia said. It was all she had. "You're on the sheet. I won't pretend you're not a core. You're a core, and you're the one I'd be undoing a goodbye in, and I don't have the right to it, and if I ever reach for the whole world I will know, every moment of it, that I'm reaching past your no to do it." She did not soften it. To soften it would be to lie, and Amber would rather be told the truth at a wound than soothed at one. "That's not a promise not to. It's a promise to carry it as exactly what it is. It's the only honest thing I've got, and I'm sorry it isn't more, and I won't dress it up, because you didn't dress yours up."

Amber held her eyes a long moment, and then she nodded, once, and picked her joke back up off the floor where it had been waiting, because she had to, because she was Amber and a serious thing did not leave the room she was in without one.

"Well," she said. "This has been the worst conversation I've ever had, and I once watched a man die. So. Congratulations. You've outdone a death." It came out wet.

She let it. "I'm keeping the note open. I reserve the right to ask it again every single day until this is over, and you're going to let me, because you owe me a wire I never got to un-carry." She rose, and her legs were slow under her, the bone-deep tiredness that was in everyone now. "I have to go pack the children's slates. Two hundred people are walking out of here in a day and somebody has to make sure the little ones can still spell the old word for being safe when there isn't a wall left to write it behind."

She went to the door, and stopped with her hand on it, and did not turn around.

"You didn't win," she said, to the door. "And you didn't cheat your way out, and you didn't make me feel small for asking. You just stood there and let it be true. I don't know what to do with that. I came in here to be furious at you and you've left me nothing to be furious at except the world, and the world won't even hold still for it." A breath. "That's the worst trick you've got, Vee. Being honest at me. Nobody can stay angry through it. It's not fair. None of this is fair." And she went out, into the camp that was packing itself to march, and let the thin door fall shut behind her.

* * *

Jazen sat with the grey hand a while after she had gone, and Viridia stood, and neither of them moved to fill the room with anything, because there was nothing the right size to put in it, and they had both learned, in their different houses of grief, that you do not insult a true silence by talking over it.

"She's better than both of us," Jazen said, at last. "You know that. The conscience usually is. It's why we don't make them generals." He pressed his thumb gently to the back of Hiram's fallen hand, the way you check whether a person is still warm, and the man was still warm, barely, and Jazen

took his thumb away. "I meant it, what I said. The mirror. I'm not here to tell you to act and I'm not here to tell you not to. I'm telling you the road has a ditch on both sides and I've been lying in the left one for two years calling it high ground. Don't take that as counsel. Take it as a warning from a man who can't tell you which side of the road is worse because he's only ever been in the one ditch."

"I know which ditch I'm afraid of," Viridia said.

"Hers. The council's. The acting." Jazen almost smiled, the grief coming up under the flat for just a second. "Of course you are. You're the one who could actually do it. The ditch you're afraid of is always the one you could fall into. I'm afraid of yours and you're afraid of mine and that's most of why my mother would have wanted you in this camp, because between the two of us we're afraid of every wrong road there is, and a war wants people who are afraid of the right things." He stood. He took up the marching-list off the bench, and left the bread, and looked at the broadsheet a moment, and left that too, the camp's lie and the camp's food side by side for whoever needed either. "Eat that. The old one told you to and so do I. A girl carrying a question that size shouldn't carry it hungry."

"Drake said the same about the symbol."

"Then the dragon and I agree on one thing, which is more than I'd have bet on." He went toward the door, and the flat came back over his face as he went, the war pulling him back into itself, two hundred people and a road. "We weigh the last door tonight. The councilor. The real one, with a seat at the table." He had his hand on the latch. "I sent the thread out this morning, before the broadsheet, on my mother's old line. I didn't tell you because I didn't know if it still ran. It runs." He looked back at her, and there was something behind the rawness of his face that was, against everything, almost hope, which in that face after that morning was

harder to look at than grief. "He answered an hour ago. Not up the wire. They'll have a tap on the wire now, after the poster, so he didn't use it; he sent a man, on foot, the slow careful way, which means he's more afraid than the desk-man ever was and means more by it. He'll meet. Not a letter. Himself. In a room, the way you said you only ever wanted, an hour of his time and your eyes on the proof of it." He opened the door on the camp and the grey light and the noise of a village folding itself up to walk. "In secret. Three nights from now. The last door, Viridia. And after the morning we've had, I'll be honest with you the way the old one taught you to be. I don't know whether it's a door or a grave dressed as one. But it's the last one that isn't the wall. And you asked me to spend every one of them before you'd touch the wall. So we'll spend this one."

He went out. The door fell shut.

And Viridia stood alone with Hiram's slow breathing and the lamp and the bread she was finally, slowly, going to make herself eat, and the question Amber had set down on the bench between the food and the lie, the question that had no answer that survived being said, sitting now exactly the size it truly was, which was the size of one friend who had chosen her own wound and would have it healed against her will. Somewhere beyond the painted forest a man on foot was carrying word back to a councilor who held a seat in the chamber itself, the last door that was not the wall, three nights off. And Viridia did the only thing there was left to do with a question that large and a door that thin.

She picked up the bread. And she ate it. And she did not let her hands shake, because there was still a great deal to do, and a person carrying both the unmaking and a question with no floor under it ought not walk into the last room there was on nothing at all.

CHAPTER TEN

The Almost

The room they had got for the last door was a back room in a railway hotel two valleys over, the kind of place where men who sold grain to the army stayed one night and left no name in the book, and it smelled of cold coal-smoke off the line and of the wax somebody had rubbed into the table fifty years ago and never since, and Viridia kept to the window of it with the curtain held an inch off the frame and watched the slow particular way the councilor came across the yard, on foot, in a coat too plain for the man inside it, the way a rich man dresses down and gets it slightly wrong, the cut too good for the cloth. She marked the wrongness of it. She could not yet say what it would come to mean.

Jazen sat at the table behind her with his palms pressed flat to the wax, not moving them, which in Jazen meant the same as Viridia going still. He had not slept. None of them had. The camp two valleys back was a half-folded thing now, the wards still up but the carts loaded under them. A man who has loaded the carts and then walked away from them to sit in a stranger's hotel knows the weight of what he is gambling on the next hour. Jazen sat under that weight. He let it press him and did not flinch off it.

"He came alone," Viridia said, to the curtain.

"He said he would."

"Men say that." She let the curtain fall. "He did, though. No second man in the yard and no third in the lane and nobody on the roof of the goods-shed where I'd have put a man if I were the kind to bring one." She turned from the window. "He's afraid. He's wearing a poor man's coat to be nobody and he's checked over his own shoulder four times on the way in and his hands are cold even through the wool, I can see it in how he carries them. He didn't bring anyone because he was afraid of who he'd have to trust to bring them. That's not the same as brave. But it's better, for us, than brave."

"Both, maybe," Jazen said. "Sometimes a man's afraid and good in the same coat. My mother always said that was the only kind of ally worth the having. The ones who aren't afraid haven't understood the price yet."

* * *

The councilor came in without a knock, the way the truly frightened do, quick through a door so the corridor sees them for less of a breath, and he shut it behind him and put his back to it for a moment with his eyes closed, an old man getting his breath and his nerve back in the same pull of air, and then he opened his eyes and looked at the two of them and did the thing none of the others had done, not the careful desk-man on the rail-wire with his three cold words, not anyone.

He turned to Viridia first. Not to Jazen, the known quantity, the man with the name and the price on it. To the girl. He took in the slip of a girl by the window with the silver-blond hair worn loose and the dark-blue stone at her throat and the four spears wrapped in oilcloth leaning in the corner where she could reach them, and a thing crossed his face that Viridia had seen before only on Drake, the day on the mountain, the look of a thing very old and very tired

meeting a thing it had been told could not exist and finding it standing in a hotel room being ordinary.

"You're the one," he said. "The letters said a girl. I told them it was a figure of speech. A movement calls itself a child to seem harmless." He took off the cap he'd worn down over his face and turned it in his hands the way Jazen turned his when the grief was up. "You're an actual child."

"I'm what wrote the letters," Viridia said. "If that's what you mean."

"It is. It's exactly what I mean, and it's worse than I'd hoped, and I came here half hoping you'd be a fraud, do you understand, I came on foot in a coal-man's coat half praying you'd be some clever older man who'd built a tale around a girl, because that I'd know what to do with. A liar I can manage. I've managed liars my whole life in that chamber. I have no handling at all for the thing the letters describe being true, and being true in a child, and looking at me from a window like she's already counted the exits." He sat down across from Jazen, heavily, and set the cap on the wax. "Sit, child. Or stand. I find I don't much care which. I came to be told the truth to my face and I'm too old and too frightened to manage manners on top of it."

* * *

She told him. Not all of it. She told him the part the letters held: that the gift had two sides and had always had two, that six hundred years ago a council in a chamber not unlike his own had decided to cut every person alive down to one side and tell them the half was the whole, that it had been done on purpose and could be read in any living core by anyone who had the eyes, and that she had the eyes, and that the school had burned because the people who burned it could not afford the eyes to go on existing.

She did not tell him she could give it back. She had decided that in the night, with Amber's question sitting where it sat now and would always sit. The last door was a door for peace, and a man does not walk through a door for peace if you have shown him on the threshold that you hold the power to remake him whether he opens it or not. So she told him the wrong and not the remedy, the wound and not her hand, and Jazen, who knew exactly which half she was withholding and why, sat unmoving and let her hold it.

The councilor listened the way old men listen who have spent their lives in rooms where listening is the work itself, without moving, with his eyes on the middle distance, and when she had finished he was quiet a long while, and the train-line outside let a goods-train go by, slow, the floor of the room humming with it, the wax table buzzing faintly under the cap, and when it had passed and the humming died he put his hand over his own eyes for a moment and took it away.

"I voted against the war," he said. "Twice. You'll have known that or you wouldn't have spent a runner walking to reach me. I voted against it because I thought it was expensive and unwinnable and beneath us, and I made all my arguments in the language of cost, because that's the language the chamber speaks and I'm fluent in it and I've never once, in forty years, made an argument in the language of right, because the language of right doesn't carry a vote." He looked at her. "You've just made one to me in a railway hotel and it carried. I haven't the first idea what to do with that. I'm a man who's spent forty years being careful and you've walked a war's worth of truth into a back room and set it on the table next to my cap and now I have to decide, at my age, in this coat, whether I'm a man who knew a thing and did nothing or a man who knew it and moved. I

didn't want this. Hear me say it plainly. I didn't want this. I came here to be able to say I'd looked and found nothing."

"And you found something," Jazen said. Quietly.

"I found a child who counts the exits and tells the truth like she's setting down something heavy she's been carrying a long way, and an old story that explains forty years of things I'd filed under *unfortunate* and never let myself add up." The cap turned in his hands. "Yes. I found something. God help me. I found something."

* * *

While they talked, Viridia had Lightwell's papers in the satchel between her boots, the whole compartmented cache of them that Jazen had finally given her entire, not the few sheets he'd shown the camp but all of it, and somewhere in the night between the sickroom and this room she had read them through, the way you read a dead person's hand when there is nothing else left of the voice, slowly, touching each page longer than the reading of it took.

She had read the routes and the names and the small careful sums of a woman who had run a secret thing inside a public school for years. And near the bottom of the deepest fold she had found the note. Not the original. The original had gone into Hazel's furnace with everything else of that night. But a fair copy in Lightwell's own hand, the same weightless precise letters she'd seen on the school's order-sheets, copying out word for word the unsigned note that had been packed in the case with Viridia's mother's focus, *she would hear it if it came from the right mouth*. And under the copy, in the same hand, a single line that was not part of the note, that was Lightwell talking to herself across the years: *sent it myself, the coward's way, unsigned, so she could refuse it without refusing me*. And that was the answer to the question that had sat open since her first weeks at Hazel:

who wrote the unsigned note. The answer was that the woman in the rose-tinted spectacles had written it and had not signed it on purpose, so that a frightened mother could say no to a stranger and not to a friend. Viridia had read that line four times in the cold of the night and set it with the other things Lightwell had done that she would never now be able to thank her for.

There had been one more thing in the fold. Half a page of a family line, a tree set down in the same hand with the small square boxes and the lines running down, light mages mostly, a few names she half-knew from the chamber, and the tree ran clean and orderly the way such trees do, generation under generation, until near the bottom there was a name that did not sit in its box right. The hand had drawn it the same as the others. But the line that should have run down into it ran from nowhere the page showed, and the line that should have run out of it stopped. And beside it, faint, almost rubbed away, Lightwell had pencilled three small words and then scored them out so hard the paper had nearly torn, so that Viridia could see there had been three words and could not read one of them, only the violence of their crossing-out. It was a woman striking through her own writing the way you strike through a thing you have decided you were wrong to have set down, or a thing you are afraid to have set down. Either way it sat in Viridia's chest now exactly where it had sat all night, a name that did not fit its own tree and three words the dead woman had been afraid to leave standing. She could not read what it meant, and she had decided, in the night, that she did not need to read it tonight. It would keep. The dead kept their secrets better than the living. She let it stay closed, the not-knowing and all. It was not yet hers to open. She came back to the railway room and the old man turning his cap, and she let the family-tree name sit unread down in the

satchel like a stone in a pocket you keep meaning to take out and never do.

* * *

"What would you need," Jazen said. "To move. Say it plain. We don't have the time for the chamber's long way round."

The councilor told them. He could not stop a war alone, he said, no one man could, but he was not alone, he was the loud end of a quiet thing, there were others, four he could name and three more he suspected, men and women in the chamber who had voted the cost-arguments with him and might vote a right-argument if one of them stood up first and made it and did not die of the standing. He could call a closed session. He could put the truth of the severing on the floor, with a witness, the girl herself, masked or screened if it came to that, and force the chamber to look at the thing it had decided six hundred years ago and had been re-deciding by inaction every day since. It might fail. It would probably fail. But it had not been tried, not once, not in six centuries, because no one who knew had ever lived long enough or stood close enough to the floor to try it, and he was old and frightened and close enough to the floor, and there was now, as there had never once been in six centuries, a witness who could not be called a liar because she could show the thing in the cores of the very men who'd deny it.

It nearly worked. That was the part Viridia would carry. It was not a fool's hope and it was not a trap, or if it was a trap the man springing it did not know he was the bait. It was a real door, with a real room waiting past it, and a real old man genuinely moved, deciding in front of her, at the end of a careful life, to be brave the expensive way, and for the length of one slow goods-train and one old man's breath the war had a shape that did not end in the thing Amber had asked

her about, and Viridia, who never allowed herself hope, allowed it, for that length, almost.

"Three days," the councilor said. "I need three days to reach the four and the three. Quietly. On foot or by the slow lines, nothing on the wire, the wire's not safe, they've had a tap on it since the broadsheet. Three days, then a closed session, and then we see what an old coward's worth when he finally spends himself." He stood. He put his cap back on, down over his face, nobody again. "I'm glad you were real, child. I'm terrified you were real. Both, in the same coat. Your mother's friend was right about that being the only kind worth having."

He had his hand on the latch when the window went bright.

* * *

It was not bright the way a lamp is bright. It was bright the way the air goes bright a half-second before you understand it is light from outside coming in, and Viridia was already moving, already had the cold working part of her reading the room before the slow part had named the thing, and the thing was a lens. A true-seer's lens. Somewhere across the yard, on the roof of the goods-shed where she had checked and found no one, someone had been there after all, had come in the half-hour they talked, and was turning a glass-of-true-seeing on the back-room window, and the brightness was the lens drinking the room and throwing back what it found, and what it found was the thing Viridia had spent every coin of her care to keep banked, because in the surprise of it, in the half-second of the window going wrong, her furnace had come up off its flicker the way a long-held breath escapes all at once, and the lens had caught the whole of her lit.

She killed it. Two ways at once. The spear came out of the oilcloth and into her hand and through the window-glass and across the yard faster than the old man could turn his head, and behind it, under it, the death-symbol Drake had taught her, drawn small and clean in the air over the goods-shed roof, the symbol that ends any magic, and the lens went dark mid-drink, the true-seeing in it simply over, the glass a glass again. But a glass that has drunk and sent before it dies has already sent. The network did not need the lens to live. It only needed the lens to have looked, once, and the looking had gone up the line to the next glass and the next, the way the capital's true-sight ran now, glass to glass to the silver frames on the Chancellor's own short bald head, and Viridia stood in the railway room with a spear-arm still extended and knew, before anyone in the room had finished flinching, that the meeting was not secret anymore and had not been for the length of a sent breath, and that somewhere in the capital a short man in silver frames had just watched a chamber councilor stand in a hotel with the dark mage and the girl from the broadsheet, and had a face to go with the votes.

"They saw," she said. It came out level and stripped. "The roof. A seer. I have killed the glass. I have not killed the seeing. They have your face, councilor. They had it before I broke the lens. I'm sorry. I checked the roof. I checked it twice. He came after." She lowered the arm. "He came after, and I let myself be surprised, and the cost of my being surprised is yours, and there's no part of that I can give you back."

The old man had gone the colour of Hiram on the pallet. He stood with his hand still on the latch and did not open the door, because there was nowhere past it to go that the seeing had not already gone first.

"Three days," he said. To himself. "I needed three days." He laughed, once, a dry broken sound, the kind that is only terror with nowhere to be. "And I had a quarter of an hour. They didn't even let me have the three days to be brave in. They took the bravery before I could spend it." He looked at her, and there was no blame in it, which was worse than blame. "Don't be sorry, child. I checked the roof too, on the way in. I checked it and saw nothing and came in glad. We were both careful men in poor coats and it was never going to be enough against a thing that can put an eye on a roof we already searched. Go. Both of you. Go now and go fast and don't go back the way you came. I'll manage what's left of my quarter-hour."

* * *

What was left of it was short.

They were two valleys gone, back over the goods-line on a hand-trolley Jazen pumped with the flat grief-fueled strength of a man who would not stop to feel the thing yet, when the capital answered, and it answered not on the wire and not on foot but in the manner the capital used for everything now, all at once and to everyone, the broadsheets going out from the presses before the ink could have dried on the morning's session, which meant the session had not waited for a session, which meant the Chancellor had not bothered with the chamber at all.

Jazen had a scout meet them at the trackside with the first of it, a boy white to the lips, and the boy did not say it, he only held the sheet out, and Viridia took it and read it the cold way, because there was no other part of her that could have held it level.

TOTAL WAR, the type said, the whole width of the page. And under it, smaller, the chamber councilor's name, the old man's name, the man who had turned his cap and

decided to be brave, named as a traitor taken in the very act of treating with the dark corruption, taken with the girl and the dark mage themselves, and Viridia read past the word *taken* looking for the word that would tell her what *taken* meant, and found it lower down, set in the same flat type as the grain prices, the way the capital set the deaths of men it wanted no one to mourn. The word was that the traitor had been dealt with under the emergency law that very morning, and *dealt with* was a word the capital used the way it used *blinded* for a man whose glasses it crushed, except that this time it meant the full thing, it meant the old man in the poor coat was not going to manage what was left of his quarter-hour or anything else, and Viridia folded the wrongness of that into the place where the wrongness lived and kept it off her face entirely, because the boy was watching and the boy was white to the lips already and a girl who breaks in front of a frightened boy has taught him there is nothing left to hold him up.

But that was not the worst of the sheet. The worst of the sheet was the woodcut.

* * *

They had cut a block for it, which meant they had had it ready, which meant the parade was not the answer to the meeting, the parade was the thing they had been waiting to attach a meeting to, and Viridia understood that the way she understood the off-cut coat, all at once and after the fact, that the old man had never had three days because the capital had never been negotiating the existence of a peace, it had been holding a parade in reserve waiting for a door to slam on so it could call the slamming a war.

The woodcut showed the captives. The dark corruption's victims, the type called them, rescued from the schools the dark mages burned. It showed them in a line, in chains, on a

cart, paraded up the capital's main way past the chamber steps for the crowd to fear and pity. The cutter had been good. The cutter had got faces, and Viridia made herself look at the faces the way she went at every hard thing, on purpose and to the end, and she found the one she was looking for third from the left, a heavysset girl with long hair and a wide mouth, and the cutter had even got the tooth, the one tooth turned a little out of the line of the others, because the cutter had cut what he saw and what he saw was Alice Pembroke in chains on a cart being shown to a city as proof that girls like Viridia were a thing to be afraid of.

Alice. Alive. The woodcut said alive. The chains said it too. You do not chain the dead. You chain the living to walk them. And the relief of that came up in Viridia exactly as sharp and exactly as ruinous as it had come the day the rumor first reached her, because alive on a cart in chains past the chamber steps was alive in the deepest part of the place that wanted Viridia dead, alive as a thing the enemy had decided to use. Viridia stood at the trackside with the sheet in her two hands and the boy watching and Jazen come round the trolley to read it over her shoulder, and she did the only thing there was to do with a friend's face turned to a woodcut to frighten a city: fold the sheet so the face was inside it and not showing, slowly, careful as a thing turned face-down in a sickroom, and put it in the satchel beside Lightwell's papers and the name that did not fit its tree.

"Every door," Jazen said. His voice did the flat thing. He had read past the woodcut to the same words she had, the old man's name and *dealt with*. "You made me promise to knock on every last door before we touched the wall. The desk-man on the wire. The light-mages by letter. The councilor walked in on foot. That was the last one that wasn't the wall, Viridia. And they didn't shut it. We didn't shut it. *They* shut it, and they shut it with a block they'd already cut,

which means they were always going to. There was never a door. There was only a hallway they let us walk down so they could nail the end of it shut behind us with a man's life and call us the ones who built the wall."

"I know it," Viridia said.

"I need you to know it the right way. Not as a thing to grieve. As a thing that's true. You spent every door. You spent them honestly. You held the worst thing you could do in reserve and you knocked on every smaller one with your bare knuckles until they were bloody, and the wall that's in front of us now is not a wall you walked us into. It's a wall they built across the only road out, with the bodies of the men who'd have opened the doors. Whatever you do now, you do it on the far side of having tried everything. I will say that to your face for the rest of my life if you need me to. You did not choose the wall. The wall was chosen for you, by the people who burned the school, and they chose it this morning, with a man's head, before he could spend the bravery you gave him."

* * *

She did not answer that. There was no answer the right size for it, and she had learned in a sickroom three nights gone not to insult a true thing by putting a smaller one over it. She stood at the trackside in the cold coal-smell with the folded sheet in the satchel and the goods-line humming faintly the way the wax table had hummed under the train, and she let the thing be as large as it was. It was the size of every road run out at once: the desk-man and the letters and the old man in the poor coat, all of them tried, all of them honest, all of them ended not by her hand but by the silver frames on a short bald head. And behind every one of them, growing now where the doors had been, was the one thing she had sworn she would not reach for while any door stood open. Now no

door stood open. The wall and the unforgivable thing behind it had become, by the capital's own choosing and not hers, the only road left that was not lying down to die.

It was the boy who pulled her back into the moving world, and he pulled her back into the worst of it without knowing he was doing anything but his job, which was to carry what the scouts carried.

"There's a last thing," the boy said. White still. Younger said out loud than he'd looked. "Ferro sent me ahead with the sheet but he stayed to listen on the south line, and he sent the second thing up after, by runner, not voice, because—" He swallowed. "Because the seer that looked at the hotel. Before you broke his glass. Ferro says the capital's putting out that he didn't just look at the room. He says they're putting out that a true-glass can backtrack a thing it's caught lit. That once it's drunk a mage burning, it can follow the line of her back to where she banks. Like a thread to its root." The boy's hands were shaking on nothing now, the sheet already passed over. "Ferro says he doesn't know if it's true or if it's a thing they're saying to frighten us into moving wrong. But you came up off your flicker in that room. You said so. The glass caught you lit. And if it's true, and if it followed the line of you back the way Ferro's afraid it can—" He stopped. He could not say the rest of it. He was a boy and the rest of it was the whole half-folded camp two valleys away, all those people, the one place in the world that would have had any of them, and he could not be the one to put it into words.

Viridia said it for him, level, because someone had to and a girl who has run out of every other place to put her hands can at least carry the saying of a thing so a frightened boy does not have to.

"Then they know where the camp is," she said. "Or they will. They followed me home."

She turned to Jazen, and Jazen was already turning to the trolley, already had his hands on the pump-bar, the grief gone down under the war the way it always went, fuel and not feeling, and the two of them stood for one breath on the goods-line with every door behind them nailed shut over a dead man's name and the one road left running straight into the thing she could not justify, and ahead of them, two valleys off, under a ward held now by two spent men and a girl who had just been followed home, the camp, folding itself down for the road and not yet knowing it might already be too late to be the ones who chose the day.

"Then we don't go to the camp," Jazen said. "We *beat* the thing to the camp." He threw his weight onto the bar. The trolley took it. Slow, then faster. The goods-line unrolled ahead of them into the painted hills. "Pump, Viridia. Whatever you've got left in those arms, put it here. We are racing a glass home, and the glass doesn't get tired, and we do, so we'd better not start."

She put what she had into the bar, both arms, already counting the valleys and the grade and the light left in the day, and behind them the broadsheet's ink dried on a city being taught to fear a child, and folded down in the satchel a dead woman's crossed-out three words kept their secret, and ahead the camp had no warning yet at all, and Viridia pumped the trolley faster into the closing afternoon and kept her hands from shaking on the bar, because the day was not done with her, and would not be for a long while yet.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Cost of Hiding

They beat the glass to the camp by the length of a held breath, which is to say they did not beat it at all. They only arrived first, which is a different thing. Viridia understood the difference in the moment the trolley topped the last grade and she saw the valley still whole below her: the smoke of the cookfires standing up straight in the windless afternoon, the long table out under the elms with the children at it and Mirelle moving down the bench with the baby on her hip, and the wards still up over all of it, holding, invisible to anyone who did not have the eyes. And Viridia had the eyes, and so she could see the thing the rest of them could not: that the ward was already thinning at its eastern edge the way ice thins from underneath before it shows a crack on top. The thinning was not the ward failing of its own age but the ward being read, somewhere off east, by a thing that had followed the line of her home and was now standing at the door of it learning the shape of the lock.

"It's here," she said. "It's already looking. East edge. We have minutes. Not hours."

Jazen did not ask her how she knew. He had stopped asking that two valleys back. He threw the trolley's brake and was off it before it stopped rolling, down the cinder bank toward the camp at the long flat run of a man who has been waiting his whole life to be too late and has finally arrived

exactly that, and Viridia took the spears out of the oilcloth, all four, and went after him into the one place in the world that would have had either of them, to spend the minutes it had left teaching it how to die.

* * *

There was no bell in the camp. There had never been a bell, because a bell is a thing the outside can hear, and the camp's whole life had been the practice of being a thing the outside could not hear, and so the alarm went the way alarms go in a place that has trained itself to silence, person to person, a hand on a shoulder, a word said low and once and not repeated, and it moved through the cookfires and the carts and the half-loaded wagons faster than a bell would have and with none of a bell's comfort, because a bell at least tells you someone else has heard it too, and a hand on the shoulder tells you only that the thing has reached you.

Jazen took the loading-yard, because that was where the bodies were and where the road out was, and his voice did the flat thing and carried the way it carried, and Viridia watched the camp turn from a place into a leaving, the wagons that had been half-loaded for three days now loaded the rest of the way at a run, the children pulled in off the long table, the old ones who could not run set on the carts first because they took the longest to set and there was no time to do the kind thing slowly.

She found Hiram against the anchor-post.

He had not got up. He could not get up, she saw, not anymore; the blade under the collarbone in the spring had taken something out of him that the healer's drawing of it had not put back, and he sat against the post he had helped raise the way he had sat against it since Ferro's runner first brought the word two valleys back, grey, spare, his hand flat to the wood the way Jazen pressed his palms flat to a table,

and the ward ran up out of his hand into the air above the camp the way it ran up out of Abe's two posts down and out of the third post that had been Hiram's full strength once and was now only the memory of it.

"It's reading the east edge," she told him. "I can see it. It's learning the ward."

"I know." His voice was the voice of a man speaking from the bottom of a well. "I can feel it learning. It's like being read a letter you wrote, by someone who means to use it against you." He turned his hand a fraction on the post, and the ward held, and the effort of the holding stood out on him like a fever. "Abe can't carry it alone. I tried, in the spring. A ward this size wants three. We have two and a half, and the half is going, and once it goes the whole thing comes down at once, not slow. So here's the arithmetic, girl, and you're the only one who'll do the arithmetic instead of arguing it. I can hold it up while it comes down. For a while. Not long. But the difference between *it falls* and *I let it fall slow* is the difference between the wagons being out on the road and the wagons being still in the yard when the looking turns to the striking. You understand me."

She understood him. The cold working part understood him before the whole of her had finished hearing it. She had spent her whole banked life learning to do arithmetic that the people doing it would not survive, and here was a grey man against a post offering her the answer to a sum she had not wanted to set down.

"Yes," she said.

"Then don't waste my holding by standing here being sorry at me." Something in his grey face that was almost the ghost of the kindness the camp had been built out of. "Go and be the thing they're afraid of. I'll keep the roof on as long as there's a roof to keep. When it comes off, it'll come off all at once, and you'll know, because the sky will change. Get

the children past the elms before the sky changes. That's all I'm buying you. Spend it well."

* * *

The sky changed forty minutes later, and it changed in the manner of all the worst things, which is to say after a stretch of nearly believing it would not.

For forty minutes the camp came apart in good order. The wagons loaded and rolled, the children went out past the elms in two strings with the older girls Amber had drilled walking the flanks, the old ones went on the carts, and for forty minutes the ward held over the leaving and the thing east of the valley could read the lock and could not yet break it, and Viridia stood among the elms counting heads onto the road with the cold working part and let herself, for the length of it, believe the arithmetic might come out kind, that Hiram's holding might buy enough, that the camp would be empty of everything but timber and cookfires by the time the looking turned to the striking and the capital would strike a place that nobody was in.

She should have known better. She had let herself believe in the *almost* in a railway room not three days gone, and the believing had cost an old man his head before he could be brave with it, and she had told herself at the trackside that she would not do it again, and she had done it again within the week, because hope is not a thing you decide about, it is a thing that happens to you while you are deciding about other things.

Then Hiram let the roof come off.

He did not let it fall, at the end. That was the thing she carried. She felt it through the soles of her boots before she saw it, the ward not collapsing but being *set down*, the way you set down a great weight you have carried to the exact edge of where you can carry it, deliberately, in the one place

where setting it down will do the least harm, and the air above the camp went from the held stillness of a warded place to the ordinary thinness of open valley, and the smoke of the dead cookfires that had stood up straight all afternoon bent suddenly east in a wind that had been there all along and that the ward had been holding off, and the camp, the one place in the world, stood revealed under the open sky to anything that cared to look.

A great many things cared to look.

* * *

They came over the east ridge as the capital did everything now, all at once and to everyone, a line of them dark against the bright sky and then not a line but a falling, fire-mages mostly, the cheap brutal half of the gift the capital had spent six hundred years pretending was the whole of it. They did not parley and they did not demand a surrender and they did not, Viridia understood in the first half-second of seeing them, regard the camp as a thing to be taken, because you take a thing you want, and they did not want the camp; they wanted it gone. The order they carried was to make a valley where a camp had been into a valley where one had not, and that is a simpler instruction than taking, and it is carried out faster.

The first fire came down on the loading-yard.

Viridia was already moving. She had been moving since the smoke bent east. And in the moving she did the thing her whole banked life had been the practice of never doing, the thing the lens had caught her at in the railway room and that she had killed a glass to unsay and could not unsay now and would not have unsaid if she could, because there was no longer any reason in the world to keep it banked: she came up off her flicker entirely, the whole furnace of her up at once, and she did not care who saw, because the thing that

would have read her was already here and the reading no longer mattered, only the burning did.

She put the first fire out in the air.

The unmaking-stroke Drake had drilled into her hand on the mountain, the one that puts an end to any working, drawn vast now and fast, not the small clean thing she had made over a goods-shed roof but a great rough killing stroke across the whole falling arc of the fire, and the fire that should have taken the loading-yard and everyone setting the last cart in it simply stopped being fire, the magic in it over, and what came down on the yard was warm ash and no more, and the people in the yard did not even know how close it had come, which was the first mercy and very nearly the last.

She could not do it again fast enough. That was the arithmetic of the unleashing, and she learned it in the next ten breaths. One fire she could unmake. Two she could unmake if they came close together. But they did not come one and two, they came in a falling rain of them, eight and ten and twelve across the whole spread of the camp at once, and she had one hand and one symbol and one furnace however high it was banked up, and a girl with the eyes and the will and the whole of her power up and showing is still one girl, and a valley is wide.

She chose. The cold working part chose, because nothing else in her could have. She let the timber burn. She let the empty wagons burn and the cookhouse and the long table under the elms where Mirelle had taught the children Moravian, and she spent her unmaking only on the fires that were falling toward people, and she ran the camp's width doing it, and she saved, she would count it later, she would count it for the rest of her life, she saved perhaps two in three of the fires that mattered, and the third one she did not reach, and the third one was the arithmetic she had not been

able to do fast enough, and the third one was the cost of having a body that could only be in one place and a power that could only end one fire at a time.

* * *

She reached the long table last, because the long table was deepest in, under the elms, the safe heart of the camp where the children were kept, and safe heart is a phrase that means nothing to fire that comes from above.

Mirelle had the children under the table.

She had got them under it, all of them, the dozen small ones who had been at the bench and could not run the way the older strings had run, and she had put the long table between them and the sky: the table she had taught them at, the table that had stood for the camp being a place where children were taught Moravian as though there would be a world for them to need it in. She was on her knees at the open end of it with her back to the sky and her arms spread across the gap and the baby still, somehow, on her hip, because a widow who has carried a baby through two winters of a hidden war does not set it down to do the last thing; she does the last thing with it on her. And Viridia saw all of that in the half-second she had, the table and the children under it and the woman's spread arms and the one crooked tooth showing because Mirelle's mouth was open, not screaming, counting. She was counting the small ones under the bench out loud so they would have a voice that was not the sky's to listen to.

The fire came down on the table.

Viridia was four strides too far. The cold working part had measured the strides before she finished seeing them and had returned the answer that there were four too many of them, and she made the strides anyway, all of them, and drew the symbol anyway, and the symbol reached the fire a

half-breath after the fire reached the woman, which is the cruelest of all the distances, near enough to know exactly what you failed by and not near enough to have not failed by it.

The ones beneath it lived. Every one of them. The table held, scorched black and the elm above it gone to torch, but the table held, because Mirelle's back had held it the half-breath the table needed, and the children under it came out the far side into Amber's arms grey with ash and alive and counting, some of them, still counting, the way she had taught them, because the last thing a person teaches you is the thing you do in the dark afterward.

Mirelle did not come out. Viridia knelt in the warm ash at the open end of the table and the woman was face down across the gap with her arms still spread, and the baby was crying, and the baby was alive, the woman's body had been the table for the baby the way the table had been the roof for the rest, and Viridia lifted the baby out from under the arm with the part of her that was not the cold working part, the small remaining part, and held it against her, and it cried into her collar, and she kept her face the careful face over the top of its small head because Amber was three strides off with the other children and a girl who breaks where the children can see her has taught them the dark has won.

She filed it. There was no other thing to do with it in the moment and she had only ever had the one thing to do with the unbearable, which was to put it whole into the place she kept and shut the place and carry it. She filed the outstretched arms and the counting and the crooked tooth and the warm ash, all of it, away under the heading she kept for the things she had been four strides too far to stop, and she carried the baby out to Amber, and she went back into the burning to do more arithmetic, because the valley was

wide and the fires were still falling and the cold working part had not finished counting heads.

* * *

Brutus she found at the cookhouse, which had been the first thing he built and was the thing he died defending, except that he did not die there, the dying of him was a longer thing than one afternoon, and would not finish for a long while yet, and what she found at the cookhouse was only the start of it.

He had a beam. He was a broad man, sunburned even now under the ash, and he had got a roof-beam up off the burning cookhouse and he was using it the way you use the only tool you have against the only enemy you have, which is to say wrongly and bravely, swinging the great beam at a fire-mage who had come down low to fire the last of the wagons, and the fire-mage burned him for it. Viridia saw the burning land. She unmade the second fire, the one meant to finish him, the symbol coming off her hand without her deciding it now, the unleashing become a kind of breathing, but she could not unmake the first one, the one already in him, the one that had gone in under the ribs where he had not got the beam up in time, because a fire already arrived is not a magic you can end, it is a wound, and wounds do not answer the symbol.

He went down against the cookhouse wall he had laid stone by stone. He was still holding the beam. He looked at her with the particular outrage of a man who built a thing with his hands and is watching it burn, which is an outrage that has no fear left over in it because all the room is taken up.

"I built this," he said. There was blood in it. "Two years. With my hands. I built every—" He stopped. He had run out of the breath for the rest of the sentence and there were only the four fingers of his free hand to finish it, lifting off the

beam to take in the cookhouse and the long table and the whole burning valley, *every bit of it*, and falling back. "Don't let them have the field too. Whatever's left. Don't let them have the field."

"I won't," she said. She did not know yet what the field was. She would learn it. The promise went down whole into her, the way Mirelle's outstretched arms had, a thing she would carry until she could spend it. "Hold on. Brutus. The healer's with the carts. Hold on to the beam."

"I'll hold on to the beam," he said, and he did, he held on to the beam the whole way out, they got him onto the last cart still holding it, a broad sunburned man with a roof-beam across his lap and a fire-wound under his ribs that the healer's hands could slow and could not close, and that was the start of Brutus's dying and not the end of it, and she knew already, looking at him hold the beam, that he would hold it a long way yet before the field took him, and that she would be glad, later, in the way you are glad of cruel things, that the cookhouse had not been the end, that he had got to see what the field was before he paid for it.

* * *

By dark the camp was gone and the valley was a valley where a camp had been.

The fire-mages did not stay to be sure. They never stayed; staying was a thing you did to a place you wanted, and they had been sent to unmake and they had unmade and they went back over the east ridge before the last of the timber had finished falling, dark against a dark sky now, the day's work done, a line again and then nothing, and the silence they left was the silence of the ward gone forever, the open thin silence of a valley that nothing was hiding anymore because there was nothing left in it to hide.

The survivors gathered on the road past the elms where the children had gone out, in the dark, by the carts, and there were more of them than Viridia had let herself hope and fewer of them than there should have been, and the arithmetic of the more and the fewer would keep her counting for the rest of her life. Amber had the children. The baby was on the healer's wife's hip now, fed, quieted, alive, a thing Mirelle had made into a table with her own back. Brutus was on the last cart with the beam across his lap, grey, holding on. Abe sat against a cart-wheel with his hands shaking on nothing, the way Hiram's hands had shaken, because Abe had carried the half of the ward Hiram could not at the end and had felt the moment Hiram set the whole of it down.

Hiram they did not gather. Hiram had stayed at the anchor-post to set the roof down slow, and the anchor-post was ash, and there was nothing of him to put on a cart. Viridia stood on the road in the dark and did the arithmetic of that too: a grey man against a post had bought forty minutes with the last of himself, and the forty minutes had got the children out past the elms, every one of them, alive, counting, and the buying had cost the buyer everything and had been, by her count, the best-spent forty minutes in the valley. She filed the spending of it away under the heading she kept for the debts she would never be able to pay back, beside Lightwell's, beside the dead councilor's, the man dealt with before he could spend the bravery she had given him. The heading was getting crowded, and she kept her face the careful face over all of it, because the survivors were watching, the way the boy had watched, and to let them see her come apart now would be to tell them the failing was the whole of the story.

Only her breath changed. She let it, the once, where it could not be seen. The breath was the one tell she allowed

herself, in the dark, where the dark could have it and the people could not, and she stood with it on the road past the elms and let the valley be as large as it was, the arms across the gap and the counting and the crooked tooth, the beam across the lap, the post gone to ash, all of it, and did not put a smaller thing over any of it.

* * *

Jazen came up out of the dark and stood beside her, and he had ash on him to the elbows from the loading-yard and the flat thing was gone out of his voice, not because the grief was down but because they had finally come, the two of them, to the far edge of the thing the flat voice had been holding off.

He looked at the valley a long while. The cookfires were out. There were no cookfires. There was only the dull red of timber finishing its burning here and there across the dark, the way a thing glows after the flame of it has gone, and he looked at it, the camp he had built into the one place in the world that would have had any of them, and he said the thing the council had feared he would say since the first day they had begged him to wait, the thing Viridia had heard him want to say and watched him swallow week after week for the sake of every door she made him knock on, and he said it quietly, the way the truest things always got said in that camp, without heat, the heat all burned out of it now and only the iron left.

"There is nothing left to protect by waiting," Jazen said. He did not look at her when he said it. He looked at the red of the timber. "I built this so there would be somewhere to wait. So there'd be a thing the waiting was *for*. They burned the thing the waiting was for. So now I'll tell you what I told the council I'd never tell them, because it wasn't true while the camp stood and it's true now that it doesn't." He turned, finally, and there was nothing in his face but the iron and the

ash. "We don't wait for the right day anymore. We don't have a place left that the right day would save. We march now, Viridia. With what we've got. From the ash. Because the only thing the capital left us to protect is the one thing they can't burn down from a ridge, and that's whatever we do back. We march now, and we do not stop, and we do not knock on one more door, because there are no more doors and there is no more house, and the wall is the only thing standing in front of us, and the wall is where we were always going."

She looked at the valley with him, at the dull red going out across the dark where the one place in the world had been, and she did not tell him no. She had run out of the road that said no to him. She had spent it, every coin of it, on a desk-man and a packet of letters and a frightened old councilor who had walked in on foot to be brave, and the capital had taken the last of it that very week with an old man's head and a parade they'd readied in advance, and there was nothing past all that knocking but the wall, and Jazen standing in the ash of the thing he'd built, telling her the wall was where they were always going, and the worst of it, the thing she filed away last and deepest in the place she kept for what was true and could not be helped, was that he was right.

"We march now," she said. It came out flat and bare, the way the hardest things had always come out of her, and she held her hands still on the saying of it, because the survivors were close and the dark was full of them, and the day was not done with her, and would not be, she understood, until it was done with all of them. "From the ash. We march now."

CHAPTER TWELVE

Goodbyes

The road took them all morning to become an army. You do not declare an army into being along a night road. It assembles out of the wreckage of whatever it used to be, and what these people had used to be was a camp, and a camp is the opposite of an army in every way that matters, a camp being the practice of not being seen and an army being the practice of going to where you cannot help but be. So the first hours after the valley were not marching at all. They were the slow grim sorting-out of people who had loaded carts to flee and now had to unload the same carts to fight. Viridia walked the length of the column twice before sunrise in the unkind grey and watched the sorting happen and did not interfere. The sorting was Jazen's, and the part of her that did not feel had already counted what it would cost and found the count bearable, which was the most you could say of any count now.

They had come up out of the valley by the cart-road and stopped at the first crossing where there was water. A brown stream ran under a stone bridge old enough that nobody knew who had built it. The survivors spread along the bank in the half-light and made the small fires that a camp on the run is allowed when the thing that hunted it has already done its hunting and gone home. Viridia stood above them on the bridge and counted how many fires there were

against how many fires there should have been. Then she stopped counting. She had done the same sum through the night and the answer had not improved with daylight and would not.

* * *

Raizen felt them coming before she did.

She knew it the way she knew everything that moved in him now, through the bond that had been a warm ache across unmeasurable miles for a season and was a near and constant weather in her since he came back. What moved in him as the sun came up over the stone bridge was not fear. Raizen did not fear his parents. It was the particular bracing of a child who has been told to expect a hard thing and has decided to meet it standing. Viridia felt that bracing and looked up from the fires and saw the two shapes come down the morning out of the west, the one pitch black and burning at the edges with a fire that gave no warmth, the other brilliant scarlet against the pale sky. She knew before they had landed what they had come for. Raizen knew it, and what Raizen knew she knew.

They did not land in the column. They landed across the stream, in the wet meadow beyond it, where there was room, and where the survivors could see them and be afraid of them at a distance that the fear could be borne, because Drake had been alive six thousand years and knew exactly how much dragon a column of the freshly bereaved could stand to have among them, which was none, and so he put the width of a brown stream between his grief and theirs and let them keep their distance and their fear and their morning.

Raizen went to them across the bridge, and Viridia went with him, because the bond did not give her the choice of

staying and because she would not have taken the choice if it had.

* * *

Drake spoke first, because Drake always spoke first, to get the hard thing said before the softness in it could be heard.

"You're going to the wall," he said. It was not a question. He had the death in him for an affinity and the death in him could read the shape of where a thing was going the way Viridia could read a core, and he had read the shape of where the army was going from across a continent and had not liked the shape of it, and he stood in the wet meadow with the black fire moving at his edges and looked at his son and said the thing. "All of you. And the boy with you." He did not look at Viridia when he said *the boy*, which was how she knew he meant Raizen and not Jazen, because Raizen was the boy to Drake and would be the boy to Drake when Raizen had outlived every human in the meadow by four thousand years. "You're taking him to the wall, and you mean to do the thing at the source if the wall doesn't break, and a True-Bond that reaches for the source reaches with both ends of itself, and the first end is you, girl, and the second is my son, and the source does not give back what it takes hold of in the same shape it took it."

"I know that," Viridia told him.

"You don't," Drake said, but he said it without heat, which was worse than heat, the way the councilor's no-blame had been worse than blame. "You know it as a sum. You don't know it the way you'll know it after. Neither do I. I have only ever stood on the after side of it once and what I stood next to was a hole." The black fire flared once and went down. "I lost a child to the last war. You know that. I taught you the symbol because of it, the mark that ends a thing, and I taught it to you as grief and not as a weapon, and you took it

like a weapon anyway, because you're young, and the young cannot help it. I am not here to teach you another symbol. There isn't one. I am here because my son is going to the source tied to the other end of you and I have stood next to the hole one time too many to send him there without standing next to him first."

* * *

He went to Raizen then, and the great black head came down to the dragon that was his son, and they touched the way dragons touch, which is brow to brow, the death-fire and the prismatic light meeting at the join and neither one going out. Drake said something to him in the deep register under hearing that Viridia felt through the bond more than heard. It was not words. Words were a human thing and Drake was not speaking the human thing to his son. What came through was the entire mass of six thousand years deciding to let a thing it loved walk toward a hole it could not follow it into. Viridia stood close in beside it with her hand on Raizen's flank and held her face still and unreadable, because grief that was not hers to spend was still grief she could honor by not making it about herself.

Drake's grief was loud. That was its register. He grieved the way he had always grieved, from a height, in the deep tones, the black fire flaring and the great wings half-spread, and a creature on the bank a hundred yards off who could not see the meadow began to wail and was hushed. Drake did not care that the column heard him; he had earned the right not to care six thousand years and one dead child ago, and he poured the grief out over his son in the open the way he poured everything. Then he drew it back in, because it was said, and a thing once said does not need saying twice, and he lifted his head off Raizen's and was the gruff thing

again, the *doesn't look like much* thing, the armor of it back up over the wound of it.

"Don't let the girl spend you cheap," he said to Raizen, gruff, and it was the closest Drake would come to *I love you* in front of a human, and Raizen, who spoke now, who had spoken his first words this very season, did not waste any of them on answering, he only pressed his brow back against his father's once, the answer in the pressing, and Drake took it, and that was Drake's goodbye, said loud and ended fast, as he did everything.

* * *

Varissa's goodbye was the opposite.

She had not spoken at all yet. She had stood the whole while a little behind Drake with the scarlet of her gone dull in the morning the way a banked fire goes dull, and she had let Drake say the hard thing first, because Drake always said the hard thing first and because the soft thing was hers and she did not give the soft thing away in front of the hard one. When Drake had drawn back she came forward, low, the scarlet head down nearly to the wet grass, and she did not touch Raizen brow to brow as his father had done. She put the side of her face along the whole length of him, the way one creature lies down beside another in the dark, and she stayed there, not speaking, breathing him in, and the flame she breathed came out of her only as warmth now and not as fire, a mother breathing warmth along a child she had carried in the egg and would not carry again whatever the source gave back. And Viridia felt through the bond the thing Varissa was doing, which was memorizing him: the exact heat of him and the exact light and the exact way the prismatic ran along his spine when he breathed, laying it all down inside herself where the source could not take it, because the source had no reach into a mother's keeping.

"I grieve close to the ground," Varissa said at last, and she said it to Viridia, not to her son, because to her son there were no words, and to Viridia there were, and the words were a thing handed across like a key. "His father throws his up at the sky where everyone can hear it and thinks that is the honest way, and it is honest, it is, but it is not the only honest way. I will go back to the mountain and I will lie in the place where his egg lay and I will not make a sound, and that is mine, and I am telling you it is mine so that you will know, girl, when you reach for the source with my son fastened to your other end, that there are two of us grieving him already, in two ways, and that one of them is silent, and that the silent one is the one you should be afraid of, because the silent grief is the grief that does not let go, and if you spend him at that wall and do not bring him back the shape you took him, I will not throw my grief at the sky. I will bring it to you. Close to the ground. Do you understand me."

"Yes," Viridia said.

"Good." The scarlet head lifted off her son, slow, the memorizing finished or as finished as it would get. "Then we understand each other. Bring him back. Whatever shape. Just bring him back."

* * *

They left the way dragons leave, which is all at once and upward. The column watched them go and was glad to have them gone. Viridia stood on the bridge after with her hand still warm where it had rested on Raizen's flank and let the meadow be as large as it had been, the loud goodbye and the silent one. She kept both of them whole. Then she went down off the bridge to the parts of the morning that were hers.

* * *

Amber had the rescued girls.

She had them in a knot under the lee of the bridge-wall where the wind off the water did not reach, the Hazel girls who had folded into the camp over the season and the camp-born ones who had run clear of the burning in Amber's two drilled strings. She had them doing a thing. Amber had learned in the season that the rescued ones did better with a thing to do than with comfort, comfort being a thing that gave the grief a room to fill and a task being a thing that did not. The task was the count, the same count Mirelle had taught them under the table, the small ones told off by name down the bench. There was no bench now. There was a stone wall and a cold morning, and the names they told off had two fewer in them than the names had held a week ago. The girls said the count the way you say a thing somebody died teaching you, carefully, getting it right, because getting it right was the last thing the teaching was for.

Viridia crouched at the edge of the knot and one of the small ones, a girl with her hair come loose from its plait, looked at her and said, "Mirelle isn't in the count."

"No," Viridia said.

"Amber says we say her at the end. After the living ones. So we don't lose where she goes."

"That's right," Viridia said. "That's exactly right. Say her at the end."

She did not say the other thing, which was that there was a name she would have liked to put at the end of the count herself if a count could hold a man it had no place for, Hiram against the post with the roof going down slow over the children's heads, and that there was no count in the column with a place for Hiram in it, because Hiram had not been in the leaving, he had been the leaving, the forty minutes of it, bought and spent, and a thing that buys a count cannot be a

line in it. She kept that off her face as she had kept the morning's date. The small girl did not need a second dead name to learn this morning. She had the one, and she was holding it the right way, at the end, after the living, where it would not get lost, and that was as much as a stone wall and a cold count could do for the dead, and it was more than most of the dead got.

And the small girl turned back to the count and got to the end of the living and said *Mirelle* into the cold morning the way you lay a stone on a cairn, once, plainly, and went quiet, and the other small ones went quiet with her. Amber, over the tops of their heads, found Viridia's eyes. Amber's face had the armor back up over it. Under the armor was the question, the one Amber had asked her in the dark a fortnight ago and had not asked again and had not stopped asking, *do you have the right*. Viridia met the look and did not answer it. There was no reply she could give it that did not fall apart in the open air. Amber knew that, and let the not-answering stand between them the way it had stood between them since. Then a whistle went up the line, two short notes, Amber's own signal, and Amber was on her feet and turning before the second note finished, clapping the small ones up out of the knot and onto their feet and into the line, the count folded away mid-name to be finished walking, and the morning gave neither of them the room to hold the question a moment longer, which was the morning's one mercy, that it kept moving and made you move with it.

* * *

Brutus was on the last cart still, and his broad hands had not come off the beam.

They had not been able to take the beam from him. The healer had tried, in the dark, because a burned man

bleeding under the ribs does not need a length of timber on him making the wound worse with every jolt of the cart-road. Brutus had held it, the broad hands still in it, the outrage still in him. The healer had let him keep it. There is a point past which you do not take a dying man's grip off the last thing his hands made. So Brutus had ridden through the night with the timber laid across him and the burn going at the slow patient pace the healer's hands could set it to and could not stop, and he was grey now under the sunburn, greyer than yesterday, the way Hiram had got grey. Viridia came to the side of the cart and Brutus opened his eyes and found her.

"Still here," he said. There was less of the voice than there had been at the cookhouse.

"Still here," Viridia said. "The field's still ahead of us. You haven't missed it."

That was the thing he wanted; she had understood it on the road. He was keeping his grip on the timber and keeping the wound at bay with the same broad stubbornness because he did not want to die on a dark cart-road having only seen the cookhouse burn. He wanted to get to the field, to see what the field was, the thing he had made her promise about without either of them knowing what it was. And the cold working part of her had counted whether his wanting would carry him as far as the field and had returned that it might, just, if the road did not get worse, and she did not tell him the count; she told him the part of the count that was a thing to hold.

"You haven't missed it," she said again. "Hold on to the beam."

"Then I'll keep my hands where they are," Brutus said, which was the same promise worn down to fewer words, and he closed his eyes, and the broad hands stayed in the wood, and the cart went on bearing him at the front of the column

where the carts went, toward the field he had not yet seen and meant to.

* * *

Somewhere in the middle of that long morning, with the carts groaning ahead of her and her own feet finding the road's ruts, the day turned over, and it was a day that meant a thing to no one in the column but Viridia, and to Viridia it meant a thing she did not say.

She had kept the date as she kept all things, banked, off her face, a small private arithmetic running under the larger ones. She knew without a calendar what the morning was. Her mother had told her the morning every year of the seven years she had a mother to tell her, *this was the morning*, and Viridia had counted the mornings since on her own after there was no one to tell her. This was the morning. She was a year older on it than she had been yesterday, and no one in the column knew, and there was no one left living to know. That was the whole of the marking of it, a girl walking a cart-road to a war one year further from the start of herself with the knowledge of it held inside where the cold morning could not have it.

She did not tell Lor-ar. She did not tell anyone. It was not a thing that needed telling and there was no one it would have helped to tell. She only let herself know it, the once, walking, *a year older today and no one knows it*, and then she folded the knowing in with the rest and went on, because the day did not care what else the morning was, the day had a wall at the end of it, and the wall did not keep birthdays.

* * *

Lor-ar found her at the back of the column in the afternoon, where she had dropped to walk alone for a stretch. A cart

had bogged in the soft verge ahead and the line had concertinaed back to her, walkers piling up and grumbling and putting shoulders to the wheel. She had stepped wide of the snarl to let it pass her. That was where the cat-shape of him came trotting up out of the long grass at the verge and grew as he came until he paced beside her at her shoulder the full seven feet of him, sky-blue and forest-green, the bone-white horns, the lightning-blue eyes, matching her stride down the moving column. He did not say *little one*. *Little one* was rationed hard and this was not a *little one* moment. This was the graver thing, and he knew the difference better than she did.

"You have decided something," Lor-ar said. "You have been deciding it since the valley. You have decided it now."

She walked a while before she answered him, because the thing was true and saying it true was the only way she would say it.

"If the war can't be won at the wall," she said, "I'll mend the severing. All of it. Every living core, in a single stroke, the way I told you I could on the mountain. I won't ask them. There's no way to ask them. I'll do it because every other road is shut and the bodies are real and there's nothing else left that isn't lying down to die." She kept her voice level on it, the cold working part carrying the saying so the rest of her did not have to. "I'm saying it to you because you're the only one I can say it to. Jazen would call it the only road, and he'd be right, and his being right wouldn't make it mine to do. Amber would ask me the question. I can't carry the question and the doing both. So I'm telling you. Because you won't do either of those things."

"No," Lor-ar agreed. "I will do neither of those things." He paced beside her, the great soft tread that made no sound in the grass. The bogged cart broke free behind them with a wet suck and a cheer that died as soon as it was made, and

the line lurched forward again, and they walked on at the pace of it, the war-clock of the column dragging the conversation along the road whether it was finished or not. "But you should not have come to me hoping I would do the third thing, which is to tell you it is all right. I will not do that one either."

"I didn't come to you hoping that."

"You did," Lor-ar said, gently, which was rarer in him than the rationed name. "Everyone who tells a thing to the one creature who will not judge them is hoping, underneath, that the not-judging will feel like the absolving. It does not. I have lived three hundred years and watched a great many people mistake my silence for a blessing and walk away lighter, and they were always wrong to, and they always found out they were wrong to, after, when the silence had not in fact carried any of the weight off them at all." He turned the lightning eyes on her, and there was the ancient amusement in them and under the amusement the thing that was not amusement at all. "I will not tell you that you have the right. I do not know whether you have the right. I am a tiger and the question is a human question and it is too large even for three hundred years. I will only tell you this, which is the most I have: that whatever you decide at the wall, you will have decided it, and you, and no one else, and not me, and that you must carry it as a thing you decided and never once let yourself believe a creature in the grass told you it was fine. Because no creature did. Do you understand me, Viridia."

He said her name, not *little one*, and the name from Lor-ar was its own kind of weight.

"Yes," she said. "I understand you."

"Then we have spoken of it," Lor-ar said, "and we will not speak of it again until you have done it or not done it, because speaking of a thing you have already decided is only

a way of asking to be absolved a second time, and I have told you there is no absolving in me." And he shrank, between one stride and the next, down to the house-cat shape, and sprang up onto the rail of a passing cart and rode there the rest of the afternoon with his eyes shut, a small unremarkable cat on a refugee's cart. He did not look at her again. The not-looking was not a withdrawal. It was the thing he had given her, the weight left whole in her hands where he had refused to take any of it.

* * *

By evening the column had become, as much as it ever would, an army.

The carts went at the front where the wounded and the children and the old ones went, and the able ones walked, and the able ones who could fight had been sorted out of the able ones who could not and given the spears and the few rifles the camp had hidden against exactly this morning and never wanted to use, and the fighters walked at the flanks the way Amber's drilled girls had walked the flanks of the children leaving the valley, and the whole of it moved east, toward the capital, on the long road that the camp had spent two years pretending it would never have to take.

Jazen came back down the column at dusk and walked beside Viridia at the rear, where she had stayed, and the ash was off him now, somebody had given him water and he had used it, but the thing the ash had been on the outside of was still in him, and he looked at the column moving ahead of them in the day's dying light, the carts and the fighters and the small fires not yet lit, and he did not do the flat voice. He had stopped doing the flat voice on the bridge. Nothing remained for the flat voice to hold off.

"I counted them," he said. "While you were with the dragons. Two in three. A little better than two in three." He

let that sit. "I built it for eight years and it held them all and now there's two in three of them on a road to the one place I swore I'd never take them, and the third that isn't here is the price of my building it instead of marching when there was still a school standing to march for." He shook his head once, slow. "I'm not saying it to be sorry at you. You hate being sorried at. I'm saying it because I want one person walking next to me who knows the exact size of what we're doing, and you're the only one who counts it the way I count it, and a man shouldn't carry a number like that with nobody beside him who has the same number."

"Two in three," Viridia said. "A little better."

"A little better," Jazen agreed.

And they walked on into the dusk with the same number between them, not smaller for being shared and not larger, only carried by two sets of hands instead of one. Ahead of them the column took the bend in the road where the land began its long tilt down toward the eastern plain. Past the plain, two days off, three, was the wall. The wall was where they had always been going, and they went toward it now in the day's last grey with the dead remembered behind them and the living counted ahead of them and the one thing Viridia had told no one but a cat folded down deep where it would keep until the wall asked for it.

They took the long road east to the capital. There was no other road left to take.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Road and the Walls

The plain went on for two days, and the two days taught Viridia a thing about armies that the camp had never had room to teach her, which was that an army on a road is mostly not a fighting thing at all but an eating, sleeping, blistered, quarrelling, grieving thing that has to be carried across distance the way water is carried in a cracked jar, with most of the effort going to the not-losing of it. She learned it on her feet. She walked the length of the column each of the two days the way she had walked it the first grey morning, up the line and down it against the flow of it, stepping over a dropped bundle here and a fallen walker there and a child being hoisted back onto a cart, and she put her own shoulder to a stuck wheel twice and carried a sleeping infant a half-mile while its mother bound a split boot, and learned the small business of it in her hands and not her head, and added the small business to the count she carried.

The small business was this. A wheel went on the third cart the first afternoon and a man whose name she did not know mended it with a strip of iron off the cart that had carried Mirelle's bench, and nobody said where the iron had come from, because everybody knew, and the knowing was its own small funeral, done in passing, over a wheel. The healer ran out of the clean cloth on the second morning and

began boiling the dirty, and the boiling smelled of the camp's old cookpots, which was the worst smell on the road, not because it was foul but because it was familiar. An ox went down in its traces at midday on the first day, just folded at the knees and stopped, and for a bad quarter-hour the whole column behind it stacked up and the men at the front cut the dead beast out of the harness and dragged it clear by main force while a fight nearly started over whose cart took the next pull, and Viridia got between the two men with the cold flat voice that did not argue, and named which cart, and it was named, and the column went again, and that was the largest thing that happened in two days and it was about an ox. A girl Amber's drilled string lost a shoe in the river-ford and would not cry about the shoe, having learned in the season that the shoe was not the thing worth her crying, and walked the rest of the plain with rag bound round the bare foot and her chin up, and Viridia saw the chin and the rag and the not-crying and thought, *that is the camp's whole teaching in a child's bare foot*, and kept it with the rest, and gave the girl her own spare wrappings at the next halt without a word, because words would have made the girl have to be brave about it out loud.

There were larger businesses too, the ones the songs would have wanted, and Viridia learned in the two days that the songs had it backward, that the larger businesses were the easier ones. Amber drilled her strings at each halt, spear up, spear set, fall back to the carts, and the girls did it grim and quick because drilling was a thing with a shape and the shape held the fear off the way the count had held it off under the table. Abe and the two spent ward-mages who were left taught a dozen of the fighters the words that turned a screen of air against a low fire, not a true ward, there was no true ward left in any of them, only the cheap field-trick of it, and the fighters learned the words wrong and learned

them again and got them, more or less, and that was a larger business, and it was easy, because it had a thing to do at the end of it. It was the small ones that undid people. The braiding and unbraiding. The blade sharpened twice. A man who walked the whole second day with his dead brother's boots tied by the laces around his neck because he could not wear them and could not leave them, and said nothing about it to anyone, and Viridia read the boots round his neck the way she read the bare foot and the mended wheel and filed it whole, a man carrying the weight of a thing he could neither use nor set down, which was, she thought, the truest description of the whole column that the whole column had given her.

That was the army, then: Brutus on the front cart holding the beam a day greyer, the boiling cloth and the bare foot, the boots round a man's neck and the mended wheel with Mirelle's iron in it. Viridia walked among it and was useful where useful did not need explaining, and banked her furnace to the daylight flicker as she always had, and watched the plain tilt eastward toward the thing at the end of it that everyone could feel and no one named.

* * *

They named it on the second evening, because they could see it.

It came up out of the eastern haze the way a mountain comes up, not all at once but by degrees, a grey line that might have been more plain and then was not more plain, was the wall, the capital's outer wall, the thing two years of hiding had been a way of never having to look at, and the column saw it and the column went quiet, not the trained silence of the warded camp but the older silence of people looking at a thing too large for them, and the quiet ran up the line from the rear where the fighters walked to the front

where the carts went, and even the children felt it come and stopped their small noise.

Viridia stood at a rise in the road with the wall on the edge of the world and read it as she read all things, by the single detail out of place, and what was out of place was that it was beautiful. She had not expected it to be beautiful. She had expected a thing built to keep people out, and it was that, grey and high and old, the stone of it laid by hands six hundred years dead. But the evening was on it, the low eastern light, and the light made the grey go gold along the top course, and the gold ran the whole length of the wall as far as she could see it in either direction. And the thing that was built to keep her and everyone like her on the killing side of it caught the last of the day and held it and gave it back, gold, indifferent, and she stood and looked at the indifferent gold along the top of the thing that wished her dead and understood that the wall did not know what it was for. It only stood. It had stood for the deliberate severing and through the six hundred years of it and it would stand for whatever came tomorrow, gold in the evening, grey in the day, and the not-knowing of the wall, the great patient stupidity of stone, was somehow the hardest thing on the plain to look at, harder than Brutus's grey face, and she held herself to looking at it until she had it whole, and then she went down off the rise to where the column was making its last camp before the thing it could not unsee.

* * *

The last camp was no camp. There were fires because nothing remained that hiding would save, and the having of fires openly was its own grief, the loss of the long habit of dark, and people sat at the open fires on the plain under the wall and did the things people do the night before, which are smaller and stranger than the songs make them.

A man sharpened a blade that did not need sharpening and then sharpened it again. A woman braided and unbraided a child's hair four times because the braiding was a thing her hands could do that was not the other thing. Two of the fighters argued, low and savage, about whether a spear was better held high or low against a fire-mage, and neither of them had ever fought a fire-mage and both of them knew it and the arguing was not about spears. Someone laughed once, sharp, at something, and the laugh fell into the quiet wrong, the way a dropped plate falls into a quiet house, and the man who had laughed looked stricken at the sound of himself and the quiet took the laugh and closed over it.

Viridia moved through it the way she moved through everything, banked, watching, useful in the small ways, and she gave the bare-foot girl the wrappings and she stood a while with Abe where he sat shaking his spent hands at a fire and did not tell him to stop shaking them, and she went to the front cart and told Brutus the wall was in sight, because it was the thing he had asked the road for.

"How far," he said. The voice was nearly gone now. The broad hands were still on the beam.

"Tomorrow," she said. "We reach it tomorrow. You've kept your hands where they were."

"Then they'll stay there one more day," Brutus said, and that was all he had for it, and his eyes shut, and she left him the beam and the one more day and went to find the last thing the night had for her, which was Jazen, who was not at any of the fires.

* * *

He was out past the last of them, alone, at the edge of where the firelight gave out and the plain went dark to the foot of the wall, sitting on the bare earth with his arms across his

knees, and he was not doing the flat voice, because there was no one out here to do the flat voice at, and he was not doing the iron either, the iron he had found in the ash of the camp, and what he was doing, Viridia saw when she came up on him quiet out of the dark, was crying.

He was crying the way he did everything that the camp had not seen him do, which was openly, without managing it, the tears just on his face in the last of the firelight, his breath catching and going on, and he did not stop when he heard her, and he did not turn his face away, because Jazen's grief had a different register than hers and his register was this, the showing of it, the not-hiding, and she had known that about him from the first and it had been one of the things she could not do and could not look away from, the way you cannot look away from a person doing in the open the thing you have spent your whole life learning to do in the dark.

She did not say anything. She sat down on the dark earth beside him, near, not touching, and let the not-saying be the thing she had, as Lor-ar on the cart had let his not-looking be the thing he gave her, and she waited, and after a while the catching of his breath slowed, and he wiped his face with the heel of his hand, once, not ashamed of it, only finished with it for now.

"You don't ask," he said. "That's the thing about you. Anyone else would ask if I'm all right. You just sit down."

"You're not all right," Viridia said. "There's nothing to ask."

That got a sound out of him that was nearly a laugh and was not, and he looked out at the dark plain and the black mass of the wall against the stars and he was quiet a while, and then he said the thing he had come out into the dark to say to no one and was now going to say to her, because she had sat down instead of asking.

"I have to tell you a thing," Jazen said, "before tomorrow. Because tomorrow you'll be standing next to me, and if it happens you'll need to have known it was coming, and not learn it the way the rest of them learned it the first time." He turned the iron over in him, found the level place under it, the place she found her own hard things in. "You know about Jan. My sister. Burned, two years gone, at the start of all this. You know that one."

"I know that one," she said. Jan was in the wound the camp carried about him the way the parents were in the smell of soap and machine oil she carried about her own.

"Here's the one you don't." He kept his eyes on the wall. "There was a town. After Jan. North of here, on the salt road, a small one, you wouldn't know the name and I won't say it, because I don't say it, it's the one word I keep the way you keep your dead's faces, not for showing. There was a town, and there was a column of the capital's soldiers in it, the ones that had been at the burning where Jan was, the actual ones, I knew their faces, I'd seen them do it. And I carry more of the dark gift than any soul living, which is a thing people say about me like it's a blessing, and I went into that town to find those soldiers and make them answer for my sister, and I found them."

He stopped. Viridia did not fill the stop. She let it be his.

"I don't remember the doing of it," Jazen said. "That's the part. I remember walking in with the faces I'd come for in my eye and I remember walking out and there was no town. Not the soldiers. The town. Everyone who'd been in it. The ones who fed those soldiers under a roof and the ones who'd had a soldier hold a knife to them to make them, no way to tell which by the time I was done, no way for me to tell and no way for the dead to tell me, a town's worth of people, and I did it in a grief I cannot remember the inside of, because the grief reached for the whole of me, the way Drake's death-fire

reaches for the whole of him, and the whole of me is the most power any one person carries on this side of a dragon, and when the whole of it goes out in grief it does not count heads. It does not do the arithmetic. You do the arithmetic. I envy you the arithmetic, do you understand me, because the arithmetic is the thing that keeps your power on a leash and I have never once been able to find the leash when the grief is on me, and I killed a town's worth of people looking for four faces, and I have built eight years of careful walls between me and that ever happening again, and tomorrow I am taking the last of my walls to a place that holds the man who burned my sister and gave the order, and the man is going to be there, in the open, in front of me, where I can see his face."

* * *

Viridia sat with it the way she had learned to sit with the unbearable, taking it in whole, not putting a smaller thing over it, and she understood, sitting beside him in the dark, the thing the outline of him had always been the shape of and she had not quite said to herself until now: that Jazen was her, turned the other way out. She had a furnace and a cold working part to hold it, grief banked behind arithmetic, the leash she had been born with or beaten into having. He had the same furnace, more of it, the most of it of anyone, and no leash at all, only walls, and walls are not a leash, walls are a thing that hold until they don't and then come down all at once, the way Hiram's ward had come down, as the camp itself had come down, everything in this war coming down all at once at the end because that is how held things end.

"You're afraid you'll lose it tomorrow," she said. "When you see his face."

"I know I'll lose it," Jazen said, and there was no drama in it, only the iron, the truth said level. "If I see his face across an open field with both armies watching and Jan in me and the camp in me and my mother in me, I will lose it, the way I lost it on the salt road, and I will reach for the whole of myself, and the whole of me, when it goes out, does not count heads, and there are children in our line, Viridia. There are children in our line and there are captives on his wall, your healer girl among them by the rumor, and a man who loses the whole of himself in grief in front of that does not get to choose where it falls." He turned and looked at her then, full, the tears dried on him, the fear bare and unmanaged on his face in the way nothing was ever bare on hers. "I've never said this out loud to a living person. I'm the leader. You don't tell the people you're leading that the deadliest peril out there might be you. But you're not the people I'm leading. You're the one who tallies the dead the way I tally them. So I'm telling you. I'm more afraid of myself tomorrow than I am of him."

* * *

She did not tell him it would be all right. She had learned from Lor-ar that the telling was a thing you did to take the weight, and that the taking was a lie, and that there was no absolving in a creature in the grass and there was none in her either. She did the other thing, the true thing, the thing that cost.

"Then I'll be the leash," Viridia said.

He looked at her.

"You said you've never found it when the grief is on you. The leash." She had her hand flat on the dark earth between them and she moved it, deliberate, and put it on his arm, on the lean forearm crossed over his knee, and let it rest there, flat, as one lays a steadying hand on the one thing a held

burden runs through. "I'll be where I can reach your arm. The whole battle, I'll be where I can reach it. And if I see it taking you, if I see the whole of you start to go out the way you say it goes out, I'll put my hand here, exactly here, and I'll say your name, and that will be the leash, because it'll be a thing outside the grief, a thing the grief didn't make, and only a thing born outside the grief can reach down into it. You won't have to find the leash. I'll be the leash. My hand on your arm. That is all of it. That's what I'm for tomorrow, next to you. Do you understand me."

It was the thing he had said to her on the bridge and at the dusk, *do you understand me*, the handing of a weight across, and she handed it back to him on purpose, his own words, so he would know she meant it the way he had meant his.

Jazen turned his eyes to her hand on his arm a long time. The firelight was nearly out behind them and the wall was a black absence against the stars and somewhere down the line a child was being braided and unbraided to sleep.

"You'd do that," he said. "You'd stand where you couldn't get away, the whole battle, in reach of the worst danger on that whole field, on purpose, to be a hand on my arm."

"Yes," Viridia said.

"Why."

And here was the place she could have said the small thing, the true small thing that would have been a kind of giving, *because you're my friend*, or *because you're the only one who weighs it the way I weigh it*, and she did not say either, because the truest thing was barer and she gave him the bare one, the way he had given her the salt road.

"Because you held the camp for eight years so people like me would have somewhere to be," she said. "And the camp's gone, and the eight years are spent, and the one thing left that you built that I can still stand inside of is you. So I'll

stand inside of it. I'll be the hand on your arm. It's the only roof you've got left and I'm going to keep it on."

He did not answer that with words. He put his own hand over hers, on his arm, just for a breath, the rough warm weight of it, the answer in the pressing and not in any word, and then he took his hand away and wiped his face once more even though it was dry, and the two of them sat in the last of the firelight under the black wall with the thing said, and did not say it again, because a thing once spoken did not want repeating, which was Drake's teaching, and the dead taught the living everything in this war, in passing, over a wheel, over a beam, over a hand on an arm in the dark.

* * *

The morning came grey, the way the worst of them came, and the column made itself the last way into an army, and went up the plain to the wall.

They did not have to go far to find the other army, because the other army had come out to meet them, which Viridia understood as she saw it forming up before the gate: the capital was not going to be besieged. The capital was going to make this a field. It had brought its strength out from behind the gold-topped wall and arrayed it across the field below the gate, rank on rank of it, more of it than the camp's whole count, the broad coarse half of the severed gift in its thousands, and it had done this on purpose, in the open, where both sides could see both sides, because the capital wanted witnesses, the capital had always wanted witnesses, the parade and the woodcut and the glasses that watched, and a battle fought in plain sight below a watching wall was a parade that the dying made of itself.

The two armies came to a stop a long field apart on the grey plain, and the stopping was the worst thing Viridia had felt yet, worse than the fires, worse than the wall going gold,

because the stopping was the held breath, the moment when both things that were going to happen had not yet happened and could still, in the mind, not happen, and everyone on the field knew that the not-happening was a lie and stood in the held breath of it anyway because the breath was the final thing before, and you hold the last thing before as long as you can.

Viridia took her place. She took it deliberately, just as she had said she would, near Jazen, at his right, where her hand could reach his arm, and she put the spears where she could draw them and banked her furnace where she could bring it up all at once and stood in the held breath with the rest, and felt Raizen far back behind the line where the dragons were kept, the bond a steady close weather in her, and felt the whole field hold its breath together, two armies and a watching wall, and waited for the breath to break.

She let her eyes go down her own line once, the way she would soon be made to look down the chained line she could not yet see. Faces she knew. The bare-foot girl with a spear too long for her in both hands. Abe, grey, his field-trick on his lips. Amber at the head of her string with the armor up over the question she had never stopped asking, and the question rode the morning with them, *do you have the right*, unanswered, brought to the wall whole the way the man had brought his brother's boots, a thing she could neither use nor set down. Viridia met none of their eyes. She kept hers forward, on the small bald shape that was forming itself out of the enemy's opening ranks, and she held her face still over all of it, because if she was the leash she could not also be a thing that flinched, and a hand that means to steady a man cannot shake on his arm.

It broke from the capital's side.

* * *

A horn went, once, from the gold-topped wall, and the capital's ranks opened in the center the way a curtain opens, deliberate, theatrical, made for the watchers, and a thing came through the gap that Viridia read before she could see the face of it, because she did not need the face, she knew the shape of the staging from that railway room and the woodcut and the parade, she knew that the capital never did a thing without an audience and never showed a thing it did not mean to wound with.

It was the Chancellor. He came out small on a grey horse, short and bald in the white robe with the light-gold sash, and even across the long field she could see the silver-framed glasses catch the grey morning and throw it back, the true-seeing lenses, the eyes that read a lit mage like a thread to its root, riding out where both armies could not fail to see him, to be seen, to be witnessed, to make of his coming-out a thing the dying would remember.

He did not come alone. He came with a line behind him, walking, on foot, in front of his horse where the watchers could not miss them, and they were in chains, the line of them, the captives, the first-generation healers the capital used what it could use of, paraded out before the army that had come to free them. And Viridia ran her eye down the chained line the way she ran her eye down everything, by the one thing that did not fit. The one thing that did not fit was near the end of the line: a heavier girl, blond hair gone lank, hands held oddly still at her chained wrists, calm hands, a healer's hands. And even across the long grey field, even at this distance, Viridia saw the mouth of her, saw it because she had been finding it across crowded rooms for a year, the wide smile that was not smiling now and the one tooth turned out of its line.

Alice.

The Chancellor stopped his grey horse halfway across the field, the chained line stopped behind him, and he lifted one small hand to the watching wall and the watching armies, grandfatherly, warm, the false warmth carrying even at the distance the way false warmth does, and Viridia felt Jazen go still beside her, utterly still, the stillness of a held thing at the exact edge, and she did not look at his face. She did not need his face. She moved her hand the few inches to his arm and laid it there, flat, where she had promised it would be, and felt under her palm the whole of him straining toward the small bald man and the chained line and the tooth turned out of its line, and she held her hand still on his arm and held her own face the careful face over the thing that had just gone through her at the sight of the lank blond hair, and the field held its breath, every soul on it, two armies and a wall gone grey now in the flat morning with no gold left in it at all, and waited to hear what the small man halfway across the field had come out to offer them.

He opened his mouth to speak.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The First Hour

The small bald man began to speak, and what he said was not for them.

Viridia understood that before he had finished the first word, because the first word was *children*, and a thing offered to an army does not begin with the word children unless the offering is a knife dressed as a mercy. He said it warm, grandfatherly, the false warmth carrying the length of the grey field the way it had carried in the station and off the woodcut and out of every parade the capital had ever made of the dying. He said the capital had no wish to spill the blood of children misled. He said the misled could lay down their spears and come behind the wall and be taught the true and lawful use of the gift, the half of it that was clean, the half that did not corrupt, and live. He said it twice, the living, because a man says a thing twice when he wants the saying to look like patience and not like a trap. And the rest of them, he said, the dark ones, the ones whose gift was a rot, would be put down where they stood, and this was not cruelty but hygiene, the way you do not reason with a fever, you break it.

He did not name the terms no one could accept. He let the chained line behind his horse be the terms. He let Alice be the terms, lank and still at the tail of it, and the others, the healers' hands held oddly quiet in the iron, and the offer beneath the offer was the one the capital had built itself on

and would perish still making: give us the ones we have decided are rot, and we will let the rest of you live as half of what you are. It was an offer built to be refused, so that the refusing could be witnessed. It was the woodcut, waiting for the block.

Viridia kept her hand where she had promised to keep it and felt the whole of Jazen strain forward under her palm, and she held it down, and held her face level, and counted, because that was what she was for. Forty feet behind the small man's grey horse stood the iron. A long field stood between her and the horse. A thousand of the coarse-gift stood between her and the iron, and the iron held the only thing on the plain she wanted, and she could not cross a thousand to reach it without unleashing the power she had vowed to hold for the very end, and so she did not cross it, and the not-crossing was its own labor, harder than any throw.

"No," said Jazen.

He did not shout the word. He spoke it as level as he had spoken the hard thing in the dark, the iron under it, loud enough only to reach the front of his own people, and the front of his own people passed it back along the ranks, *no*, not a roar, a word handed down the column the way Mirelle's bench-iron had been handed onto a wheel, and the *no* ran the length of the line and the line did not move, and that was the whole of the answer.

The small man heard it. The silver-framed glasses caught the flat morning and threw it back, and he inclined his head, grandfatherly still, as though he had looked for nothing else and was only sorry, and he raised one hand to the wall behind him.

And the first hour began.

* * *

It did not open the way the songs would have it, with a charge. It opened with the air going wrong.

She felt it before she saw it, in the always-open sight she could not shut, the plain lighting all at once with the coarse half of the gift waking in its thousands, a thousand small fires catching across the enemy rank the way a dry hillside catches, and the air over the open ground between the armies began to bend and shimmer with the heat of it. Then the first volley came, not as arrows but as flame, a long low rolling wall of it loosed from the front of the capital's line, conjured and thrown, coming across the burnt grass at the column the way weather comes.

"Screen," Jazen said, and the word ran the line, and Abe and the two burnt-down ward-mages still on their feet and the dozen fighters who had learned the field-trick wrong and learned it again said the words into the head of the column, the cheap trick of turned air, no true ward in any of them, and the screen went up ragged along the front and met the rolling flame and split it. The flame went over and around and through the seams, and where it found a seam, people burned.

That was the first hour. It was not a battle the way she had pictured a battle. It was a thing done to a crowd. The fire came and the screen split most of it and the rest of it found the seams and there was screaming up the line and the smell she knew from the village, the worst smell, and the column did the one thing it could do, which was close the seams and go forward, because forward was the one direction the fire ran thinnest, the enemy's front having to stop throwing once the column's front reached it.

Viridia took her hand off Jazen's arm.

She did it deliberately, as she did all things, because a finger of the rolling flame had found a seam thirty feet to her left where the barefoot girl's string stood with their spears

too long for them, and the fire was on them, and she had a choice she had made once before in a burning corridor and would make again, which was that she could not be the leash and the spear in one motion, and for this motion she chose the spear.

She drew the first of the four Damascus heads from the quiver at her back and did the thing she had spent the whole season not doing in plain sight, the thing she had banked to a flicker by daylight through all the months of hiding: she brought the furnace up.

She did not bring all of it. She brought enough. She wrote the Moravian for it without a focus, the way she had gone without a focus since Hazel, the intent going straight from the still observer in her into the world, and the first spear left her hand carrying the whole of what she put in it and crossed the thirty feet and went through the rolling flame, and the heat went out of the flame where the spear passed, sucked into the line of its flight and gone, and the fire that had been about to take the barefoot girl's string guttered and dropped as cold ash, and the spear flew on and took the thrower through the chest, and he folded, and the head came back to her hand the way she had made them all to come back, and she had the second drawn before the first had finished its crossing.

The girl looked at the cold ash where the fire had been, and then at Viridia, white. Viridia did not look back at her, because a look would have made the child have to be brave about it where everyone could hear. She kept her eyes forward and threw the second.

* * *

There is a thing that happens to a person who has held a furnace banked a whole year and is then given leave to spend it, and the thing is not joy, because she had never

once wanted it, but it is a kind of terrible ease, the ease of a breath held too long and finally let go. Viridia felt the ease arrive and watched the cold part of her feel it and did not trust it, because she knew where the ease wanted to go. The ease wanted all of it. The whole of the furnace, gone out across this plain, would do to this plain what Jazen's whole self had once done to a town in the night, and so she fed the ease the spears and nothing but the spears, the four of them, drawn and thrown and home to her hand, drawn and thrown and home, each one carrying enough and never all, every cast a measured thing with the arithmetic riding on it.

She killed with them. She would not let herself stop knowing she was killing. She had decided long ago, in a different burning, that she would never let the count go easy, and so she made it hard on purpose, made herself see the faces the spears took, the coarse-gift throwers and the ones behind them, men and women with the broad half of a severed gift who had been told their whole lives that the killing of her kind was hygiene and had believed it, and she took them and counted them and filed them, because the not-counting was the first step down the road the ease wanted, and she would not take the first step.

Four spears were enough to break the head of the enemy where the column met it. They were not enough to win. She had known they would not be. She had known it on the road and in the dark with her palm on Jazen's sleeve and she knew it now, with the plain a roar around her and the village's worst smell in her teeth: that four spears and a banked furnace and a column of the grieving could break a front and not a war, and that the only thing she carried that could end the war for good was the one she had vowed to hold until nothing else remained, the ending-mark Drake had set in her hand as grief and never as a weapon, lodged now in the cold place where she kept the faces of her dead,

the ones not meant for showing, and she did not reach for it. She left it in reserve. She held it the way Jazen held his walls. She told herself, every cast, *not yet, every other door first, not yet.*

* * *

Hiram had died holding a ward so others could run. Mirelle had died making her own back into a table over children, counting them aloud. They were both in Viridia the way her own dead were in her, filed whole, and through that opening hour she watched the column avenge them and did not feel the avenging the way the songs said it was felt.

Abe found the thrower whose volley had split the screen, where Hiram's name had been passed down the ranks, and Abe was spent to the wick and shaking and could not throw a true thing anymore, but he could throw the field-trick, the cheap turned air, and he threw it not as a screen but as a wedge, into the face of the one who had killed the man beside him, and it bought the fighters at his shoulder the half-second they needed, and they took the thrower down with three spears at once the way Amber had drilled it, spear set, spear up, fall back, and Abe sat down in the churned mud after and shook his spent hands and did not rise, and she saw it and could not reach him and set it with the rest.

Amber's strings held the left where the barefoot girl stood, and they held it the way drilling holds the fear off, grim and quick, the shape of the drill standing where the courage ran thin, and the doubt Amber had carried whole to the wall, whether Viridia had the right, was nowhere on her face now, because there is no room on a face in the thick of a battle for a doubt, only for the next thing, and Amber did the next thing and the one after it, her armor up over the real damage, the armor holding, the girls holding because she

held. That was a larger business, and it came easier than the small ones, the way the larger ones always did.

The column went into the broken front and avenged its named dead by the plain arithmetic of taking more than it gave in that first push, and the avenging was not a song. It was a thing done in the worst smell with the wrong people dying in the seams, and more of the column fell. The man who had carried his brother's boots about his neck the whole second day fell, and the boots fell with him into the mud, and nobody had the half-second to take them up. A girl of Amber's string fell, and Amber did not stop, could not stop, and the not-stopping was the cost. Viridia threw the spears and counted and kept the symbol in reserve and watched the first hour become a thing made of seams.

* * *

Brutus was up at the head of the carts.

He had been there since the village, mortally hurt, the burn under his ribs that the healer could slow and not close, his broad hands kept on the beam he had swung at a fire-mage in the cookhouse he had laid up himself, stone over stone, and he had begged the road for one thing only, which was the wall, and she had told him the wall the night before, *tomorrow*, and he had said then they would stay where they were one more day, and the day had come.

The fighting reached the carts before that hour was out, because a broken front does not break clean, it breaks in fingers, and a finger of the coarse-gift came round the left where Amber's string had thinned and reached the rear where the children were and the wounded were and the head cart was, and nothing stood between the finger and the children but the carts, and the man on the head cart.

Brutus stood up.

She did not see how he did it. She was forty feet off with the third spear drawn and the finger of fire coming round, and she saw, in the corner of the sight that showed her everything, the broad grey bulk of him on the cart take its hands off the beam it had held since the village and lay them instead along the beam itself, the roof-beam, the one he had carried out of the cookhouse ash and laid across the cart because he could not abandon it and could not raise it to use, the way the other man had carried his brother's boots, a weight he could not set down and could not put to work. Brutus took it up off the cart in both hands and stood on the boards with the burn open under his ribs and the fire coming, and he did not hide.

That was the thing. She saw it and it went through her cleaner than the flame, because she understood his fear as well as she understood every other thing she kept, knew it from the village, from the wall he had been mending the first grey morning, from the whole shape of him: that the dying had never been what frightened Brutus. What frightened Brutus was losing the thing he had built and not being there for the losing — being somewhere tucked and safe when the wall came down, outliving the village into a world with no village in it. He had raised the place with his hands so people would have somewhere to be, and his one terror was being kept back of the carts, made safe, useful in some small hidden corner, when the field decided the thing. And now the field had come to the carts and to the children behind them, and he was back of nothing. He was up on the boards in the grey morning with the beam in his hands where the whole plain could see him, and he swung it.

He swung it the way he had swung it at the fire-mage, the once, the swing that had cost him the wound, and he had no furnace and no spears and no field-trick, he had a roof-beam and two hands and a burn that should have had him on his

back, and he swung it into the first that came round at the children, and the man dropped under it, and Brutus took the second with the back-swing. The fire found him then. It found him full, the coarse-gift flame he had no screen against, and it took him on the cart, and he did not fall off it. He kept his feet. He got the beam up one more time over the children's heads, a roof, the last roof, the only roof, and held it there burning until the fighters Amber threw round at last reached the gap and shut it, and then the holding was done, and Brutus came down off the cart, the great grey bulk of him folding the way the ox had folded in its traces on the road, all at once, finished, the beam still across his hands.

She drove the third spear through the last that came at the carts and it flew and came home, and she had no half-second to go to him; the battle would not lend her the half-second. She stood forty feet off in the roar with the head back in her grip and looked at the great grey ruin of him down at last on the boards he had held, the beam across him, the children alive behind him in the lee of the last roof he had made. And she filed him whole, as she filed all of them, and the filing of Brutus ran like this: a man who had borne the burden of a thing he could not wield and could not surrender the whole way to the wall, and at the wall had found the one use it was good for, and used it, and set it down, in the open, on his feet, where every soul on both sides could see him not be hidden. He died as the others had died and unlike them, because Mirelle and Hiram had gone in the doing of the small saving, the table and the ward, and Brutus had gone in plain sight with both armies looking on, on the field and not behind it, and that was the thing he had begged the road for under the word *wall*. Don't give them the ground. She had told him she wouldn't. Whether it was a promise within her power to keep she still could not tell, but

she knew Brutus had kept his half, the part that was his, which is the only part any of them ever gets.

She had no spear to spare for grief. The field would not allow it. She set the grief where she set the faces of the dead, away from any eye, and turned with the spear once more in her hand to the next thing, because there is always a next thing in a battle, and that is the cruelty of it and the mercy of it both, that it will not let you stop to feel the one you lost, because it is already taking the next.

* * *

The hour wore on and the column did not break and did not win, and the fight settled into the long grinding middle of a thing with no clean end in view, the broken front re-forming and breaking again, the seams opening and closing, the worst smell laid over all of it. She passed through it the way she passed through every other ordeal, throwing the four heads in their measured turns, killing what she had to kill and counting it.

And the counting taught her, in the grinding middle, the thing the road had not had room to teach: that the dying did not slow down because it had taken someone who mattered. The ox had taught her a smaller version of it, on the plain, when it folded in its traces and the column had stacked up behind a dead beast and then gone on. The field taught her the whole version. Brutus was down on his boards and the children were alive in the lee of him and the broad-gift came on anyway, indifferent to the trade, the way the wall had been indifferent to the gold the evening laid along its top, the vast unfeeling patience of a thing that did not know what it was for, and she found, taking a thrower through the chest where he stood over a fallen girl of Amber's string, that the indifference was the part that wore the count thin. It would have been bearable if the killing had paused to mark the

worth of what it took. It did not pause. A man fell and the gap he left was a gap and nothing more, a place for the next finger of fire to come through, and the column closed the gap and the gap was a man and the man had borne his brother's boots about his neck two days and now they were in the mud with him and the line walked over both, because the line had to, because a line that stops to grieve is a line the fire takes whole.

She marked one more before she turned back. A boy of the warded string, not Amber's, one of the ones the camp had folded in late, took a fire he had no screen for, holding a place beside the head cart where the children still huddled, and he did not go down clean. Viridia was four casts away and could not reach him and could not even take the one who had done it, the thrower already gone back into his rank, and she stood with the head home in her hand and watched a boy she could not name finish dying for a place she could not have held without him. And she put him with the others, unnamed, which was the cruelest filing of all, a death she could not even give a name to keep, and she turned away from it because the field made her turn, and she came back round at last toward the place she had left, toward Jazen's right where her hand belonged, because the spears had taken her from it and she had not forgotten what she was for.

She got back to where he should have stood and looked for the arm to lay her hand on.

And she could not find it, because she could see, from where she stood, two things at once, the way the sight showed her everything whether she wished it or not, and the two things were the two worst on the plain.

The first was Alice. The chained line had shifted in the grinding of the hour, the small man having pulled his horse back toward the wall and the captives dragged with him

toward the gate, up onto the low rise where the stone met the field, and the line of them stood there now above the battle, beyond reach, the iron on them catching the flat light, Alice near the tail of it with her lank hair and her calm hands held still in the chains, looking down at the army that had come to free her and could not climb to her. And in the very instant that Viridia found her, she saw the thing none of the rest could see, because she was the only soul on the plain who could walk where shadow reached. The wall threw a shadow. The low rise lay in it. The morning was grey and the light was flat, and the wall threw a long flat shadow down the rise toward the field, and the near edge of it touched the broken ground where the column's left had thinned, and from there the shadow ran unbroken up the rise to the feet of the captives, a road of shadow from the field to Alice that no one alive but Viridia could walk. She saw it. The path. The one path. The thing she had been waiting the whole hour without knowing it to be shown: a way to Alice through the shadows.

And the second thing, in that same grey breath, was Jazen.

He was not at her right. He was twenty feet ahead of it and moving, and she knew the shape of the moving before she had the face, knew it the way she had known the small man's coming-out, by the staging — except that this was the opposite of staged, this was the thing he had sat in the dark and told her would happen and that she had sworn to be the leash against, and she had not been at his arm, she had been throwing spears, and the small man had pulled back toward the wall with his face still on him, and Jazen had seen the face. In plain view of both armies, with Jan in him and the village in him and his mother in him, he had looked on it at last, and Jazen was breaking toward the High Chancellor.

He was not running. It was worse than running. He was walking, the way he had walked into that northern town the night his sister's killers were in it, the level terrible walk of a man who could no longer find the leash, because the leash had been thirty feet to his left lifting a fire off a barefoot child. And the whole of him was rising up around him as he went, the most of the dark gift any soul living carried, coming up the way Drake's death-flame came up, reaching for the whole of him, counting no heads, walking straight over the broken ground and the seams and the worst smell toward the small man on the rise with the chained line beside him and the glasses watching, against the plan, against the *no* he had handed down his own ranks an hour before, away from her hand, toward the one face on the field that would make him lose the whole of himself where it could not choose where it fell.

And Viridia held her place on the churned ground with a spear in her hand and the road of shadow to Alice on her left and Jazen breaking toward the High Chancellor on her right, the two of them pulling her from the two sides at once, the friend she had crossed a year to reach and the friend she had promised in the dark to keep, and she could not be the spear and the leash together, she had known it in a burning corridor and she knew it now, she could go through the shadow to Alice or she could reach Jazen's arm before he reached that face, and the plain would not give her both. It never gave anyone both. She had one breath to choose which one she would fail.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Through the Shadow

She had one breath, and she spent it the way she spent everything, by arithmetic, and the arithmetic told her a thing she did not want to be told.

It told her that the road of shadow up the rise to Alice would still be there in ten heartbeats, because the wall was not going to move and the grey morning was not going to brighten, and the long flat shadow it threw down the rise would lie where it lay whether she crossed it now or after, and Alice in her chains at the tail of the line was going nowhere her own feet could carry her. The captives were the most fixed thing on the plain. They had been staged to be fixed, dragged up onto the stone and left there to be looked at, and a thing staged to be looked at does not run.

Jazen was not fixed. Jazen stood a full twenty feet beyond where her hand belonged and was moving, and the rising up around him was not going to wait ten heartbeats, was barely going to wait one, and the small bald man up on the rise with the glasses on him had a wall at his back and a gate beside him and a thousand coarse-gift soldiers between, and the only thing on the plain fast enough to lay a hand on him before he came to that face was a girl who could walk where the shadow walked.

The arithmetic was clean and it was cruel and it gave her the answer she did not want, which was that the rescue could wait and the leash could not.

So she chose the leash. She turned off the road of shadow to Alice and reached, with the whole of the cold part of her, for the shadow that ran to Jazen.

And the shadow was not there.

* * *

She saw why in the same breath she reached for it, the sight showing her the whole of it whether she wished it or not. The morning was flat and grey and the light came from everywhere and nowhere, the way it does under cloud, and a wall throws a shadow under cloud and a man on open ground in the churn of a battle throws almost none, has the grey light coming at him from every side at once so that the dark of him is a smudge at his own feet and nothing more, a thing too small and too broken by the trampling to be a road. She could go anywhere the shadow reached that she had stood in. The shadow did not reach Jazen. He was walking the open middle of the field where there was no shadow to reach him, and the only deep unbroken dark on the whole grey plain was the long fall of it off the wall, down the slope, to the feet of the captives.

The road of shadow went to Alice. It did not go to Jazen. There was no road to Jazen at all.

She had a breath to understand that the thing her power was good for and the thing she needed it for were not the same thing, and that the choice she had thought she was making, which one to fail, had already been made for her by the angle of the light, and that the only fast way she had on the field led to the one of them who could wait.

She ran.

She did not shadow-walk, because there was nowhere to walk to that helped, and so she did the slow ugly human thing instead, the thing anyone on the field could have done and most of them were doing, she put her head down and ran across the broken ground toward Jazen's back with a spear in her hand and the worst smell in her teeth and her own feet failing her the way feet fail, catching on the churn, on a fallen spear, on a thing she did not look down at because looking down would cost her a stride. She ran the way she had run once down a burning corridor toward a door, knowing the run was too slow, knowing it every stride of the running, and running anyway because the only thing worse than a run that is too slow is the not-running.

She called his name. She did it without thinking, which was itself a thing, because she did not do things without thinking, and the name came out of her flat and hard and went nowhere, swallowed by the roar of the field the way a stone is swallowed by deep water, and she knew before the sound had left her that he would not hear it and that even if he heard it he was past the place where a name reaches a person, he was in the level terrible walk where the leash had been and was not, and a name is a thing you say to a person who still has hold of himself.

Twenty feet. The rising came up around him as he walked, the dark gift rolling off him the way heat rolls off stone, and the ground he walked over went wrong behind him, the broken grass curling black, the air bending, the coarse-gift throwers in his path turning to face what came at them and then not throwing, because a part of even a hardened man knows when the thing walking at him is not a thing his fire will stop. They fell back from him. That was the worst of it. The enemy fell back and made him a lane, a clear lane up the broken middle toward the rise, because the only thing on the field more frightening to the coarse-gift than

the war they had been promised was the half of the gift they had been taught their whole lives was a rot, walking at them whole and unleashed in the shape of a lean man in a dark blue shirt, and they opened a road for him out of pure animal sense, and the road they opened ran straight to the bald man waiting on the crest.

Fifteen feet. She was gaining. She was faster than him because he was not running, he was walking the slow inevitable walk, and she put everything she had into the closing of the gap and felt the gap close, ten feet, and reached the spear-hand out ahead of her toward the back of his arm the way she had promised in the dark, *my hand on your arm, that is all of it*, and she was going to make it, the arithmetic had been wrong, she was going to reach him, and—

The line of captives on the rise screamed.

Not all of them. One of them. A voice she did not know pitched up out of the chained line above the battle, high and broken, a girl's voice or a young woman's, screaming a word down the rise into the roar, and the word was a name, and the name was *Jazen*.

He heard that.

He did not hear his own name from her at ten feet. He heard a name screamed from a captive at four hundred. Because the name from her was a leash and the name from the rise was the thing the leash had been holding him back from, the proof and the parade and the line of the people the small bald man had dragged up onto the stone to be looked at, and one of them knew him, one of them had screamed for him, and Jazen's head came up toward the rise and the rising around him doubled, and he did not slow. He went faster. He broke at last into the run she had been dreading, up the lane the enemy had opened for him, toward the gate and the glasses and the chained line, away from her hand,

and the gap she had closed to ten feet tore open again to twenty, to forty, because she had spent her speed gaining and he had spent his patience and a man at a dead run with the whole of the dark gift lifting him is not a thing a girl on failing feet runs down.

She stopped.

She stopped because the running was now arithmetic too, and the arithmetic said she would not catch him, said it flat, said it the way the wall said its indifferent gold, said that he had four hundred feet of opened lane to cross and she had forty feet of his lead to make up and his stride was longer and his terror was faster than her care, and that she could run the whole four hundred and arrive at his back where the rise began a half-second after he reached the top of it, which is to say she could arrive in time to watch.

And there was a road that did not run. There was a road of shadow up the rise to the captives, to the very stone he was running toward, and a girl who could walk it could be waiting up there on the stone before he had crossed half the lane.

She turned for the shadow.

* * *

The shadow took her as it had always taken her, with the small cold lurch of the world folding, the field gone and the dark gone through and the new place arriving around her all at once, and she came out of the deep cast of the wall's shadow onto the cold stone of the crest with the battle suddenly below her instead of around her, the roar dropped to a roar-at-a-distance, the worst smell thinner up here in the moving air, and she came out of it three feet from the chained line with a spear in her hand and the cold part of her already counting the iron.

She counted it before she would let her eyes go to the faces. That was the order. The cold part counted first: nine captives, chained wrist to wrist along a single run of iron staked at both ends into the stone, two guards at the near stake and two at the far, the small bald man and his grey horse forty feet on toward the open gate with his back half-turned to the parade because the parade was for the army below and not for him, and the glasses on him throwing the flat light. Nine and four and one. She had it whole in the time it took the nearest guard to register that the dark of the wall's shadow had just put a girl onto the stone where no girl had walked.

She took the two near guards before either had the word out. She did not use the furnace. She used the spear and her hands and the cold economy of a thing done before it can be seen to be doing, the first guard through the throat with the head she carried and the second with the same head come back to her hand and driven up under the jaw, both of them down on the stone before the far two had turned, and the far two she took with the second and third heads drawn and thrown across the length of the chained line, over the heads of the captives, two casts, two down, the heads home to her hand, the whole of it done in the flat cold register she kept for the work, no furnace spent, nothing lit that a man on a grey horse forty feet off might feel at his back. She did not look at the small man. She had ten heartbeats, maybe, before he felt the absence of his guards as a man feels a draft at his collar, and she did not mean to spend them on him.

She spent them turning to the chained line, and at last she looked at the faces.

And there, near the tail of it, lank blond hair gone lanker, the one crooked tooth that turned out of line, the unmoving hands quiet inside the iron, was Alice.

* * *

She had crossed a year to reach this. She had crossed the gates of Hazel and the burning corridor and the whole season of hiding, had banked a furnace to a flicker through every grey day of the camp, had walked two days of plain and into a battle and across a road of shadow no living soul but her could walk, all of it converging on the three feet of cold stone between her and the heavyset girl with the crooked tooth who had once told a frightened child *I'm Alice P., the P is for Pembroke and it's also for present, because I'm always present*, in a corridor before the world ended, and she had carried that girl in the count the whole way, filed whole, never set down.

"Alice," she said.

And Alice looked at her, and the looking was wrong.

It was wrong in a way the cold part of her catalogued before the whole of her could refuse it, the way it catalogued all wrong things, by the one detail that did not fit, and the detail that did not fit was that the calm hands were not still from fear. She had read them from below as fear, the calm hands in the iron, the stillness of a captive too broken to struggle. They were not that. The calm hands were calm. They lay in the iron the way hands lie when their owner has decided a thing and the deciding has gone all the way down, no tremor in them, no pull against the chain, and the face above them was not the face of the girl who was always present. It was a face that had gone somewhere and come most of the way back and brought the somewhere with it. The wide smile was nowhere on it. The eyes that found Viridia's were green and they were steady and they knew her, they knew her at once, and there was no leap in them, no breaking, no *you came*. There was a steady green recognition with a stillness behind it like the stillness

behind the wall's gold, the stillness of a thing that has stopped expecting to be reached and has built something else where the expecting used to be.

"Vir," Alice said. The voice was low and even. It did not shake. "You shouldn't have come up here."

That was all. Not *you came*. Not her name said twice the way the stressed say things. *You shouldn't have come up here*, said calm, said in the tone you keep for someone you are already a little sorry for.

Viridia had the third head in her hand and she put it to the stake-iron at Alice's wrist and wrote the Moravian for the parting of metal straight into the lock of it, no focus, the intent going from the still cold observer in her into the cold iron, and the iron at Alice's wrist gave and fell open, and Alice's calm hands came free and did not reach for her. They folded in her lap, free, the way they had lain bound. Viridia knelt on the cold rise in front of the friend she had crossed a year for and the friend looked back at her with a kindness that was the worst thing she had seen on the whole plain, worse than the fire in the seams, the patient sorry kindness of someone explaining a thing to a person who has come a very long way for nothing.

"They didn't hurt me," Alice said. "That's the part nobody believes. They needed my hands." She turned one of the freed hands over and looked at the palm of it as though it belonged to somebody she was minding for. "Do you know how many of theirs I've put back together since Hazel. They bring me the burned ones. I'm good at it." A small even breath. "I'm so good at it, Vir. I didn't know I was that good."

"We're going," Viridia said. "There's a way down. Through the shadow. I can take you."

"I know you can." The green eyes did not move off her. "I knew it was you the second the light went wrong on the stone. Nobody else walks out of a wall." The faintest thing

crossed the calm then, not a break, the memory of where a break used to be. "You always came through the wrong door at the right time. I used to think that about you. She comes through the wrong door."

"Alice." Her own voice came out careful, the careful face down over it, every coin she had going into the holding of it, because the field below had a clock running on it and the clock had Jazen on it and she could not afford the thing that was happening in front of her, the friend who was alive and free with her hand unchained in her lap and would not take Viridia's hand. "We don't have time. He's." She did not finish it. *He's running at the man who will kill him and I left the rescue to come up here and the shadow won't take me to him, only to you, and now you won't come.* "We have to go now."

And Alice, calm, kind, terrible, said: "Then go."

* * *

Below them, on the field, Jazen crossed the half of the lane.

Viridia did not see it because she was on the rise with her back half-turned to the battle and her whole self bent toward a girl on cold stone, the sight gave her the whole field whether she bent toward it or not, and so a part of her watched it the whole time she knelt, the lean dark shape of him coming up the opened lane at a dead run, the rising around him a thing the whole field could see now, the dark gift standing off him in a column the way Drake's death-flame stood, the enemy ranks falling back and back from the lane until it was a clear black-curling road from the broken middle to where the stone began to climb, and at the crest the small bald man on the grey horse, who had begun, at last, to turn.

He had felt the draft. The absence of his four guards had reached him the way Viridia had known it would, a man who lived inside true-seeing glasses feels an absence the way

other men feel a sound, and he had turned his grey horse a quarter and his face had come round toward the chained line and the dead guards and the kneeling girl, and the silver-framed glasses had caught the flat light and thrown it, and behind them his small grandfatherly face had done a thing Viridia caught in the corner of the sight and filed: it had not been afraid. It had been pleased. The girl from the woodcut, the dark one, the rot the whole parade had been built to draw out, had walked out of a wall onto his stone in plain view of his army, and that was not a thing that frightened Erik Meros. That was a thing he had been fishing for.

And coming up the lane at his rise, faster than fear, came the most dangerous dark mage living, broken open, unleashed, running at him in front of both armies with the whole of an ungoverned gift lifting off him, which was the bigger fish, and the one he had not even had to bait.

Viridia understood the whole shape of it kneeling on the stone with Alice's free unmoving hand a foot from her own. She understood that the small man wanted this, that the parade and the chains and the captives pulled up onto the rise had all of them been a hook, that the line had been staged in plain sight precisely so that someone would come for it where the army could watch them come, and that the someone the small man had most hoped for was running up his lane now with no leash on him, because a dark mage who loses all hold on himself in front of both armies is the proof the whole capital had been raised to need, the rot made visible, the fever they did not reason with but broke. She understood that if Jazen reached the crest unleashed he would do to the small man what he had done to a town on a salt road in the night, and that the small man's glasses would watch him do it, and that whatever happened after, the army below would have seen the dark gift take a man

whole, and the capital would have its woodcut at last, cut from the living.

She had to reach him. The leash. *My hand on your arm, that is all of it.* And the only fast road left to her went to the rise she was already on, and the lane Jazen ran up had no shadow in it at all.

"Alice." She stood. The careful face was gone now; she did not have the coin to spare for it. "Stay in the shadow of the line. Don't move from the stone. I'll come back for you. Do you understand me. I will come back."

"I know," Alice said, and there was the old thing in it then, just for a word, the present girl, the friend, surfacing up through the calm and the kindness and going under again, "you always come back through the wrong door." And then, low, even, the last thing she said on the rise: "He's not going to make it, Vir. You know that. You've known it longer than I have."

Viridia did not answer her. She stepped to the near edge of the rise where the wall's long shadow fell, and she gathered the cold part of her and the furnace banked behind it, and she did not reach for the Death symbol lodged in the place where she kept the faces of her dead, did not let the thought of it even surface, because that mark was for the very end and this was not yet the very end, and she looked down the lane at Jazen running at the base of the climb with the small man turning to meet him, and she stepped into the shadow to put herself between them.

* * *

The shadow took her down the rise in one cold lurch, the wall's long-thrown dark carrying her from the top of the stone to the broken ground at the bottom where the lane met the rise, and she came out of it onto the churned grass at the very mouth of the lane with the roar of the field full around

her again and the worst smell back in her teeth and Jazen thirty feet off and closing, coming up the last of the lane at her. She planted herself in the throat of it with a spear in her hand and her arm coming up, not to throw, to bar, to be the leash, to be the hand on the arm at the last possible foot of the last possible second, and she opened her mouth to put his name into the small gap between them where it might finally reach him, and then—

and a wedge of the broad-gift, a dozen of the fallen-back throwers who had opened the lane out of fear and now saw the dark one barred from below by a thin green-eyed girl come out of nowhere, took their chance at the both of them at once, and loosed.

The fire came across the mouth of the lane in a low rolling wall, the way it had come at the column in the first hour, conjured and thrown and crossing the broken ground like weather, and it came between her and Jazen, a wall of it. She had a quarter of a heartbeat and one head in her hand and a furnace she had sworn to keep banked, and there were two things in the path of the fire and she could put her spear and the heat-eating of the furnace through only one of them, one, the same one as ever: the leash or the spear, the friend she had crossed a year to free standing safe in the iron-shadow above or the friend she had crossed a field to keep running into the fire below. And she had known it in a burning corridor and she knew it now: she could not be the spear and the shield in one motion, and the plain did not give anyone both.

She threw the spear through the fire at the throwers, and brought the furnace up through the line of its flight to eat the heat out of the wall where the spear passed, and opened a cold seam in the rolling flame a yard wide, a door in the fire, the only door, straight at Jazen so he could come through it to her hand.

And Jazen did not come through the door.

He went into the fire.

He went into the part of the wall she had not cooled, the part she had no spear and no furnace left in that quarter-heartbeat to reach, because the small man was turning above and the rise was right there and the chained line was right there and the screamed name was right there, and Jazen at the dead end of his terrible walk did the thing that an unleashed gift does, which is that the fire did not stop him. It broke against him and poured past the way it had poured into the seams of the column, and where it found the column it had killed, and where it found Jazen it did nothing at all, parted around the rising of him like water around a stone, because there was that much of the dark gift risen off him now, and he stepped clear of the wall of fire on its high side untouched and unslowed with the cold door she had opened for him gaping useless a yard to his left, and he was past her.

He was past her. The wall of fire was between them now, her on the field side and him on the rise side, and the door she had made had been the wrong door, had been a door he did not take, and she stood in the throat of the lane with the furnace half-up and a single head left in her hand and the heat of the wall she had not finished cooling beating on her face and watched the back of him go up the last of the rise toward the bald figure on the grey horse, four hundred feet of opened lane crossed, the leash thirty feet behind him and a wall of fire she had made worse for the cooling of it standing between. And she understood, flat, in the cold counting part of her that did not stop counting even now, that she had reached the rescue too late for it to be a rescue and the leash too late for it to be a leash. She had had two of them to keep and a road that went to only one and a fire that took the choice out of her hands at the end the way the angle

of the light had taken it at the start. Both of the things she had crossed a year and a field and a season of hiding to keep were now beyond the reach of her hand at the same moment, the friend who would not come and the friend she could not stop, one of them calm and kind and lost on the crest behind her and one of them running the last thirty feet to the man with the glasses who had been fishing for exactly this.

She put the furnace down. There was nothing the furnace could do that would not be worse. She did not reach for the mark in the cold place; the very end was a breath away and was not yet here. She started, on her failing human feet, around the burning wall she had made, toward the rise, toward Jazen's back, knowing the whole way there that she would arrive in time only to watch, the way she had always arrived, through the wrong door, at the right time, for nothing.

Above her, on the crest, the small bald man drew his grey horse fully round, and folded his grandfatherly hands on the pommel, and waited, pleased, glasses bright in the flat grey light, for the lean unleashed man to finish climbing into the trap that the whole long morning had been built to spring.

And Viridia, running the long way round the fire she could not unmake, was too late.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Before Both Armies

She rounded the burning wall she could not unmake, and the running was the last arithmetic she did before the arithmetic stopped.

It told her, the way it had told her everything that morning, the cruel clean truth she did not want: that the flame she had only made hungrier by cooling part of it ran forty feet along the throat of the lane, and that she could take its near end or its far end, and that the near end was four steps closer and gave onto the broken middle where the stone began to climb, and that even taking the near end, even pouring the furnace into her own legs as she would not pour it into anything else, she would come up behind Jazen's back a half-dozen strides after he gained the top. The arithmetic did not lie to spare her. It never had. It laid the half-dozen strides out in front of her like coins on a table and let her count them and gave her no place to spend them, and she ran the long way round anyway, because the only thing worse than a run that arrives too late is the not-running, and she had learned that in a corridor and she had not unlearned it.

She came round the near end with the heat of it on her left cheek and the village's reek in her teeth and the grey morning opening the rise above her, and she saw all of it,

because the sight gave it to her whether she could bear it or not, and what it showed her was Jazen reaching the crest.

* * *

He did not reach it the way a man reaches a place. He arrived at it the way weather arrives, the rising standing off him in a black column the whole plain could read now, the coarse-gift ranks fallen back to either side and leaving him a clear stone road to the top, and at the head of it the small bald shape on his grey horse, his grandfatherly hands folded on the pommel and the silver-framed glasses bright in the flat grey light, pleased, unmoved, a man who had set a hook in the water and watched the bigger fish come to it.

And then Meros did a thing Viridia did not expect, and the not-expecting was the first crack in the morning, because she had given up being surprised by the Chancellor hours before and she was surprised now.

He raised one small hand, not to Jazen, not in defense, there was no defense a man could raise against the thing walking up at him, but back over his own shoulder, a small flat lifting of the hand, the gesture a man makes calling a thing already prepared, a thing that had waited behind him all that long morning for exactly this. And out of the ranks at the gate behind him came three of the coarse-gift, big men, and they did not come at Jazen, they came around him, fast, from the flanks, the way men come who have drilled the coming, and the air went thick and gold and wrong across the top of the rise, a low broad working thrown not at Jazen but under him and round him, a net of the broad half of the gift, a thing Viridia had no name for and read on sight: a smothering, a damp, a thing the capital had built and kept and carried to this field for one purpose, to put out the very fire it had spent six hundred years teaching its people to dread.

The rising guttered.

It did not go out. The whole of the dark gift in the most powerful dark mage living did not go out for the throwing of three drilled men. But it guttered, the column of it dropping the way a flame drops when the air is pulled from under it, and Jazen staggered, the level terrible walk breaking into a stumble for the first time since he had left her hand, his hands rising to the gold-wrong air closing round him as though he could tear it, and he could not tear it fast enough, because there were three of them and they had drilled it and he was one man at the end of a four-hundred-foot walk that had cost everything in him to make, and the gift that should have answered his hands answered slow, smothered, half, and in that smothered instant two of them reached him and seized his arms.

They seized his arms. That was the thing Viridia would carry, of all of it, the smallest and the largest: that they did not strike him, that they did not kill him in the closing, that they had been told plainly and drilled plainly to take him alive, two coarse-gift men with their hands on Jazen's lean arms and the third behind with the smother held over him like a wet cloth over a candle, and they bore him the last six feet to the crown of the rise, not fighting now because the gift was smothered and a man without his gift is only a man, and they forced him down onto his knees on the cold stone before the small bald shape on the grey horse, in plain sight, in the open, where neither army could fail to see.

And the small man got down off his horse.

* * *

Viridia was halfway up the rise.

She was running it on the furnace now, spending it into her legs and her breath, the slope falling away under her and the captives' rise above her with Alice somewhere on it and

the chained line and the crest where the small man had got down off his horse, and she ran and she did the arithmetic one more time, the last time, because she could not stop doing it any more than she could stop her own heart, and the arithmetic said: too far. It said she had the rise still to climb and the smother to break and the men who held him to take and a thousand things between her and the kneeling shape of him, and that the small man had got down off his horse already, was already walking the few steps round to where Jazen knelt, was already lifting from a thing held ready at the gate a thing she would not let herself name yet, and that there was not, on the whole grey plain, a road of shadow up the last of the rise, because the crest was in the flat open light and threw nothing, and the only fast way she had ever owned did not reach the one place she needed it to reach, again, the way it had not reached him on the field, the angle of the light deciding for her the same cruel way twice in one morning.

She reached for the furnace anyway. Not into her legs now. Out. She gathered the cold working part of her and the whole of the banked fire behind it and she meant, in that running breath, to throw it up the rise, to put the whole of it through the smother and the men gripping him and unmake the thing the small man was lifting, every door first, this door, now, this one, and she did not care any longer what the army below saw her be.

And she was too low on the rise, and the throwers were turned, and the small man was faster than her care.

She had time to write half the Moravian. She had time to bring the furnace to the very edge of her hands, to feel the whole of it lift in her the way it had lifted at the wall, the year of it, the held thing finally answering, and she had her hands coming up and the cold part of her counting the distance and the half-second and finding it, almost, almost, a hair

short, the way the run had been a hair short, the way the door in the fire had been the wrong door, everything that morning a hair and a wrong door short—

and the small man, who had no glasses turned on the rise behind him and did not need them, who had built the whole long morning to bring exactly this to exactly this stone in exactly this light, raised the thing he had lifted, and brought it down.

* * *

It was very quick.

That was the thing about it that broke her, after, when she was able to think the word *broke* at all: that the capital, which made a parade of everything, which never did a thing without an audience and never showed a thing it did not mean to wound with, did this one thing quickly. There was no speech. There was no grandfatherly warmth carried the length of the grey field. Meros did not lift his face to the watching armies and explain the hygiene of it, the breaking of the fever, the lawful and the unlawful halves of the gift. He had said all of that already, an hour ago, with the word *children* dressed as a mercy, and he did not say it again, because a thing once said does not want repeating, and the capital had learned that lesson the capital had taught itself the same and turned it now against her: he let the doing be the saying. He brought the thing down on the lean neck of the man kneeling on the cold stone with the men holding his arms and a smother held over the whole of him, in front of both armies, in the flat grey light, and it was done.

And the rising went out.

That was how she knew, before the sight had finished showing her the thing on the stone, before the column had made the sound it made, before any of it. The rising went out. The black column that had stood off Jazen the whole

length of the field, the most of the dark gift any soul living carried, the thing the coarse-gift had fallen back from out of pure animal sense, the thing that had poured around a wall of fire like water around a stone—it dropped. All at once. The way a held thing ends, the way Hiram's ward had ended, the way the camp had ended, everything in this war coming down all at once at the last because that is how held things end. One breath there was the most power on the plain standing in the air over the crest, and the next breath there was grey morning where it had been, flat and empty and unremarkable, the air gone ordinary, and Viridia, three-quarters up the rise with the furnace at the very edge of her hands and the half of a Moravian on her, felt the place in the world where Jazen had been go quiet, the way a furnace goes quiet, the way a house goes quiet, and she knew.

The furnace dropped out of her hands. She did not put it down. It fell, the way the rising had fallen, the way the man had fallen, and she came up the last of the rise on her own failing human legs with nothing in her hands at all and the captives' stone leveling out in front of her and the chained line to her left and the crest to her right where Meros was wiping the thing in his hand on a square of cloth a servant had brought, unhurried, grandfatherly, the way a careful man cleans a tool he means to keep, and at his feet on the cold stone was the lean dark shape in the dark blue shirt that she had crossed a field to keep and had not kept, and it was not whole, and she stopped.

* * *

The breath went out of her.

Not a sound. There was no sound in her yet. The breath went out the way breath leaves a thing struck under the ribs, all of it at once and none coming back to take its place, and

she stood on the cold stone of the rise with her hands empty at her sides and the whole field below her gone to a roar at a distance, and she looked at the thing on the stone that had been Jazen, and the cold working part of her, the part that counted, the part that had measured everything her whole life, the part that had counted four guards and nine captives and a half-dozen strides and the angle of the light, the part she had been born with or beaten into having, the leash she had carried in place of the one Jazen never found—

it tried to count this.

It reached for the thing on the stone the way it reached for everything, to take it in whole, to file it, to set a heading over it and put it away where no eye could find it, the way she had laid Brutus to rest on the boards and Hiram at the post and Mirelle under her own back made a table, the way she had filed her mother and her father and the smell of soap and machine oil, the way she had filed every dead thing in her life under the careful headings she kept, *not for showing*, and the cold part of her reached for Jazen to do the same, to make him a thing filed and held and survivable, and it could not.

It could not because there was no heading. She understood that in the empty breath, with a clarity that was the last clear thing she would have for a long time: that all the headings she had ever kept were headings for the dead she had not been able to save, and that those were bearable, those could be filed, because a thing you could not save is a grief with a wall around it, the wall being *I could not*. And this was not that. This was the one she had crossed a field to keep, the one she had promised in the dark, *my hand on your arm, that is all of it*, the one whose leash she had sworn to be and had not been, had been thirty feet to the left lifting a fire off a barefoot child, had opened the wrong door in the fire, had run the long way round, had reached for the furnace a

hair too low on the rise, had done everything, every careful measured thing she had ever been good at, and it had all of it been a hair and a wrong door short, and the wall the cold part of her wanted to build had no *I could not* to lay it on, because she could have. There had been a road. There had always been a road, the road of the furnace, the whole of it, the thing she had banked to a flicker every grey day for a year because Bella Saeren had told her *be careful who you let see you do it*, and she had been careful, she had been so careful, she had held the furnace back and back and back through every door, and the holding had been the leash on herself, and she had held it one door too long, and the man she had held it to keep was on the stone.

The cold part of her broke.

It did not crack and hold the way a wall cracks and holds. It went the way the rising had gone, the way the held thing goes, all at once, and the thing it had been holding back the whole of her life came up through the place where it had stood.

* * *

The first thing was the sound.

She had never heard it before, because she had never made it, because no one had ever seen her make it, because the whole of her life had been the not-making of it, and so when it came up out of her it was a stranger's sound in her own throat, low and torn and rising, a sound with no words in it and no shape, the sound of a thing that has held a furnace banked a whole year and is now no longer holding anything, and it came up the rise and out across the crest and down the grey field, and the field heard it.

The field heard it. That was the thing she would not understand until much later, when she could understand anything: that the sound carried. A whole plain at war, two

armies and a roar and the worst smell laid over all of it, and the sound she made on the rise carried, the way Jazen's *no* had carried down his ranks, the way the Chancellor's false warmth had carried the length of the field, because some sounds are not loud and carry anyway, and this was one, and it ran down both armies and it did not stop, and people on both sides who could not have said why turned their faces up toward the rise where a thin green-eyed girl stood over a dead man with her empty hands at her sides and her head going back, and they felt the air change.

Because the air did change. She did not choose it. She had chosen everything her whole life, every coin she had ever spent going into the holding of her face and the banking of her fire, and now she chose nothing, and the thing she had never let out came out without her choosing it, and the furnace that had dropped out of her hands when Jazen fell came back up through her not as a thing she lifted but as a thing she stopped holding down, and it filled her the way grief fills a person who has stopped fighting the grief, all at once, to the brim and past it, and the always-open sight that showed her the world's lattice of broken cores lit up around her edges with the whole of her own core waking, no flicker now, no daylight bank, the whole furnace open, and the cold stone under her feet went warm and then hot and the grey air over the rise began to bend the way it had bent over Jazen, and she stood in the middle of it and wept.

She wept. That was the unmaking of it, the thing the whole series of her life had been built to prevent, the thing Bella Saeren had spent her last careful warning to forestall: that Viridia Saeren, who held her grief inward, whom no one had ever seen cry, who had filed her mother and her father and her whole burned school behind the careful face, stood on a rise before both armies with the tears coming down her face in the flat grey light where every soul on the plain could

see them, and did not hide it, and did not hold it, and did not care.

* * *

Meros looked up from his cleaning.

She saw him do it through the bending air and the blur the tears made, the small bald figure forty feet off on the crest with the cloth still in his hands and the silver-framed glasses coming round toward her, and she understood, distantly, with the last fragment of the cold part of her still able to understand anything, that he was pleased. That this, too, he had been fishing for. That the woodcut the whole capital had been raised to need was the dark one, the girl from the railway room, broken open and unleashed before both armies the way the dark gift was always said to break open, and that she was giving it to him, was standing on his rise weeping fire into the grey morning with the most dangerous power on the plain coming up out of her unleashed, and that he was watching it through the glasses-of-true-seeing the way he had watched everything, taking it in to be used, the fever made visible at last, the rot drawn out into the open where the army could see it and be confirmed in its fear.

And the fragment of the cold part of her that understood this was not enough to stop the rest of her, and the rest of her did not want to stop.

The furnace went up.

It went up the way she had never let it, the way Jazen's had gone up on the salt road, reaching for the whole of her, and the whole of her was the thing Lor-ar had named in the dry counsel on the hill, the thing she could mend the world with or unmake it with, and it came up now with no leash on it because the leash was on the stone, and she felt it find the rise and the net-mages still half-turned and the men who

had held him and the small bald shape with the glasses, felt it gather toward them the way water gathers toward a broken dam, and she did not call it back. She wanted it to go. She wanted, in the place where the cold part of her had stood and did not stand now, to put the whole of the furnace through Meros and his glasses and his grey horse and his net-throwers and the gate behind them and the wall behind that, to unmake the crest and everything on it, to spend in one breath the year she had banked, and there was nothing left in her that wanted to be careful who saw her do it.

Bella Saeren's voice did not come to stop her. She would think about that, after. The careful warning that had held her her whole life, *be careful who you let see you do it*, did not surface on the rise, because the part of her that kept the warning was the part that had broken, and a broken thing keeps nothing.

But the furnace, gathering toward the crest, gathering toward the bald man who stood pleased in its path, found, as it gathered, the lattice.

It found the lattice the way it always found it, because the sight could not be shut, and the furnace going up lit the sight to the brim, and the lattice was the whole of it: the broken cores of every living soul on the plain, both armies, every coarse-gift thrower and every dark-gift fighter, six hundred years of severing written into every chest on the field, every core burning on half its wick, the captives on the stone and the children at the carts and the smother-throwers turned half-toward her and Meros himself with his own severed core burning on its own half-wick behind the white robe and the light-gold sash, the whole grieving half-made world of them, lit up around her all at once in the moment the furnace reached the very edge of going out across the crest.

And the furnace, which did not count heads, which she had stopped holding to a leash, which wanted Meros and the

crest and the wall, met the lattice and did not know the difference between him and the rest of them, because an ungoverned fire does not. It does not do the arithmetic. Jazen had told her that in the dark, *the whole of me when it goes out does not count heads*, and she had thought she understood it and she had not, not until the furnace was up and ungoverned in her own chest with the lattice lit before it and no cold part left to choose where it fell. And she understood it now, all at once, the way she understood everything too late that morning: that the whole of her going out across this rise would not stop at Meros, that it would find the lattice and pour into it the way Jazen's gift had poured into the seams of the column, and that what it did to the lattice it would do to all of it at once, the children and the captives and Alice on the stone and every half-made core on the plain, because that was what the whole of her was *for*, that was the thing Lor-ar had named, the mending and the unmaking the same gathering, the same furnace, and she had no leash on it.

She had a breath. The same breath she had spent all morning, the one breath, and she spent it the way she had spent every other one, on the only thing she had ever been able to do, which was to choose who she would fail.

She turned it.

She did not call the furnace back, because she could not, there was no cold part left to call it back with, and a thing that has stopped being held cannot be held again by an act of will, only spent. She could not stop the going-out. But there was a fragment of her, the last fragment, the part that had counted the lattice and seen the children in it, and that fragment did the only thing left that a fragment could do: it did not aim. It put no Moravian under the furnace, wrote no intent, gave it no shape and no direction toward the crest, because a furnace given a shape goes where the shape sends

it and a furnace given none goes up. And she let it go up. She turned the whole of it from the crest where the Chancellor stood pleased and put it into the grey sky over the rise, and it went, the year of it, the held thing, the unleashed whole of her, straight up into the flat grey morning in a column of light that was not fire and was not lightning and had no name in any tongue the field knew, a column of the source itself, the furnace spent harmless into the empty air above both armies where it could find no lattice and no child and no grandfatherly man, and the column stood over the rise taller than the wall, taller than the haze, a thing both armies saw and would never agree on the shape of, and it burned there, spending her, while she wept beneath it.

* * *

When it was gone she was on her knees.

She did not remember going down. The stone was warm under her where the furnace had warmed it, and the column of light was gone out of the grey sky, spent, and the field below had stopped its roar, not all of it, but a great hush had run through both armies the way the sound she made had run through them, the hush of an army that has seen a thing it has no song for, two armies standing in the worst smell on a grey plain looking up at a rise where a column of nameless light had stood and stood and gone out, and beneath where it had stood, a thin girl on her knees on the cold stone with the tears still on her face, and beside her the lean dark shape that did not move.

The small bald man was still there. She saw him through the blur, forty feet off on the crest, and the seeing of him was a small cold ember in the wreck of her, the one coal the broken furnace had not spent: that he was alive. That she had turned the whole of it up into the empty sky to spare the children in the lattice, and the sparing had spared him too,

the small grandfatherly man with the glasses and the cloth and the thing he had cleaned and put away, standing untouched on his crest with the bigger fish landed at his feet and the woodcut he had fished for given him whole, the dark one broken open before both armies. He had what he wanted. She had spared him to spare them, and he stood in the gift of her mercy he had not earned and did not know he had been given, and watched her weep on her knees over the man he had killed, pleased, glasses bright, and she let him stand. There was nothing left in her to take him with. The furnace was spent. The cold part was broken. She knelt on the warm stone with empty hands and a wet face and nothing, nothing, between her and the world.

She put her hand on Jazen.

She did not write anything into him. There was no Moravian for it, no parting of metal, no door in the fire, no symbol in any tongue that mended this, and she did not reach for the one symbol that was made for endings, the mark Drake had set in her hand as grief, lodged in the cold place where she kept the faces of her dead, because the cold place was broken open and the faces were all of them loose in her at once and she could not have found one mark among them if she had wanted it, and she did not want it, because the very end was here and it was not the kind of end the mark was for. She only put her hand on the lean still arm in the dark blue shirt, on the forearm she had laid her hand on in the dark and promised, and she let it stay there, flat, as one lays a hand on the one thing a held burden runs through, except there was no burden running through it now, only the cooling stillness of a man, and she knelt over him with her hand on his arm where she had sworn to keep it and wept, openly, in the flat grey light, before both armies, and did not care who watched her do it.

* * *

That was the thing.

Somewhere far down the line a fighter she could not see was watching her, and somewhere on the enemy rank a coarse-gift thrower with a severed core burning on half its wick was watching her, and on the crest the bald man with the true-seeing glasses was watching her, taking her in to be used, and on the stone to her left, freed and unmoving at the tail of the iron line, a heavysset girl with a crooked tooth and calm hands was watching her, the only one of them who had said it aloud, *he's not going to make it, Vir, you've known it longer than I have*, and Viridia knelt in the middle of all their watching with her grief out on her face where the whole world could see it, and for the first time since the morning the world ended she did not arrange a single thing about herself for any of them.

She had spent her whole life choosing who could see her. She had filed her dead behind the careful face and banked her fire to a flicker and given the world only her breath to read her by, because her mother had told her, *be careful who you let see you do it*, and she had been careful, every coin of her composure spent on the choosing, the whole of her a thing arranged for who was looking. And now she knelt on a rise with her hand on a dead man's arm and the careful face gone the way the furnace was gone, spent, broken, not coming back, and she let them all see. The fighter and the thrower and Meros and Alice and the whole grey plain. She let them see the tears and the wreck and the thin girl who had turned the unmaking of the world up into an empty sky and could not unmake the one small death at her own hand. She had nothing left to arrange and she did not try. The wall was down, all at once, the way held things come down, and behind the wall was not the cold working part she had kept

there her whole life but only this, a person on her knees in the open, weeping where everyone could see, no longer careful, at last and too late, about who saw what she was.

Below her, the column had stopped fighting to look. Above her, the Chancellor on the crest folded his cloth and put it away.

And Viridia Saeren knelt in the silence she had broken open, with her hand on Jazen's arm and the careful face gone forever, and let the whole grey world look at her grief.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Decision

She knelt on the warmed stone with her hand on Jazen's arm and let the grey world look, and the world, having looked, began again to move, because that is the one thing a world will always do.

She heard it before she could make herself care about it. The hush that had run down both armies when the column of nameless light stood over the rise was a held breath, and a held breath is a thing with an end in it, and the end came the way ends come, raggedly, from the edges first. Somewhere far down the capital's line an officer found his voice and used it. Somewhere a horn went, two notes, then three, the small machinery of an army remembering it was an army. The net-mages on the crest, who had stood the whole while half-turned to her with their gold-wrong working gone slack in their hands when the furnace went up, gathered themselves and looked to the bald shape for what to do, the way men look to the thing they have been built to look to. And the bald shape, who had folded his cloth away, who had got the woodcut he came for and stood untouched in a mercy he did not know he had been given, lifted his grandfatherly face from the wreck of the man at his feet and looked down the rise at the girl on her knees, and Viridia, through the blur, watched him decide that she was not finished being useful to him yet.

* * *

She knew the look. She had learned it on him hours ago and had stopped being startled by it and was past startling now in a way that had nothing to do with him. It was the look of a man weighing a thing to find the use in it, the silver-framed glasses swinging round and steadying, and what he read, she understood, was that the dark one was spent. That the column of light had emptied her. That she knelt on his stone with her hands open and nothing in them, no furnace, no spear, no cold part left to lift any of it, a thin girl wrung out past the wringing, and that a thing wrung out past the wringing is a thing you can finish at your leisure, in the open, before both armies, as the last clean stroke of a morning that had gone exactly the way he had built it to go.

He raised the small flat hand again, the calling hand, the one that had brought the three drilled men up around Jazen out of the ranks at the gate. He did not raise it to the net-mages this time. He raised it to a man near the gate with a long capital rifle, one of the few the camp had hidden against exactly this and never wanted to use, and the man brought it to his shoulder and sighted down the rise at the kneeling girl, unhurried, because there was no hurry in it, because the thing on the rise could not run and could not burn and could only kneel and be finished, and Meros watched the barrel come up with the mild pleased patience of a man tidying a tool he means to keep, and meant to watch the dark one die the way he had watched the resistance leader die, quickly, as a message, the fever broken at last in the open where the army could see it ended.

And Viridia, kneeling, looked up the rise at the barrel and the bald man behind it, and felt the thing the whole book of her life had named come up in her, not as fire, because the fire was gone, but as a door.

* * *

It came the way the worst clarities had always come to her, all at once and too late, and it laid itself out in front of her the way the arithmetic had always laid things out, except that this was not arithmetic, this was the thing under the arithmetic, the thing the cold part had stood in front of her whole life to keep her from having to look at, and the cold part was broken now and not standing in front of anything, and so she looked.

Every other door was shut.

She had promised herself she would walk every other road to its end before the last, and she had walked them. She had sent the true letter up the rail-wire to the man with the open circle and seen the capital twist it into a broadsheet that taught a frightened country to fear her. She had sat in a secret room with a councilor who voted the war down twice in the language of cost and had felt him move, genuinely move, brave the expensive way, and had watched the glasses find that room and watched the courage executed under emergency law before it could be spent. She had tried the small doors first. She had tried all of them. She had drafted and sent and sat and waited and hoped, every patient measured thing she had ever been good at, spent on the keeping of every other road open, and the capital had shut them one by one, not she, the enemy and not her choice, until there was one road left, the one she had told no one but a cat, the one Lor-ar had refused to absolve her for, and at the end of that road was the source of all magic and the whole of her core and the six hundred years of cutting graven into every chest on the plain.

And the bodies were real. That was the thing the cold part could not file and could not wall, the thing that did not come with an *I could not*, because she could. Jazen was on the

stone. Hiram was at a post in a valley two days behind her with nothing left to put on a cart. Mirelle had made her own back into a table over the children and counted them aloud while she died. Brutus had held a burning beam up as the last roof and folded. The net-mages half-turned to her had severed cores burning on half their wick, and so did the rifleman at the gate, and so did Meros himself under the pale robe and its gold band, every soul on the plain made half a thing six hundred years ago by a council that cut the world and called the cutting an order, every one of them carrying the wound and calling it the whole of magic, and the whole of her, the thing Lor-ar had named on the mountain, the furnace and the lattice and the source-thread all the one thing, could mend it. Could mend all of it. Not for one. For everyone. At once. In a single stroke. The thing she had said level to a tiger on a cart-road with the cold part carrying the saying so the rest of her did not have to.

There was no cold part to carry it now. She would have to choose it with the broken thing. That was the whole of the difference, and it was the difference the book of her life had been about.

* * *

Amber's question came to her then. It rode up the rise out of the wreck of her the way Bella Saeren's warning had not come on the page before, surfacing where the warning had not, because the part that kept the warning had broken and the part that kept the question had not, the question being a thing Viridia had chosen to keep where the warning had only been a thing she was given.

You fought a government that controlled people through their magic. How are you different, if you change every core alive without asking them?

She had had no answer for it in the dark a fortnight ago and she had no answer for it on the rise. She turned it over once, the whole of it, the way she had turned it over every grey day since Amber said it, looking for the reply that did not fall apart in the open air, and it did not exist, it had never existed, there was no version of the doing that survived the question, because the question was right. She had no right. No one had ever had the right to change a whole people through their magic without asking, and she had built a war on saying so, and the council that cut the world had had no right and she would have none either, and the having of none would not stop being true because the bodies were real, it would only weigh the other way on the same scale, the right on one pan and the bodies on the other, and a scale does not resolve, a scale only tips, and she was the thing it tipped onto. There was no answer. There was only a choice, made by a person and not a sum, and carried after as a thing the person decided, *and you, and no one else, and not me*, the way the tiger had refused to lift any of it off her.

She would do it without the answer. That was the shape of it, laid out plain at last on the warm stone with a rifle coming level down the rise. Not because she had found the reply that made it right. Because there was no reply and the bodies were real and every other door was shut and the only thing on the far side of the last door was the chance that no more backs would be made into tables and no more men held up the last roof and folded, the chance that the severing that had built this whole grieving half-made world would simply, all at once, be over, paid for once, by her, in whatever the source took, so that no one ever paid for it again.

She chose it.

* * *

She did not choose it the way she had chosen things her whole life. The choosing she knew was the cold part's choosing, the kind that tallied the guards and the captives and the angle of the light and spent the one breath on the least-bad door, and that choosing was a thing done at a remove, by the part of her that did not feel, so the rest of her could survive the choosing. This was not that. There was no remove left. The cold part was broken open on the stone with the faces of all her dead loose in it, and so when she chose the last door she chose it whole, with the wet face and the empty hands and the grief out in the open, chose it the way a person chooses who has nothing left to choose it behind, and it cost the way that costs, which is to say it cost everything and she paid it kneeling.

She understood, choosing it, that Lor-ar had been right on the cart-road, that he had been right about the thing she had not believed when he said it. *You know it as a sum. You don't know it the way you'll know it after.* She had told him she would mend the severing if the war could not be won at the wall, and she had said it as a sum, the cold part carrying the words, and she had not known, saying it, what it would be to choose it for real, with the man she had crossed a field to keep dead under her hand and the cold part gone and nothing between her and the size of it. She knew now. It was not a sum. It was a thing you did with the whole of yourself or you did not do it, and she had the whole of herself for the first time in her life, broken open and entire, no part of it held back behind any careful face, and she turned the whole of it toward the last door, and the turning was the decision, and the decision was made.

She would not ask them. There was no way to ask them. She would mend the severing for every living core on the plain and beyond it, the children at the carts and the captives on the stone and Alice at the tail of the iron line and

the net-mages and the rifleman at the gate and the bald man who had killed Jazen quickly as a message, all of them, unasked, the whole grieving half-made world made whole in a single stroke whether it had wanted the making or not, and she would carry the unaskedness after, alone, as the thing she decided, forever, and never once let herself believe a creature in the grass had told her it was fine, because no creature had.

The rifle was level. The bald man watched it down its length with mild pleasure. And Viridia, having chosen the last door, did not kneel and wait to be let through it. She set what was left of herself against the seam in the air, the edge where the wall of the world ended, the place she had found once before with her eyes shut, and she began to open it. Not to flee through. There was nowhere on the far side to flee to. She opened it because the door she had decided on was on the far side of it and a choice made is a thing you begin and not a thing you wait on, and she would rather be shot with her hand on the last door than be found kneeling with her hands empty. She knew, beginning it, that the seam would not part before the shot, that the morning would fall short of her one final time, the way it had been short all morning, the way the run had been short and the door in the fire had opened on the wrong place. She opened it anyway, because the only thing worse than a reach that arrives too late is the not-reaching, and she had learned that in a corridor and had not unlearned it.

* * *

She did not hear the rifle.

She heard, instead, a sound she had met once before and not forgotten and would not, a sound carried out of a wet meadow a continent away, the deep tones under hearing, grief flung up at the sky from a height, and she did not place

it for the length of a breath because it had no business on this rise, and then the grey morning over the gate went black.

Not the black of the rising. She knew the rising's black, the column that had stood off Jazen the length of the plain, and this was not that. This was the other black, the one that burned at its edges and gave no warmth, the death-fire, jet and cold, and it dropped out of the grey above the crest as Drake quit any place, all at once and from overhead, the great pitch shape of him crowding the air where there had been only sky, and the net-mages spun the last of the way too late, and the rifleman never fired, because between the leveling of the barrel and the pull of the trigger Drake had come down the morning.

He did not roar at the army. He had won, long ago, the freedom not to perform a thing he meant, and he did not perform this. The black fire gathered along him and ran off him in a single jet, narrow, aimed, nothing like the broad ungoverned furnace Viridia had emptied into the empty sky, because Drake owned no furnace, Drake owned an affinity, the oldest and cleanest of them, the one that ends things, and he had carried it across his whole vast age and spent it the way a creature that old spends the worst gift it owns, which is rarely, and exactly, and never cheap. The jet crossed the crest in less time than a trigger takes, and it did not find the net-mages, and it did not find the rifleman, and it did not find the freed line or the carts or the child the furnace had spared. It found the bald man in the pale robe with the gold band and the silver-framed glasses of true seeing, the man who had laid the whole long morning out to bring exactly this to exactly this stone, who had set the hook and landed the bigger fish and got the breaking of the dark one whole, who stood untouched on his crest inside a mercy he had been handed and did not know.

* * *

It was very quick.

That was the thing, after, when she could think the words at all: that the death-fire was as quick as the stroke the bald man had brought down on Jazen's neck, quicker, and that it was no parade. Drake made no speech of it. He did not lift the great black head to the watching armies and parse the lawful and the unlawful halves of anything. He had no use for the army's reading of it and shaped none for them. He let the doing be the saying, the way the capital had taught the field to do all morning, and turned the capital's own lesson back upon the capital's own head, and the man who never did a thing without an audience went out of the world before the largest audience he had ever held with no chance to address a word to it. The glasses of true seeing, that had read the whole plain and gathered everything into their lenses to be used, found nothing left to read. The pale robe and its gold band lay a thing on the stone and then less than a thing, because the death-fire leaves little, because the death-fire is the end of things and an end does not linger to be looked at, and where the High Chancellor of the capital had stood pleased on his crest there was a scorch on the cold flag and the worst smell made briefly worse and then nothing, nothing, the air gone ordinary over the crest as it had gone ordinary where Jazen had been, the most careful man on the plain unmade in less time than the tidying of a tool, and the message-making capital lost its head in the open where every soul it had taught to fear could watch it go.

Erik Meros was dead. Viridia knew it the way she had known the rising go out, before the sight finished showing it to her, the place in the world where his careful arranging mind had stood gone abruptly still, the stillness of a banked furnace, the stillness of an emptied house. She knelt where

the stone was warm and felt the plain change shape around the absence of him, the held breath of both armies breaking again, harder, because the thing the capital's whole force had been built around and pointed by and made brave by was a scorch on a flag. An army built around a man does not know what it is for the instant the man is gone, and a great wordless confusion ran down the capital's line the way the nameless column had run, the way her own torn sound had run, and the resistance, which had been breaking, stopped breaking, because the thing breaking it had stopped.

* * *

Drake's grief was loud.

It rose out of him after the doing, the way it had risen over Raizen by the stone bridge, from the height, in the tones under hearing, the black fire flaring along him and the vast wings half-lifted, and he did not care that both armies heard him and had won the freedom not to care across a span of years no human grief could measure, and he poured it over the crest and the scorch and the dead man and the lean still shape near the dead man, all of it at once, the whole mass of his years grieving in the open the way he grieved everything, loud, flung at the sky where everyone could hear it, the honest way Varissa had said was honest and was not the only honest way. And Viridia, kneeling under it, understood that the grief was not only for the dead man, was not for the dead man at all, was for the boy he had taught a symbol to as grief and watched take it up as a weapon, for the young who could not help it, for the loss he had stood beside one time too many and had now crossed a continent to stand beside again, because a creature his age cannot keep finding the pits the young dig and refuse to come to them. He had not flown to the wall to fight a war. He had told her he would not. He had come because his son was

fastened to the far end of her and she was reaching for the source, and he had taken his place beside the danger, and a bald man with a rifle had moved to put her under the ground before she could reach the well. Drake, who ended things rarely and exactly and never cheap, had spent the gift on ending that man, because the man stood between his son's far end and the thing his son's far end had to do. That, Viridia understood, was the cost of it on Drake's side: that he had loosed the worst gift he owned on a human life he would otherwise have left the war to keep, had broken his own long discipline of rarely to do it, because the other road led to the pit, and he had stood beside that pit one time too many already.

He looked at her once, the lightning gone out of the death-black eyes into something older, and he did not say *don't let the girl spend you cheap*, and he did not say anything, because there were no words and Drake did not waste words where there were none, he only held her in the look the length of a breath, the look that meant *I have done my part of it and now you do yours and I cannot follow you into it*, and then he lifted off the crest as dragons leave, all at once and upward, and carried his loud grief up into the grey where the nameless column had stood, and left her the rise.

* * *

The threat was gone.

She knelt in the strange new quiet of it, the rifle never fired, the man who had built the morning a scorch on the stone, both armies leaderless and confused and not yet fighting because the thing that had pointed them was unmade, and she understood that the door the whole morning had jammed shut, the door that had been a hair and a wrong angle short every time she reached for it, was open. She had set her hand to the last door with nothing left

and the rifle had been faster than the opening of it, and Drake had bought her the finishing of the thing she had already begun, had spent the worst thing he owned to put the time back in her hands that the morning had spent, and now the time was hers and the threat was gone and there was nothing on the plain between her and the thing she had chosen.

She did not feel relief. There was no part of her left that worked the way relief worked. She felt only that the choosing she had made on the stone a moment ago with the rifle coming level, the choice she had made expecting to die a hair short of making it, was now a choice she would have to live to carry out, and that this was worse, because a choice you die reaching for is a choice the world finishes for you, and a choice you live to do is a choice you do, with your own broken hands, knowing, and carry after, alone, forever. The rifle would have been easier. She knew that, kneeling. The rifle would have been the cold part's kind of mercy, the morning finishing the thing so she did not have to, and Drake had taken even that from her by saving her, had given her back the time and with it the doing, and she did not resent him for it, she only understood it, the way she understood everything too late, that being saved is not the same as being spared, that he had spared her the rifle and not spared her the door.

She put her hand once more flat on Jazen's still arm, on the forearm in the dark blue shirt where she had laid her hand in the dark and promised and had not kept the promise, and she did not write anything into him, because there was no symbol that mended this and she did not reach for the one symbol made for endings, the mark Drake had set in her hand as grief, because the very end was already here and was not the kind the mark was for. She only let her hand stay there a moment, flat, the last time, the burden

gone out from under it, and she said the thing she had not been able to say on the page when the cold part broke, said it low, not arranged for anyone, the wet face turned down to the lean still shape.

"Every other road," she said. "I walked them. There's one left. I'll do the thing I told the cat, and I'll do it for all of them, and I won't ask, because there's no asking it, and you'd call it the only road and you'd be right, and your being right doesn't make it mine, and I'll do it anyway, and carry the rest." Her voice did not do the flat thing. There was no flat thing left to do it with. It came out whole and torn and meant. "I couldn't be the leash. I told you I'd be the hand on your arm and that was the whole of it and I wasn't, I was a stride too far off, I was a wrong door, I was a hair short, all morning, every time. So this is the other thing. This is the thing I can still do with my hand. I'm sorry it isn't you."

She took her hand off his arm.

* * *

She got up off the warm stone.

She did not remember choosing to, the way she had not remembered going down, only that she was on her feet now in the flat grey light with both armies below her gone to a leaderless confusion and the scorch on the crest where the careful man had been and the lean shape on the stone she was leaving, and she turned, not toward the crest and not toward the armies and not toward the iron line where Alice stood freed at its tail, the crooked tooth and the lank blond hair and the calm hands, watching her, though the watching reached her and she felt it and did not arrange herself for it, but toward the thing she had always been able to see and had never until now turned the whole of herself to face.

The lattice was lit around her, as it always was, the broken cores of every living soul on the plain alight on half

their wick, six centuries of the cutting graven into every chest, and behind the lattice and under it and through it, where the unshuttered sight had always shown it to her and she had always banked that sight low and looked away, was the source. The well of all magic. The thing she was connected to, the thing the furnace had come up out of, the thing Lor-ar had named on the mountain and Drake had grieved his son toward across a continent, the single deep place where the whole of it ran from and to, where the severing had been done and where the severing could be undone, for one, or for all, at once, in a single stroke, by a girl with the whole of herself and no part held back and a choice already made.

She faced it. She felt Raizen at the other end of her, the True-Bond reaching with both ends of itself the way Drake had said it would, her one end and his second end, and she felt him brace the way a child braces who has been told to expect a hard thing and has decided to meet it standing. There was no need to pull him toward it; where she went, the bond went. And Varissa's voice came to her, *bring him back, whatever shape*, and Bella Saeren's name was on a thread that ran down into the source ahead of her, visible, unfollowable, a thing for a later door, and Amber's question rode up beside her one more time, *do you have the right*, and she did not answer it, because there was no answer, and she had chosen it anyway, and the choosing did not need the answer, only the carrying.

She let the careful face stay gone. She let them all look, the fighter and the thrower and the freed girl and the whole leaderless plain. She let the wet face be a wet face and the empty hands be empty hands and the grief be out in the open where it would stay now, no longer careful, at last and forever, about who saw what she was. And then, with the question unanswered beside her and the dead behind her

and the whole grieving half-made world lit on its half-wicks all around her, Viridia Saeren turned her broken-open self to the deepest place in the world, and reached for the well of all magic.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Rebirth

She reached for the well of all magic, and the well, which had been waiting a very long time, opened to her the way it had opened to her once before, and she went into it.

There was no portal-scroll this time, no racing chain of glyphs lit against the sun, no man on a bench with two blank coins for eyes watching her go. There was only the lattice lit all around her on the rise and the well sunk far beneath it, and she did not so much make the seam as find it, the way you find a door in a house you have lived in your whole life with your eyes shut, by the feel of the air changing where the wall ends. She set her broken-open self against the deepest place there was. The air in front of her on the warm stone split along a line that had no edges she could name, dark on the far side of it. The rise and the leaderless plain and the scorch on the crest and the long quiet shape of Jazen behind her all fell away from the sides of her at once. She stepped through. The seam sealed shut behind her without a sound, the way it had sealed on the girl who came before, the way a thing closes that means to keep her.

She was alone with the source.

* * *

The cave was dark, and cold, and the only light in it came from a stone pedestal a few feet ahead, where something glowed.

She knew it. That came before anything else, before the size of what she had come to do: she knew this place, low and rough and older than old, the walls unworked stone, the air still and dry and tasting of nothing but stone, of the deep places of the world that had never had weather and never would. There was no sound. Not the drip of water, not the stir of air, not the two armies, not the horns, not the held breath breaking down a line. The silence had a weight to it, the silence of a room that had been waiting. It had waited for her once before, a clever tired first-year banking her core to an ember. It had her again now. She was not that girl, and the room did not care which girl she was. It only held its pool of pale even light and waited the way it had always waited, with all the patience of a thing that the world is borrowed from.

She crossed the unworked floor to the pedestal.

In its hollowed top lay the pool, and the light came from the pool itself, a clean pale glow with no source above it or below it, only the liquid shining of its own accord, and it was not water, she had learned that once before in the first instant of touching it and she did not have to learn it again. This was magic itself. The source. The deep well her own furnace had only ever been a borrowing from, the thing Lor-ar had once put a name to on the mountain, the thing every focus and glyph and core in the world was only a borrowing of, and she stood over it with her wet face and her empty hands and the whole of herself loose and entire. No part walled off. No cold part standing in front of her to keep her from the size of it, because the cold part was broken on a stone two days' worth of grief and a continent of

falling-short behind her. She had nothing left to look at the source with except all of herself.

She leaned over the pool, and the light side of her stirred and the dark side of her stirred, both at once, the whole merged one core of her leaning toward the glow the way a struck bell stirs another bell across a room, and the pool felt her, and as it felt her the split symbol rose to its pale surface, the mark her lost focus had worn and her mother's book had worn, the mark of the two halves of the gift, and where it touched the surface the pool divided, light to one side and dark to the other, and both sides of her ached toward it at once. The room had not changed at all. She had changed entirely. That was the only difference there would be, and it was enough.

She put her hand into the pool.

* * *

The world came apart.

It came apart the way it had come apart once before, all at once and too large to stop, the knowing coming in like a tide, except that on that day she had been a girl reaching out of curiosity into a thing she did not understand, and the source had poured its memory into her because she had asked the only way it knew, by touching it whole, and almost no one had ever touched it whole. This time she had not come to ask. She had come to answer. And the source, feeling that, did not pour its memory into her. It opened the other way. It let her pour into it.

She felt the lattice the way she had felt it once at this same pedestal, the vast bright weave of fine lines running out from the pool to every living thing in the world and back, every mage and every beast and every blade of grass, and she was one of the lines and so was Lor-ar far away and suddenly close and so, at the far braced end of the

True-Bond, was Raizen, lit like a struck wire all the way to wherever the bond reached, and she felt the size of the world for the second time in her life and did not drown in it, because she had not come to be the world's size, she had come to be larger than her own.

And she saw the wound.

She had seen it once before too, in the feel of it more than the sight, the place where the bright lattice ran thin and frayed where it should have run full, the cut the council of frightened mages had made six hundred years ago with their hands reaching into the source itself, throttling mankind's connection to the dark half of the gift a generation at a time, a slow strangling they had called peace. Then she had been shown it and made sick by it and had carried it away with her as a thing she knew and could tell a tiger in the dark. Now she was not being shown it. Now she was standing at it, at the lip of the long cut, the place where six centuries of severing was graven not into one chest but into the root of all of them at once, every severed core on the plain and beyond it burning on half its wick because of this thin frayed place, the smother-throwers and the gunman whose rifle never fired and the dead Chancellor who was a scorch on a flag now and the children by the carts and Alice at the iron line's tail with her calm hands and her crooked tooth, every soul made half a thing here, in this room, by people afraid of equals, and the wound was here under her hand and it was hers to close.

She closed it.

* * *

There is no clean way to say what the closing was, and she would spend all the years left to her finding that there was no clean way, that it would not lay itself down in order, that it came back to her always as overwhelm and never as a

sentence, the way the first moment in this cave had come back to her always as the moment and never as a chronicle. But it began as too much. It began as everything at once.

It came up her arm out of the pool not as a knowing this time but as a drowning. Every thread of the lattice at once, every line the source ran out to every living thing, and each one reached her as its own separate voice and all of them reached her in the same instant: the children at the carts, the gunman whose rifle never fired, the net-mages with their gold-wrong workings gone slack, Alice at the tail of the iron line, the dead Chancellor's starved half, a continent of strangers she would never see, six hundred years of frayed wanting pouring up the one channel they all ran to, which was now her. It did not feel like lifting a weight. It felt like being unmade into the thing she lifted. She could feel the edges of herself going, the line where Viridia stopped and the world began washing out like a bank taking flood, every separate grief catching a thread of her loose and drawing it off into itself, and the terror of it was not pain, there was no pain anywhere in it, the terror was how simple it would be to let the edges go, to stop being a girl holding the world and sink into being only the world, dissolved gently and entirely into the very thing she had come down into the dark to mend.

One line did not pull. The bond. Raizen braced at the far end of it, lit the whole length of its reach, not pouring grief up it the way the thousand thousand starved threads poured theirs but holding, fixed, a single still point in the whole roaring flood, the one thread in all the weave that was hers and not the world's. She set herself against it the way a swimmer caught in a current sets against a rope. She found the place where she stopped and the world began and she held it, by main force, hand over hand on the one line that did not want anything from her except that she not let go,

while the entire grieving half-made world poured up through her and tried to carry that line out of her grip. The source did not make it easier because she had chosen it. The source only opened, and let it all come up at once, and waited to see whether she would close her hand or pull it back.

She did not pull it back.

She held the whole of it. She bore it as Mirelle had borne a table, with her own self as the only thing between the weight and the children under it, except that the children were everyone, the children were the whole world's worth of half-made cores, and the table was her, and she made her own self into the thing the world could rest its severing on while she mended it, and the price of it was the whole of her, paid out standing, all at once, without flinching back.

And then, somewhere in the too-much, the way the hardest knowing had always arrived in her, all at once and out of the flood, it stopped being too much and became one thing. One terrible clear thing. The overwhelm did not lessen; it resolved. The six hundred years and the every-core and the world's whole grief stopped being a thousand thousand separate screaming threads and became, in her hand, a single cut, a single long cut in a single thing, the way a wound that has frightened you across a whole body resolves, when you finally look at it plain, into one edge to be drawn together. The council had cut one thing. They had only made it look like a million wounds because it fell on a million chests. It was one cut. And one cut can be closed.

She drew it together.

* * *

She poured the whole of herself down into the pool and out along the lattice into the thin frayed place, and where the source ran starved she let it run full, and where the

connection to the dark half of the gift had been throttled to a faint surviving thread in every living core she opened her hand and let the throttle go, all of them, at once, all of them at one stroke, the thing she had once promised a cat in the dark and let the cold part speak for her so the rest of her did not have to feel the weight of the words. There was no cold part carrying it now. She felt the whole of it. The cut began to close.

She felt it close in the children at the carts, the small starved dark-side of them she had never been able to look at without her chest hurting, opening like a fist uncurling after a lifetime closed, and the children did not know, would not know, were only somewhere far above this room playing or crying or sleeping while the half-made thing in them quietly became whole. The same closing ran through the smother-throwers who had stood half-faced toward her, their gold-wrong workings dead in their fingers, and through the gunman who had never pulled his trigger. It reached Alice, the stunted candle she had grieved a month for in a school dormitory, the small starved light that had only ever been half a thing, made whole now under a grey sky at the tail of an iron line, and Alice did not know, and Alice with her calm changed hands would not know, and that was the shape of what she had chosen, that none of them would know, that she would mend them all and ask none of them and carry the unaskedness alone forever, and the mending found Alice anyway, and she let the wet run down her face into the oldest magic in the world, and did not stop the closing to grieve the asking she could not do.

The closing reached for the dead, almost. She felt the spot where Jazen had stood and lay now, the lean broad-gifted shape of him, the furnace and no leash and only walls, and the closing reached for him the way it reached for everyone and found no core there to mend, found only the still warm

absence she had laid a hand on two minutes and a whole life ago. The source did not mend the dead. The source could not. The cut drew shut in everyone living and ran clean through the emptiness of him like water through a gate that is not there, and she understood, holding the whole world's wound shut, that this was the one thing the largest doing in the world could not do: that she could make every living soul on the plain whole and could not put back the one she had crossed a field to keep. And she did not stop the closing to break on it, because the closing was for everyone and the breaking would have been only for her, and there was no part of her left that put her own grief on the scale ahead of the world's. She drew the cut shut. She let the spot where Jazen lay be a spot where there was nothing to mend. She carried that too.

* * *

And the source, while she held the wound shut and the world ran whole up her arm, gave her back the thread.

She did not reach for it. It found her, the way it had found her once before, surfacing out of the flood unlike the other lines, the line that ran not outward into the world but down, into the source's own deep memory, warmer than the rest and hers, personally, pointed, the way a letter has your name on it. And she felt it brush her in the middle of the closing, the warm familiar stillness at the far end of it, the deep-water stillness she had spent all her life living beside and a year and a month now grieving, and her whole opened heart said the name into the pool before she could decide whether to.

Mother. Bella.

The thread quivered, the way it had quivered once long ago, as if it heard her.

And the wanting came up in her so large it nearly broke the closing. To follow it. To pour herself down it the way she had once poured herself, toward the answer to every question she had not let herself ask, *what were you, were you like me, did you touch this place, is that why you told me to be careful who I let see me do it, where are you, are you anywhere, can I come.* She had her whole self this time. She had the furnace and the broken-open heart and the source running up her arm and the whole grieving world resting on her like a table, and for one half-second she thought that with all of that, with the most of herself she had ever held, she might follow it this time, might reach the warm stillness at the bottom of it at last, might have the one thing she had wanted her whole life long under all the other wanting.

She reached for it.

It had no bottom.

It had no bottom now any more than it had had a bottom on the day she first found it, except that now she could feel exactly how much of herself she would have to spend to learn that there was no reaching it, could feel the thread leading on and on into a depth that did not lessen no matter how much of her she poured, the source holding the far end of it somewhere she could not go, behind something she still had no name for, and she understood, reaching, that nothing had changed about it, that she was larger and the thread was the same and it would not be pulled by a larger girl any more than it had been pulled by a smaller one, that the thing at the other end was older and deeper than the world and would not come closer for the wanting. She could follow it. She could pour the whole of herself down it after her mother and never reach the bottom and never come back, a girl who fell into a thing with no bottom and did not come back to tell anyone what was down there. And the world's wound would tear open again the instant she let it go

to chase the warm stillness. Every core she had just made whole would fray. The children and Alice and the net-mages would be made half again by a girl who let the world's grief drop to chase her own.

She let go of the thread.

It was the worst thing she did in that room, harder than the closing, harder than the world's whole weight, and it took less than a breath and no one would ever know she had done it, and she would carry that too. She let the warm stillness with her mother's name on it sink back down into the source's keeping, unfollowed, a question held over for some far-off door, and she turned the whole of herself back to the wound and held it shut and did not look at the thread again, because if she looked at it again she would follow it, and the world was on the table and the table was her.

* * *

She felt, far past the rim, at the very edge of the source's vast humming awareness, the absence. The waiting empty place. The hole in the great bright weave that was not thin like the wound she was closing but simply was not, no line, no hum, not even the cut and frayed faintness of the severed dark, an emptiness with an edge to it, a nothing that waited, that something on the far underside of the world's weave seemed pressed against. She felt it notice that she was making the lattice run full, the whole great weave of everything pulling tighter and brighter as the cut closed, and she felt, or thought she felt, or would never be sure she had not imagined, the edge of the absence shift the smallest amount, the way a held breath holds a half-second longer when it hears a sound. She did not look at it. She had buried it once in the deepest and most uncomfortable place she kept, the place she did not visit, and she buried it again, and she closed the cut, and she did not let herself think *I have made*

the world fuller and I do not know what the empty place will make of a fuller world, because there was no part of her left to spend on a fear she could do nothing about with her hand in the pool, and because the bodies were real and the empty place was not, yet, and a person chooses for the real ones first.

The cut closed.

She felt it go the last of the way, the long six-hundred-year edge drawing together at last under her hand, the lattice running full where it had run thin, the half-made world made entire at last whether it had wanted the making or not, every living core on the field and past it holding the whole of itself after six centuries cut short and none of them knowing it. The wound that had built the war and starved the children and made Alice's candle stunted and given a frightened council the clean warm certainty of people who decide who gets to be in the world was over. Paid for. Once. By her. She felt the world settle around the closing, not the way one careful mind had gone still on the rise but in a vaster motion altogether, the entire lattice of the living easing into a new and fuller weave, a quiet rightness running out to the edge of everything. She knelt in it with her hand in the source and felt the world become, after six hundred years of the cutting, the whole shape it had been cut out of. She had done it. There was no one to tell. She did not weep harder, because the grief had been out in the open the whole time and there was nowhere further out for it to go.

* * *

And then she paid for it.

She had known there would be a cost and she had not known its shape, the way she had told Lor-ar she would mend the severing and had not known, saying it as a sum, what it would be to do it for real. She knew now. The source

did not take her life; she had half-expected it to and it did not, the way it had spared the girl who first touched it, because the source was not cruel and was not kind and only answered what it was asked the way it was asked. It took the thing she had asked it with.

It took the sight.

She felt it go as she drew her hand up out of the pool, the way she had drawn it out years younger, whole and shaking and changed, except that on that day she had come back with the mana-sight grown sharper and her core grown vast, and this time, as the pale even glow returned to the pool's surface and the split symbol sank from it, the always-on sight that had shown her the lattice and the cores and the threads and the source running under everything, the sight that had been with her every waking hour since the cave, the sight she had banked low at daylight and lifted at doors and read whole rooms and whole plains with, the sight that was the truest part of what she was, guttered. Not her eyes. Her eyes found the dark cave and the pale pool and the unworked stone the way any eyes would. It was the other seeing, the one that had made her the most dangerous person in any room, the one that had read the wound in the world she had just closed, and it dimmed as she stood there, banked itself not low but out, the way a furnace banks when the last of the fuel is gone, and where there had always been the bright humming weave of all magic laid over the world for her to read, there was, now, only the world, ordinary, mute, the way it was for everyone else, the way it had been for her before the cave.

She had spent the seeing to do the closing. She had poured it down the lattice with the rest of herself and it had not come back up her arm with her hand. It was not taken from her; it was burned to the wick, drained the way the furnace drained, and she knew the feel of her own emptied

depths well enough to know it would not light again today, nor this week, nor for a long slow count of weeks after, a thing burned that far down building its fuel back only an ember at a time. She stood at the pedestal in the dim, blind in the only way she had ever truly been able to see, and understood that she had mended all the cores of the living and could not, now, see that she had, that she had made the whole world whole and could no longer read a single thread of it, that she had given the world back the half of its gift it did not know it had lost and spent, to do it, the one gift that was wholly and only hers. The lattice was gone from her. The cores were gone. The deep place under everything was a pool of pale liquid in a dark room and nothing more, now, to her eyes than it had been to the eyes of every top student the Chancellor had ever sent in for a bigger core and a story they could not tell. She had come back from the well knowing, once. This time she came back from it seeing nothing, and would have to wait, blind and ordinary, however long the slow seeing took to find its way back to her.

She did not weep for that. She had no room left for it. She filed it, the way she filed the worst things, in the place she did not visit, beside the unfollowed thread and the buried absence and the still warm shape on a stone, and she thought, with a cold that had nothing to do with the cave, *I will have to learn the world over again, the way everyone else lives in it, by the front of my eyes, and for a good span of months I will not know who is in a room behind me, and that is the cost, and no one will ever know I paid it, and that is the rest of the cost.* She wiped her face on her sleeve, twice, carefully, the old habit, in a room where there was no one and the wiping was for no one, and she steadied, and she turned from the pedestal to the place where the seam had sealed, and she could not feel it there. She had always felt the seam, the door in the air. She found it now the way the blind find a wall, by the changed

feel where the chamber ended, and she set her hand to it and opened it the way she had opened the portal-scroll once, by a thread of light magic, and she did not have to read it to do it, she only had to mean it, and the air split along its edgeless line and showed her grey on the far side, the rise, the morning, the world.

She stepped back through, and the seam sealed behind her, and she was on the warm stone again with Jazen's quiet shape at her feet, and she lifted her ordinary eyes to the plain.

* * *

The battle had stopped.

She did not understand it at first, standing on the rise with the old sight gone and only her two eyes to read the plain with, and it took her the length of a breath to see what the plain was doing, because the plain was not doing the thing a plain does. There was no fighting. There were no horns. The held breath that had broken raggedly down both armies when she knelt, the small machinery of two armies remembering they were armies, the leaderless confusion that had spread through the capital's ranks when Meros became a scorch, all of it had not resumed into battle while she was away at the well. It had guttered out into something else. The whole great mass of both armies, the iron line and the gate and the carts and the crest, stood in the grey morning not fighting, not advancing, not breaking, only standing, rifles half-lowered and workings gone slack in slack hands and faces turned not at the enemy but inward and down at their own chests, hundreds of them, thousands, every soul on the plain gone suddenly still in the middle of a war, holding the entire of themselves after six hundred years of the cutting and not one of them knowing why.

And the stillness was not a calm one. Down the capital's near rank a man clawed at his own coat as if the wholeness in his chest were a poison poured in while he slept, and another beside him had gone the colour of ash and would not stop saying a word she could not hear. A commander somewhere behind the gate was screaming an order down a line that would not move, his arm flung at the enemy, his voice cracking when not a single man in the line so much as turned his head. One soldier near the carts raised his rifle halfway, slow, his face working, and then lowered it again, because there was no one left who would point a weapon back, and he stood holding it loose like a man who had forgotten what it was for. Off toward the crest a thin voice rose and broke on a word that carried up the rise to her even through the dim — *witchcraft* — and no one answered it, because no one knew whether he was right. The not-knowing had got into all of them, and now it included not knowing whether to be afraid.

She watched one man down by the gate, the gunman, the one who had never fired at her, stand with the weapon forgotten in his hands and his head bowed over his own breastbone, his face doing the thing a face does when something it never had a word for has arrived in it, wonder and fear and a kind of grief at the size of a thing he could not name. And she understood that he could feel it, the wholeness, the half of himself that had been starved and frayed his whole life running suddenly full, and that he did not know what it was, that he would never know what it was. He would carry the rest of his life the memory of a grey morning when the world stopped being a war for no reason he could ever give, when something he could not see laid the whole of himself into his hands like a gift and no one ever told him whose. And he was one of thousands. The whole plain was doing it. The capital's army and the resistance

both, the men who had drilled to kill Jazen and the survivors who had marched from the ash to avenge him, all of them stood in the same bewildered stillness with their hands full of a wholeness they had not asked for and could not refuse and would never understand, the war guttering out not because anyone had won it or lost it or chosen to stop it but because a thing had happened to every soul on the field at once that was larger than the reason they had come, and you cannot keep two armies fighting through a thing like that, you cannot, the thing is too large and too quiet and too far inside the chest, and the fighting had simply... stopped, while she was in a dark room a portal away, paying for it.

She had done that. She stood on the rise and could not see the lattice she had mended, and could see, instead, with her ordinary blinded-back eyes, the proof of it: the thing the sight would have shown her as a weave run full, and the world showed her instead as ten thousand people standing still in the grey with their heads bowed over their own hearts, not knowing, none of them knowing, never to know. And Amber's question came up the rise to her one last time, the one about the right of it, about what she became by changing them all and asking no one, and she looked at the bowed bewildered army of the men who had come to kill her, made whole and standing quiet in a war they had forgotten how to fight. She had no answer for it, she would never have an answer for it, and she had done it anyway, and she would carry the unaskedness alone, and let no comforting voice from the grass tell her otherwise.

She stepped off the seam, onto the rise, into the aftermath, blind in the way that had made her, whole in the way that had cost her, with the dead behind her and the living standing still below her and not one soul in the world, but her, who knew why.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

What Remains

Amber was on the rise when she stepped back through.

She had not been there when Viridia knelt, and she was there now, come up the slope through the stopped army while the girl was a portal away, and she stood a few feet off the sealed seam with her arms not folded for once, the black-nailed hand loose at her side, watching the air the way you watch a place a person has gone into and might not come out of. Viridia came out of it. She came out blind, and had not yet understood that the not-feeling-Amber-there was itself the proof of it, that a day ago she would have read the worried core of her from across the field before she finished stepping through, and now there was only grey, only the front of her two eyes, and Amber a shape on it she had to turn her head to find.

Amber found her first. Amber saw the thing Viridia could not see in herself: a girl come back out of something wrung all the way to the wick, swaying on the warm stone, her hands open and empty and her eyes open and landing on nothing, reading the rise and the army and Amber herself with the wide unfixed look of a person taking a room in by sound. She crossed the stone fast and got a shoulder under Viridia's arm before the swaying finished what it had started.

"You did it," Amber said, low, against her. Not the question. The fact. "I can't tell what you did up there, I only know what you went up meaning to do, and I can see what it took out of you to do it. I can see that much." Her voice did the rough thing it did. "I asked you whether you had the right. I'm not asking now. Now I'm getting you off this rock."

And Viridia, who had chosen to pay for the whole grieving half-made world alone in a dark room where no soul would ever watch her do it, was watched, here, at the cost's far end, by the one person who had named the cost out loud before she paid it. She was seen paying. She was held up on a rise by the conscience of the whole long march, and she allowed the holding-up, because there was nothing in her anymore to stand on, and because being watched pay a thing was a different matter from being told the thing was forgiven, and Amber, of all of them, would never hand her the second one. That was the only reason she could bear the first one from her. She leaned the spent weight of herself into the offered shoulder, and Amber took it, and did not flinch from the cold of her, and walked her down off the warm stone into the stopped world.

* * *

The war did not end the way wars are supposed to end, with one side throwing down its arms and the other side standing over it, because there was no one left on the field with the heart to be a side.

She came down off the rise in the long grey middle of that morning and walked into the stopped army the way you walk into a field of standing stones, and no one moved to bar her, and no one moved to follow her, and the men who had marched a week to put her in the ground stood with their workings dead in their slack hands and their heads bent over their own chests and let the silver-blond girl pass

through them untouched, because she was a small thing in the scheme of what had arrived in them and they had no attention left over to spend on a small thing. She walked among them with her ordinary blinded-back eyes and could not tell, now, which of them had a furnace and which a candle, which had meant her harm and which had only been frightened into the line, could not read a single core in the whole stopped mass of them where a day ago she would have read all of it at a glance, and she found she did not need to. A man whose whole life has changed in his chest in a grey morning he cannot account for looks the same from the front of the eyes as he does from the other seeing. He looks like a man who has been handed something and does not know whose hand it came from.

By midday the two armies had begun, without orders, to come apart. Not into rout and not into surrender. Into people. Men set their rifles down against the carts because a rifle is heavy and there was no longer any reason to hold one, and they sat on the churned ground in their enemy's sight and put their faces in their hands, and some of them wept and did not know what for, and some of them only sat, and after a while some of them got up and began the long business of walking home, west or east as their homes lay, and no one stopped them, because there was no one whose business it was anymore to stop a man from walking home. You cannot fight a thing no one can see. The Chancellor was a scorch on a fallen flag and his war was a thing that had been about a difference that no longer existed, and the men who had been told all their lives that the dark gift was a sickness to be managed stood in their own newly whole skins and could not have said, if you asked them, what it was they had come to the wall to do.

It was the quietest end she had ever heard of. It was the end of the largest thing in six hundred years and it made no sound at all.

* * *

Raizen came to her at the foot of the rise in the early afternoon, and she felt him coming through the bond before she heard the ground take his weight, which was the only way she could feel anything now, the old sight gone and only the bond left lit in her like the one window in a dark house. She turned, and there was the prismatic bulk of him coming through the thinning army, the men parting around him not in terror now but in a kind of stunned slow wonder, a dragon walking through them in the afternoon light with the colors running along his spine. She put her hand up to his lowered brow and held it there, and neither of them said anything, because the bond did not need the saying and her mouth was tired.

And then the air around him changed.

She could not see it. That was the thing she would mind for the rest of the day and would not say. The light side of her and the dark side of her, both, would have shown her exactly what the bond was doing as it gathered itself, the whole prismatic working of it laid out for her to read, and there was nothing, only her two eyes and the dragon getting somehow harder to look at, the colors along his spine winding tighter and brighter the way a thing winds tight before it springs, and she stepped back without knowing why she stepped back, only that the bond had gone taut as a struck wire and the warm far weight of him was drawing in, in, smaller, the way the sea draws back off the sand before it does the other thing.

The colors collapsed.

There was a sound like a held breath let go, and the great prismatic shape folded in on itself, not falling, not breaking, but gathering, light pouring inward toward a center too bright to look at, and where the dragon had stood the size of a barn there stood, when she could look again, a person.

A young man. Lean, dark-haired, taller than her by a head, standing on the churned grass with the last of the prismatic running off his bare skin like water running off a thing pulled up out of a bright sea, and the light went out of him by degrees, dimming down into the ordinary, until what stood there was only a young man, naked and new and blinking in the grey afternoon as if the afternoon were the first thing he had ever seen, which, with these eyes, it was.

She knew him. The bond did not change. Whatever shape the source gave back, the far weight of him in her was the same weight, Raizen, only standing now on two legs and looking down at the first of them as if it had betrayed him.

He fell over.

He fell straight over backward onto the churned ground, sitting down hard, and he looked up at her from the dirt with an expression of such pure outrage that something happened in her chest that had not happened in a long count of days, a small involuntary motion, gone before she could name it.

"They're terrible," Raizen said. His voice was new too, lower than she had expected, a young man's voice finding itself. "They're terrible. How do you stand on these. There's only two of them and they're at the *bottom*."

"You stand on them all your life," she said. "You stop noticing."

"You stop *noticing*." He said it back to her like an accusation. He had got himself up onto his elbows and was staring down the length of his own new body at the far ends of it with frank horror. "These at the end. These ones." He

worked them, the toes, watched them work, appalled. "Why do they move separately. Why would they need to move separately. What is this for." He flexed his foot and the whole thing did a thing he had not asked it to do and he flinched as though it had bitten him. "And it's *cold*. Is it always cold. Why are you all so calm, you live in this, this is your whole, you live with no scales and ten of these at the bottom that move separately and it's *cold*, how is anyone calm. How."

"It's spring," she said. "This is warm."

He stopped. He looked at her with the flat appalled face of a creature six thousand years old in some accounting being told that the worst thing he had yet encountered was the *good* version. "This is warm," he repeated, hollow.

"You'll want clothes," she said.

* * *

It took two of the survivors and Amber to get clothes onto him, and it was the closest thing to a comedy the field saw that day, and she let it be that, stood at the edge of it and let it be that, because there had been so little of it for so long and the bond was warm and undefended and glad in a way it had not been glad since before the wall, and she would not put the cold working part anywhere near a thing the bond was glad of.

The buttons defeated him entirely.

He sat on a cart-tail with a dead man's shirt half on and stared at the row of them as at a problem in a language he had spoken once and forgotten, his new fingers, which he could mostly drive now, going to the wrong holes and the wrong buttons and producing a garment that gaped at the throat and bunched at the belly, and he undid it and did it again wrong in a different way, and undid it, and looked up at Amber, who was watching with her arms folded and the

black-nailed hand at her mouth doing a thing her eyes had not done in a season.

"There is a god somewhere," Raizen said, with enormous dignity, "who is laughing at me. I want you to know that I know it. I am six thousand years old and I have flown over the roof of the world and I cannot fasten a shirt and there is a god laughing." He got one button into one hole, correctly, the first one, and looked at it as at a continent newly discovered, and then ruined it entirely by trying to do the next one without looking.

"Bottom to top," Amber said. Her voice was rough. "Start at the bottom. Match each one to the hole across from it. Don't look at the next one till you've done the one you're on."

He did it. Slow, his tongue at the corner of his mouth, his new brow furrowed at the work of it, he did it bottom to top one at a time, and got to the collar, and the shirt sat on him straight, and he looked down at himself fastened into it like a person and looked up at Amber with a wonder out of all proportion to a fastened shirt, and Amber, the moral conscience of the whole grim march, the girl who had shattered her own core to say goodbye to her parents and asked the hardest question anyone had asked Viridia in her life and had not stopped asking it, made a sound that was half a laugh and half the other thing and turned away so the field would not see her face do both at once.

And Viridia stood at the edge of it, blind to the bond's bright working and reading the whole scene by the front of her eyes like everyone else alive, and thought, with a quiet that surprised her, that this was the relief, that this was the thing the long road had not had, a dragon learning buttons in the afternoon with the war guttered out around him, and that she had bought it, in a dark room a portal away, with the truest part of what she was, and that she would not have changed the bargain. The boy laughed at his own foot. It was

a good sound. She filed it carefully, in the place she kept the good things, which she did not visit any oftener than the other place, and which was a great deal emptier.

* * *

Drake and Varissa came down out of the west in the last of the light.

She felt them before she saw them only because Raizen felt them, the bracing going through the bond again, but a different bracing than the one at the stream-crossing, because at the stream-crossing the brace had been a child meeting a goodbye standing, and this was a child who had been goodbyed-to-as-forever standing up out of the far side of the forever in a shape his parents had never seen, and not knowing what they would make of it. They landed across the churned field where there was room, the black one and the scarlet one, and the last of the dispersing army flinched away from them and gave them the whole width of the field, and Raizen walked out to meet his parents on two new legs, unsteady, watching his own feet, and Viridia went with him, because the bond did not give her the choice, and because she would not have taken it.

Drake looked at his son for a long time and did not speak, which was not Drake's way, Drake said the hard thing first to get it out before the soft thing could be heard, and he had no hard thing now, the hard thing had been *you are going to a hole I cannot follow you into*, and his son was standing in front of him in a borrowed shirt with the buttons done bottom to top, not in a hole, not gone, only *changed*, and the great death-fire head came down and down until the black brow was level with the young man's face, and Drake looked at him out of the one near eye, close, the way you look at a thing to be sure of it.

"Huh," Drake said.

"Father," Raizen said. His new voice did the word carefully, the way he had done the buttons.

"You've got hands," Drake said.

"I've got hands." Raizen held them up, the new hands, and turned them over, still half-amazed by them himself. "I can't fasten a shirt with them. Amber had to teach me. Bottom to top."

"Bottom to top," Drake said gravely, as if filing a thing of importance, and the black fire moved at his edges and went still, and that was the whole of it, that was Drake's grief turned all the way over into its opposite and come out gruff on the other side, *you've got hands*, said loud and ended fast, the armor up over the wound that was not a wound anymore, that was a son standing where a hole had been. He did not say *I thought I had lost you*. He did not have to. He had thrown that grief at the sky already, at the stream, where everyone could hear it, and a thing thrown once does not need throwing twice, and so he said *you've got hands* instead, and it carried the whole of the other thing under it, and his son heard the whole of the other thing under it, and pressed his new brow, just once, lightly, against the great black one, the old answer in a new shape, and Drake took it, and that was the loud goodbye made whole, the saying undone, the forever called back.

Varissa did not speak at all.

She lowered her scarlet head toward the churned grass and came on slow, the way she had come on at the muster by the water. But by the water she had laid her whole cheek down the length of him, breathing him in, memorizing a son she believed she was about to lose. She could not do that now. He was a young man's height and a young man's shape, and there was nothing dragon-long left to lay a cheek against, and so she halted a foot from his changed face and only looked, out of both eyes, and the dull banked scarlet of

her brightened slow, the brightening of a fire handed the one thing it had been starving for. Through the bond Viridia felt what she was doing, and it was the memorizing again, the laying-down deep inside where no source could reach to take it, except that this time what she laid down was not a parting. It was a face. Her son's first human face, the new dark hair and the dark new eyes and the tongue gone careful at the corner of his mouth, set down beside the egg-heat and the spine-light in the keeping a mother keeps, added in, not put in place of.

"I grieve close to the ground," Varissa told her, and she told it to Viridia and not to her son, because to her son there were no words and to Viridia there were. "I said as much by the water. I said the silent grief is the one to be afraid of, because it does not let go." The scarlet eyes did not leave her son. "I flew home to the mountain. I lay down where his egg had lain and made no sound, the way I swore I would, and I grieved him close to the ground for three days, and on the fourth day the not-letting-go let go, all at once, because he was alive. I felt it through nothing I can name. He was alive and *changed*, and I did not understand the changed and I did not need to, I only needed the alive." She breathed out, and the breath came as warmth and not as fire. "So. I am not bringing my grief to you close to the ground, girl. I am bringing you the other thing, which I have less practice at and will do badly. You took him to a hole and you brought him back. Whatever shape. You brought him back. I told you to and you did. We understand each other."

"Yes," Viridia said.

"Good." She raised the scarlet head, slow. "Then the hard understanding is finished between us, and we will have to learn the other way, the easy way, which I am told takes longer." She looked one last time at her son's new face, laid the last of it down inside herself, and was the fierce thing

again, the banked fire, the mother. "Bring him to the mountain when his feet stop offending him. I want to watch him learn to walk. I have earned that."

"They're at the *bottom*," Raizen told her, with feeling.

"I know where they are," Varissa said, and there was something in the deep register of it that in a human Viridia would have called tenderness and in a dragon she did not have a word for, and that was Varissa's goodbye, which was not a goodbye at all anymore, which was a *come home*, the silent grief unlearned, close to the ground.

They went the way dragons go, straight up and gone between one breath and the next, and the field watched them rise, and Raizen stood on his new legs and watched his parents climb the dying light with his new eyes and did not wobble, for the first time, the whole while they were going.

* * *

She found Lor-ar at the edge of the field where it ran up into the trees, in the blue dusk, after.

He sat in the long grass where the field ran up to the trees, grown to his full height, all seven feet of him, the sky-blue and the forest-green of his coat going grey in the dimming light, the bone-white horns, the lightning eyes, and he had not come to her, she had gone to him, walked the length of the field to the trees with her ordinary eyes finding the way, because she had known it through a bond she had carried three hundred years' worth of in a single one of her own, that this was the last of the field she had to cross.

"You've spent the seeing," Lor-ar said. He had been watching her come the whole way and she had not been able to feel him watching, and that, more than anything, was the size of what she had lost, that Lor-ar had watched her cross a field and she had not known he was there until she saw him with the front of her eyes. "I felt it go. The bond felt it go.

There is a window shut in you that was always open, and the wind comes through it different now."

"It comes back," she said. "Slow. The way the furnace comes back. A long count of weeks. Longer." She sat down in the grass at the tree-line beside him, the way she had sat beside him a hundred times in all the dark they had crossed, and she could not see his core, where always she had seen it, the strange three-hundred-year deep-water thing that was a spirit-walker's core, and she sat beside the place where it should have shone and saw only a great grey shape going greyer in the dusk. "I can't see you," she said. "I want you to know that. I'm sitting next to you and I can't see you the way I always have. I can see the front of you. I can't see the rest."

"I know it," Lor-ar said. "That is why I have come to the edge of the trees to do this, and not the middle of the field. The middle of the field you would have had to find me in. The edge of the trees you can see me leave from, with the only eyes you have left, and I would not take that from you. You should be able to watch."

She went very still.

"It is time," Lor-ar said. "You knew it was time. You have known since the rise. I felt you know it."

"No," she said. The word came out level and stripped, the way her voice did the thing under pressure, the careful flat thing, and she heard it do the thing and could not stop it doing the thing. "I didn't summon you for a season. I summoned you for the war. The war's over. There's no." The word stopped. The level held. "There's no rule that says the bond ends when the war does. You could stay. The bond doesn't have to be spent like the rest of it. You could *stay*."

"I could," Lor-ar agreed, gently, which was rarer in him than the rationed name, rarer than anything. "I have stayed before, with others, past the asking, because the asking one could not bear the unasking. I stayed three hundred years

on the spirit road and I have walked beside more of you than you would believe, the frightened ones and the brave ones and the ones who could not tell the difference, and I have stayed past my time with some of them because they wept and I am not made of stone. And it was wrong. Every time it was wrong. A bond held past its season is not a kindness, little one. It is a leash on a thing that loves you, and you of all the people I have walked beside should know what a leash costs the thing that wears it, because you spent the whole of this war refusing to be one, and refusing to make one, until the morning you could not refuse anymore." The lightning eyes turned on her, ancient, and tender, and entirely without absolution, as they had been on the road. "You did not summon me to keep. You summoned me to walk you to the place you could not walk to alone. You have walked to it. You have done the thing at the end of it. There is nothing past it I am for."

"That's not it." Her hand had gone to the dark-blue stone at her throat without her telling it to, and she made it come down, and it came down slow. "I don't want a reason. I'm not asking for a reason. I want you to stay because I want you to stay. That's the whole of it. There isn't a count under it."

"There is always a count under it," Lor-ar said. "You taught me that. You count everything. And the count under this one, if you let yourself do it, comes back the way the other counts came back, with an answer you do not like and cannot improve by doing it again." He was quiet a moment, the great soft sides of him rising and falling in the dusk. "I have been three hundred years away from the forest. The spirit road is long and it is cold and it is full of the frightened and the brave, and I have walked it without complaint because the road is what I am for. But the forest is what I am *from*, and a creature that is kept from the thing it is from long enough forgets it was ever from anywhere, becomes

only the keeping, only the leash, only the thing the road made of it. I would not like to forget the forest. I am very near to forgetting it. You can give it back to me, or you can keep me, and you cannot do both, and you have spent this whole war learning that there is no choice in the world that is not that choice, the keeping or the giving-back, and you have got very good, little one, at the giving-back, at a cost no one will ever count but you."

She did not answer. There was nothing in her that would come out level if she let it out, so she let nothing out, and she sat in the long grass in the blue dark and looked at the great grey shape she could only half see, and did the thing she had got so good at, which was to feel the whole of it and let none of it onto her face, because the one tell she allowed herself was her breath, and even her breath she kept, here, at the end, in front of the one creature who would not have minded if she had not.

"Release me," Lor-ar said. "It is a working you know. You knew it the day you summoned me. The same word, said backward, with the meaning turned around. You do not need the sight to do it. You only need to mean it." He paused. "Mean it."

She meant it.

She put the working into the dusk between them with no focus and no light she could see and only her two ordinary eyes open on the great grey shape, said the word she had said to bring him out of the spirit road three hundred years and a single one ago, said it backward, with the meaning turned around, with the whole of herself behind the meaning the way the whole of herself had been behind the meaning at the well, and she felt the bond, the one window left lit in the dark house of her, the one thing she could still feel after the sight went out — she felt it loosen.

It did not break. That was the mercy of it and the cruelty of it both. It did not snap or tear or go dark. It loosened, the way a hand that has held another hand a long time opens, finger by finger, not because the holding failed but because the holding was finished, and the warm three-hundred-year weight of him in her, the weight that had been there through every dark she had crossed, eased back, and back, gentling away from her toward the trees and the forest past the trees and the long road home that was not the cold road of the dead anymore but only the green road of a creature going back to the thing it was from.

The great shape stood up out of the grass.

And began, between one breath and the next, to grow small. Not the house-cat shrink, the play-shrink, the riding-on-a-cart-rail shrink. The other smallness. The going. He grew small at the edge of the trees the way a thing grows small that is walking away from you and not coming back, and she held the front of her eyes open on the small grey diminishing shape of him going into the dark under the trees, because it was the only seeing she had left and he had come to the edge of the trees on purpose so that she could use it, so that the last of him would not be a thing she had to find in the dark by the changed feel of the air. He had given her that. The watching. She used it. She did not look away.

He stopped, once, at the very edge of the trees, where the field's last grey light met the first true dark of the forest, and he turned the great horned head, going small, and looked back at her across the grass with the lightning eyes that she could still, just, make out, two points of cold blue going dim in the going-dark.

"Little one," Lor-ar said.

And that was all. That was the whole of it. He said it the way it was meant to be said, rationed all the way down to this, the last of it and the most of it, *little one*, the two words

he had spent three hundred years and a war hoarding against exactly this, said now, last, and meant last, and meant entirely, with nothing held back behind it because there was no after to hold anything back for.

Then the trees took him, and the bond went quiet, not dark, not broken, only quiet, the window in the dark house of her standing open onto a forest now instead of a cat. She sat alone where the field met the trees in the full dark with her two ordinary eyes open on a place where there was nothing left to see, and she did not weep, because the grief had gone back inward where it lived, where it had always lived, where the banked break of the wall and the well had been the once-in-a-life exception and not the new rule. She was changed by the breaking and was not broken open by it anymore, and she sat in the dark and held the whole of it inward and let no one see, because there was no one to see, and that, now, was the difference, and it was the whole of the difference.

After a while she got up and walked back across the field the way she had come, by the front of her eyes, in the dark, and could not have told anyone how many people stood behind her on the field as she walked, because she could not feel them there, and would not be able to, for a long count of weeks, and walked anyway, with her back to a field full of strangers, the way everyone else in the world had always had to walk.

* * *

They made the fires where the army had stopped, because there was nowhere else to make them.

That was the thing nobody had said yet, that the survivors who came up the road behind the fighting and the survivors who came down off the field were the same two-in-three of a camp that did not exist anymore, and that

the carts they had unloaded to fight they could not now reload to go home, because the home was an ash-print in a valley three days west with Mirelle's long table burned to char in the middle of it and Hiram's anchor-post standing over nothing, and that an army that has won a war it did not win, in front of a wall it did not take, has, when the fires are lit, precisely nowhere to be.

Alice found her at the fire in the deep of the night.

She came and sat down on the log beside Viridia without asking, which the old Alice would have asked, hovered and asked and apologized for asking, and this Alice only sat, her movements even and unhurried, her hands, when she folded them, going still all at once in her lap the way a thing goes still that has been taught to be still in a place where stillness was the only safety there was. Her hair was lank and her face was thinner than the face Viridia had grieved a month for in a dormitory and there was a calm on it that had not been earned the gentle way.

"You did something," Alice said. She did not say it the way the old Alice would have, in a rush, in a worry. She said it level, looking at the fire. "Up there. While Jazen—" She stopped. The calm hands stayed still. "After. You did something. Everyone felt it and nobody knows what. Even the guards felt it. The ones who had me. They put their hands on their own chests like they'd been struck and they didn't strike anyone, they just—" She turned her head, and the firelight did the crooked tooth, the one tooth turned out of line, the one true thing the change had not been able to reach. "It was you. I know it was you. I don't know how I know."

Viridia looked at the fire, and did not reach for the dark room inside her own eyes where the lattice used to live, because there was nothing there to find now and she had stopped, already, in a single day, reaching for it.

"Yes," she said. "It was me."

She did not say the rest. She did not say *I made every core in the world whole, including yours, the small starved candle of you I grieved for, I made it whole and I did not ask you, I did not ask anyone, and I would do it again, and that is the thing I carry now*. She did not say it because Amber's question was hers to carry and not Alice's to answer, and because Alice with her even voice and her stilled hands had carried enough in a capital cell without being handed the thing Viridia had decided over her head in the dark. And so she said only *it was me*, and let the rest of it be a thing she filed, in the place she did not visit, beside the unfollowed thread and the gone tiger and the warm absence on a stone.

Alice looked at her a long moment with the calm new face, and then she did a thing the new face had not done all night. She reached over, slow, even, and put one of her calm hands over Viridia's where it lay on the log, and left it there, and it was not the old Alice's clutch, the warm clumsy too-much grip of the girl who taught her Moravian over a desk; it was a quieter thing, a measured thing, a hand laid on a hand by someone who had learned to spend touch carefully because for a year touch had been a thing that cost. But it was warm. The new calm had not got all the way down to the warmth. The warmth was still there under it, the way the crooked tooth was still there under the change, the friendship altered and not ended, banked and not out.

"You're cold," Alice said. The healer's note in it. The calm hands' habit. "You've been cold all night. You should come closer to the fire."

"I'm all right," Viridia said.

"You're not," Alice said, even, sure, not arguing, only correcting, the way you correct a count, "but you can be cold next to me instead of cold by yourself, which is a little better." And she did not take her calm hand away, and

Viridia let it stay, and the two of them sat at the fire in the deep of the night, the girl who had been changed in a cell and the girl who had changed the whole world and could not see that she had, and there was no talking between them, and the silence was warm, and that was as much as the night had to give and it was more than most of the night got.

* * *

In the grey before dawn the survivors began to wake and stir and look around themselves at the churned field and the cold fires and the dispersing strangers and the wall they had not taken, and the question came up among them, not loud, not all at once, but the way a cold gets into a column, person to person, from the carts forward, the same question with no answer behind it.

Where do we go.

The camp was ash. The wall was not theirs and never would be. The war that had given them somewhere to march was over, won by no one, ended by nothing anyone could name, and the two-in-three of them that were left stood in the grey morning in the churned field of a battle that had stopped for no reason, with their dead behind them and a wall they could not enter ahead of them and a home that was a char-mark in a far valley, free, whole, every core in the world among them running full for the first time in six hundred years, and not one of them, not one single soul on the whole bewildered field, including the silver-blond girl who had done it, knowing where in the world the living were supposed to go now.

CHAPTER TWENTY

None of Them Know Why

She had counted her dead all her life, and days later, on a road going east in the early light, she counted them again. The count did not stop being owed because the war that ran it up was over. It never had. She did it the way she did breathing.

She did not grieve the way other people did. They wore it in the open face for a season and then set it down. She did it like a clerk in a cold room with a true ledger and no one looking over the shoulder. It was the only way she had ever found that did not leave a thing out. Open-faced grief forgot names. Forgetting a name was the one thing she would not do. So she went down the column the way she had gone down it since the morning the world ended, one entry at a time, and put nothing in the margin she did not mean.

Jazen first. He went at the top because he had been the largest and because the largest belonged at the top, and there was no kindness in moving him down to spare herself the seeing of him there. She had stood in reach of his arm and had not reached it. She had promised a hand on an arm and the hand had been a field's width away when the thing it was for happened, and the careful part of her that wanted to write *you could not have* in the margin she shut, the way she shut it on all the margins, because a margin is a place to hide a name in, and she would not hide him. He had been the

most of the dark gift any soul living carried and he had been a man who wept where she could not, openly, his whole register turned outward, and she had filed the weeping along with the rest of him, in the place she did not visit any oftener than she had to, beside the salt-road town he had told her about in the dark and the sister burned two years gone and the mother dead before that. She set him at the top and did not move him and went on.

Mirelle, who had made a table of her own back over the children and counted them aloud while the fire took her, and whose baby was alive in the next valley over with the healer's wife and would grow up knowing the count had come out one short and not knowing which one. Hiram, who could not run and would not let the ward fall all at once, who set three hundred frightened people's invisibility down slow with the last of his wick so the children could get past the elms, and died at the anchor-post with nothing left to put on a cart. Brutus, broad and sunburned, who had feared his whole life that he would die safe and hidden and instead died on his feet in front of two armies holding a burning beam up as the last roof over the children until the gap closed. She did not soften them. She did not round any of them off. A count rounded off is a lie told gently, and she had decided, somewhere back in the worst of it, that she would rather carry the true sum than the comfortable one.

And then the ones with no single name. The camp. Mirelle's long table, char in an ash-print in a far valley with the anchor-post Hiram died at standing over nothing. The one place in the world that would have had them, gone, and the two-in-three of its people scattered now along a dozen roads with nowhere at the end of any of them. She wrote the camp into the ledger the way you write in a thing too large to weigh, by its edges, by what it had been, by the long table and the wall Brutus laid stone by stone and the hiding ward

that was three tired men holding a box of invisible air over a hundred sleeping children, and she let the largeness of it be what it was and did not try to make it small enough to lift.

There were smaller entries under the large ones, and she did not skip them, because a count that keeps only the large dead is a count kept for the keeper's comfort and not for the dead. The boy with no name who had fallen in the first hour of the field, the one she had only ever seen barefoot. Mella's locket, which Mella had clicked when she was afraid, and Mella afraid no longer because Mella was on the column too. The children who had lived, every one of them, which was a thing she made herself put in both ledgers, the surviving of them, because they had survived into a world with no roof and a count one short, and the survival was a true thing and not a clean one, and she had stopped pretending true things came clean. She went down to the bottom of the small entries and did not leave a single one in the margin.

The last entry on the column was the hardest one and she made herself write it the same as the others, flat, exact, no margin.

The girl she had been.

Because there had been a girl, before all of this, who counted only her own dead and let everyone else count theirs, who chose, in a careful private way that cost only herself, who in the world could see what she was. That girl had a rule and the rule had been the whole of her: *be careful who you let see you do it*. Her mother had given her the rule in a kitchen and she had kept it through a school and a burning and a year of war, kept it past every reason to break it, and then she had broken it, in front of two armies, over a dead man on a stone, and a thing broken that way does not knit back the way it was. She was not careful anymore about who saw what she was. She had stopped being careful at the worst hour of her life and she had not started again, and she

could feel, days later on the road, that she was not going to. The girl who had been careful was on the column with the rest of the dead. She had killed her herself, with the same hand she had used on everything else, and she did not write *I had to* in the margin. There was no margin.

That was the count of the cost. She did it true. It came out heavy, the way she had known it would, because a count done again does not come out lighter than the first time. It comes out the same. That was the reason to do it at all.

* * *

Then she did the other column, which she had learned, late, and badly, to do, the one her mother had not taught her, the one she kept in the place that was a great deal emptier than the first, the place she visited even less often because she trusted it less.

She did not trust good things. She had a furnace's worth of reasons not to. But she had decided, on the rise, with her hand in the source and the whole world's broken cores laid out under it, that if she was going to count the cost true she had to count the other true as well, or the ledger was a lie told the other direction, and a lie was a lie whichever way it leaned.

So. Alice. Alive. Changed in a cell in ways the gentle change could not have done, calm where she had been a clutch of warmth, even where she had been a rush, her hands gone still in her lap all at once the way a thing goes still that has learned stillness was the only safety it had. But alive, and warm still under the calm, the warmth not got all the way down to, the one crooked tooth the change had not been able to reach. She had crossed a year to reach that tooth and the year had cost both of them, and at the end of it there was a hand laid over hers at a night fire, measured, careful with touch the way you are careful with a thing that

has cost, but warm. She wrote Alice in the gain column and did not put a margin there either, did not write *but*, because the *but* was real and so was the *alive*, and you do not get to keep only the half of a true thing you like.

Raizen. At her side on the east road on two new legs, walking better every mile, still appalled by the cold and the buttons and the ten of them at the bottom that move separately, and the bond a warm undefended weight in the dark house of her, the one window still lit when the sight went out. He had gone into a hole his father could not follow and come back changed and not gone, and his mother had unlearned the silent grief over it, and now he walked beside her telling her with great feeling about the outrage of his own feet, and she had a thing in her chest when he did it that did not have a name and that she did not file, because the things she filed she could not feel twice, and this one she wanted to be able to feel again.

And the world. Whole. Every living core running full for the first time in six hundred years, the dark half handed back to the light and the light half handed back to the dark, the cut the council made closed by a girl's hand in a pool a portal away, all of it, all at once, every soul on both sides of a dead war made whole in the same grey minute.

And none of them know why.

That was the thing. That was the whole shape of the ending, and she turned it over as she walked and could not make it come out as anything other than what it was. The war was over. It had been about a difference that no longer existed. The Chancellor who ran it was a scorch on a fallen flag, killed clean by a death-flame meant rarely and never cheap, and the resistance built around one terrified powerful man had no shape once the man was gone, and so it came apart, into people. But it did not come apart cleanly, and she would not pretend in the ledger that it had. Not

everyone who felt the new fullness run full in them took it for a mending. Some recoiled from it as from a sickness put into them in their sleep, and a few cried witchcraft over their own chests, and somewhere on the line a captain who had spent the war certain of one thing tried to hold a formation that would not re-form, and could not say why his own men would no longer stand where he put them. The war did not end because the hatred had evaporated. It ended because an army cannot keep its shape through a thing that large and that far inside the chest. The men who had marched a week to put her in the ground set their rifles against the carts, some of them weeping, some of them afraid, none of them knowing whether what had been done to them in the grey morning was a gift or a hand reaching into them uninvited. And then, in ones and twos and not in any peace anyone would have called peace, the people had walked home. The largest thing in six hundred years had ended, and made no sound, and not one soul on the whole bewildered field knew why their own chest had changed in a morning they could not account for. Including the silver-blond girl who had changed it, who could not see now, with her sight burned to the wick, that she had changed anything at all. She read the world by the front of her eyes like everyone alive, and could not have told you, looking at a stranger, whether the strange new fullness in him had come from her hand or from God or from nowhere, the same as he could not.

She had decided for all of them. That was the entry in the gain column that would not sit still in it, that wanted to climb back over into the cost column and would not stay either place. Amber had asked her the question in the dark a fortnight ago and a war ago, *you fought a government that controlled a whole people through their magic – how are you different, if you change every core alive and ask no one*, and Viridia had had no answer that survived being said out loud.

She had gone to the source with the question still standing, unanswered, and put her hand in the pool anyway, and done the thing. And the question was still standing now, days east of it, on the road, exactly as tall as it had been, not one inch shorter for the thing being done.

She carried it. That was the only honest thing to do with a question you cannot answer and acted on anyway. Not bury it, not argue it down, not write *the bodies were real* in the margin and call it settled, because the bodies had been real and the question was still real and both being real at once was the whole truth of it. She carried the question the way she carried the names, exact, unrounded, in the place she did not visit oftener than she had to. And under the carrying, in the part of her that did not lie even to be kind, she knew the thing she would not say to Amber or Alice or anyone living: that she would do it again. That set in front of the same field with the same dead and the same single open door, she would put her hand in the pool a second time and decide for all of them a second time, and carry it a second time, and that the knowing she would do it again did not make the doing it right. It only made it hers. The cost and the gain and the question, all three, hers, the way her dead were hers, the way the camp's ash was hers, the way the careful girl she had killed was hers.

She closed both columns. She did not weep, on the road, with Raizen complaining of the cold beside her. The grief had gone back inward where it lived, where the once-in-a-life breaking of the wall and the well had been the exception and not the new rule, and she was changed by the breaking and not broken open by it, and she carried the whole of it under a face the road could not read, and no one saw, because that, now, was not a rule she kept. It was only what she was.

She had thought, once, a long way back, that there would be a morning at the far side of all of it when the two columns balanced, when the gained finally weighed against the lost and a person could set the ledger down and be only alive. She knew better now. The columns did not balance and were not built to. You did not get the lost back by gaining; you carried both, full, in the same chest, the way a core carried both halves of the gift now, the dark and the light, neither cancelling the other, both running at once. That was the shape of a person who had been through a thing and out the other side of it. Not lighter. Both columns, carried, and the carrying itself the only thing that ever passed for healing.

* * *

The road forked at midday, by a stone marker worn smooth of whatever it had once said, and the survivors had to decide which way the living went.

There was no home at the end of either branch. That was the thing nobody had wanted to say since the field stopped, and the stone marker made them say it, because a fork is a question you cannot walk past. The camp was ash. The wall was not theirs and never would be. The roads west went to a country that had spent a year being taught their gift was a sickness, and the roads east went to nothing in particular, to towns that had never heard of them, to a world that did not know it had been remade and would not have believed it if told. They stood at the fork in the worn light, two hundred of them and more strung back along the road, the survivors of a camp that did not exist and an army that had won a war no one won, and they looked at the stone marker and at each other and at her, because they had got into the habit, somewhere on the long bad road, of looking at her.

She did not have an answer. She had spent the answer-giving part of herself, along with the sight and the

careful girl and so much else, and what was left did not deal in answers. But she had a thing that was not an answer and was better than one, and she gave them that, because it was the only true thing she had to give and she had stopped, at the worst hour of her life, hoarding the true things.

There is no home to go to, she told them, in not so many words, standing at the worn stone in the worn light. There is no roof at the end of this road waiting to be walked under. The camp was the one place in the world that would have had us and it is gone, and the wall will not open, and the country that wanted us dead does not know yet that it has been handed back the half of itself it cut away, and may not thank the hand that did it when it learns. There is no safety at the end of the road. She would not lie to them about that, not now, not after everything, because a lie told to the grieving is the cruelest kind and she was done with the careful merciful untruths. There is no resolution.

But there is the road. There is the next mile of it, and the mile after, and the small human business of an army of the grieving that is no longer an army, learning to be only people, the way the men on the field had learned it, setting down the rifle because a rifle is heavy and there is no longer a reason to hold one. There is movement, which is not the same as arriving but is the only thing that has ever, in the whole history of the grieving, got anyone to the place where the not-letting-go finally lets go. There is the baby in the next valley with the healer's wife who will need carrying. There is a dragon learning to walk who will need a mountain, and his mother has earned the watching of it. There is Alice, who will need a long unhurried time to come back the rest of the way to her own warmth, and may not come all the way, and is worth the road regardless. There is a whole world that does not know it is whole, going about its bewildered business, and somewhere in it the slow work of

someone, someday, putting a name to the thing that happened in the grey morning, and being believed, or not, and either way the world going on full instead of half.

One of the rescued Hazel girls asked her, at the fork, in a small voice, whether it was over now. Whether the bad part was the part behind them. And Viridia looked at her, at the thin frightened hopeful face of a girl who had folded into a camp now burned out of a school already ash, and did not give her the answer the girl wanted, because she was done handing the grieving the merciful untrue thing, and gave her instead the only one she had. It is over, she said. The war is over. And then she said the rest of it, because the first half alone was the comfortable lie and she would not leave it standing: and something is coming that none of us can see, the way none of us could see the morning our chests changed, and we will meet it the way we have met everything, late, and unready, and standing up. The girl did not look comforted. Viridia had not expected her to. But she looked steadied, which was its own thing and a truer one, and she walked on at the fork with her chin a little higher than it had been, and that was as much as Viridia had to give and it was honest and it would hold.

So they went east. Not because east was better. East was only the way the most of them were facing when the deciding got too heavy to keep doing, which is how most of the great turnings of people actually get made, not by a choosing but by a leaning. And she let it be that, stood at the fork and let the leaning be the choosing, because she had spent a whole war learning that the choices a person actually gets are smaller and uglier than the ones in the stories, and that you take the small ugly leaning one and you walk it and you make it true by walking it. They went east, into a country that did not know them, with their dead behind them and no roof ahead of them and the whole of

themselves running full in their chests for the first time in six hundred years and none of them knowing why, and the silver-blond girl walked at the front of it the way she walked everywhere now, by the front of her ordinary eyes, unable to feel the two hundred people at her back, with her back to them anyway, the way everyone else in the world had always had to walk.

She did not look for a home on the road ahead. She looked for the next mile of it. That was the residue the war had left where other people kept their resolutions, the thing she had instead of an ending: not safety, motion; not a roof, a road; not an answer, a question carried east in the early light by a girl who would do the unforgivable thing again and knew it and walked anyway, which was, she had decided, somewhere on the long bad road, the only honest way left to be alive.

* * *

Far to the west, past the wall that had stopped a war, past the capital that had lost its head, in a low stone room with the shutters drawn against a morning he had no use for, a man named Marick stood over his bench and felt the thing in his chest that had not been there a week ago.

He had never been able to do much. That was the plain fact of him, the fact he had spent forty years arranging his whole careful life around: a thin true gift, a candle, enough to light a lamp and warm a kettle and never enough for the things he read about in the bound volumes he could not stop buying, the deep workings, the old severed-half mathematics no living mage could close because no living mage carried both ends of the cut. He had spent forty years in this room being a candle and resenting it the way only a clever man resents a small gift, and then, in a grey morning a week ago, with no warning and no reason and no hand he

could see, the candle had become something else. He had felt it happen. He had put down the volume he was reading and pressed his hand flat to his own chest like a man struck, the way the whole world had, and felt the half he had never had handed to him entire, the dark side of the gift come into him full-grown and unearned and not understood, six hundred years of severed depth poured into a candle that had spent its life wanting exactly this and had no idea, none, what it was now holding.

He did not know why. No one had told him; no one could have; the girl who had done it was three days east and could not have named him if you had asked. He only knew that the workings in the bound volumes, the deep old severed-half mathematics that no one had been able to close in six hundred years, lay open in front of him now, and that his hand, when he held it over the bench, no longer shook, and that the symbol he had drawn out on the slate in the lamp-light, the one in the oldest volume, the one with the warning written under it in a hand so old the warning had worn nearly to nothing, was, he was almost certain, within him now to attempt.

He read the worn warning one more time. He could not make out the half of it. He decided it did not matter.

He picked up the chalk.

* * *

And at the rim of everything, where the source ran full now where for six hundred years it had run on half its wick, in the place that is not a place, the abstract counterpart to the well — the absence that balances the presence, the held breath against the full lung, the nothing the something is cut from — there was a differential, and the differential was a shade wider than it had been a week ago.

That was all. No one stood in it. Nothing watched from it. It was not a person and it had no name and it wanted nothing, because wanting is a thing the something does and this was the other side of the something, the clean abstract negative of it, the dark the light is measured against. But the weave ran full now where it had run half, and a thing that runs full pushes harder on what holds it, and what held it was the rim, and the rim was the differential, and the differential, with the whole world's gift handed back entire and pressing now at its old worn edges, had widened by exactly the amount the new fullness asked of it, the way a held breath gets harder to hold the fuller the lung behind it.

A shade. No more than a shade. Not enough for anyone to feel, except perhaps a girl with the always-on sight to read the rim of the world, and she had spent that sight to make the fullness that was widening it, and could not see now, with her ordinary eyes, three days gone up an eastward road, that anything at the rim of everything had moved at all.

It would come back, the sight. Slow. An ember at a time, a long count of weeks and beyond. And on some grey morning a long way off she would have enough of it back to look again at the rim of the world the way she used to, and the differential would be wider than she remembered, and she would notice, the way she noticed everything, and file it, and begin, in the careful inward way that was the whole of her, to count what it might cost.

But not yet. Not this morning. This morning she walked east at the front of the grieving by the front of her eyes, with the question carried unanswered beside her and the dead carried true behind her and a dragon complaining of the cold, into a whole world that did not know it was whole, and none of them, not one single soul on any road in any direction, knew why.

About the Author

Post Peleos writes character-driven fantasy about quiet people in loud worlds — stories that love to tease as much as they wound, and never quite stop wondering what waits out beyond the stars. *The Saeren Chronicles* is their debut series.

Acknowledgments

Thanks to everyone who has read my books and encouraged me to keep writing.

The Saeren Chronicles will conclude in

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book Three

The severing is mended and the war is over, but the world Viridia remade does not yet know what it has become — and the cost she paid in the dark is only beginning to come due.

